

WELCOME BACK!

We had takes. The NFL Draft had answers.

With draft capital and landing spots now in place, the outlook for this rookie class has been reshaped.

Bring on the rookie drafts.

Before you dive into the updated guide, make sure you take a look at some of the things that have changed since the pre-draft version of the guide. The first point is especially important.

- I heard your feedback, so a **ZAP score conversion chart** has been added to the end of the prospect guide. This allows you to compare old ZAP scores to the new scoring system.
- All draft profiles now include an **updated ZAP Model score** along with their **Draft Capital Delta** risk profiles. (Only drafted players have Draft Capital Delta risk profiles.)
- Relevant, **higher-end rookies have an updated profile breakdown** that reflects their new outlooks. On a player's profile page, you'll see the word "update" before their blurb, designating new information about the player.
- The **rookie rankings cheat sheet** is redone, and the **rookie rankings notes** have been updated, too.
- There's also a **ZAP Model cheat sheet** that provides a snapshot of how the models view each player.
- Added a player profile page for **Kaelon Black**. It's a first for this guide — he wasn't an NFL Combine invite, but he got Day 2 draft capital.

OK. Let's do this.

WARRIOR
LATE-ROUND

P R O S P E C T G U I D E

2026

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Introduction

“The film doesn’t lie.”

Actually, it does. All the time.

If film were pure truth, prospect evaluation wouldn’t be subjective. Teams wouldn’t disagree. Analysts wouldn’t argue. Entire draft rooms wouldn’t split over the same player.

And yet, they do. Every year.

“The numbers don’t lie.”

Actually, they do. All the time.

Numbers don’t tell stories — they simplify them. They strip context. They smooth uncertainty into something that feels precise, even when it isn’t.

Film lies by convincing us we’re seeing the whole picture.

Numbers lie by convincing us we don’t need one.

Like Jimmy Eat World at the turn of the century, the answer lies somewhere in the middle.

The thing is, I, JJ — hey, nice to meet you — am far more comfortable on one side of the prospect evaluation coin.

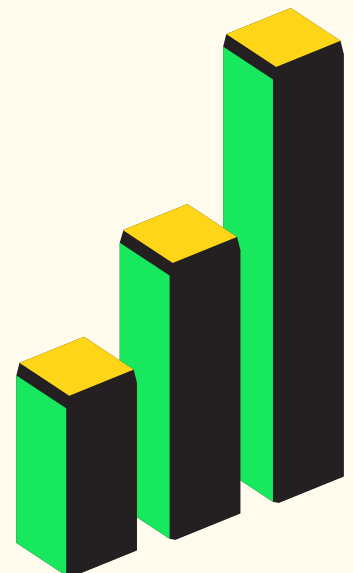
I can get down with numbers.

But they do lie. Because they’ll never tell the whole story.

That’s OK, though. As long as you know that going in.

What you’re about to read won’t give you the answers. It’ll just get you closer to them.

It’s hard to believe, but this is the fifth iteration of the Late-Round Prospect Guide. If you’ve been here before, you probably know



what you're in for. If you're new, welcome — and thank you. I genuinely appreciate you being here.

I also hope you've got your pocket protector ready. Because we're about to get very, very nerdy.

Over the last half decade-plus, I've built prospect models for running backs, wide receivers, and tight ends designed to estimate future fantasy football performance.

And they've worked.

The Zachariason-Adjusted Prospect Model — or ZAP Model — saw Malik Nabers as the best wide receiver in his draft class when consensus was locked onto Marvin Harrison Jr. It flagged Isiah Pacheco as a value before the masses even knew who he was. It projected Khalil Shakir as a potential impact slot player despite his Day 3 draft capital. It adored Jaxon Smith-Njigba.

All of it came through math. Through numbers.

Each positional ZAP Model has evolved over time. Every offseason starts with testing, tweaking, and questioning assumptions. That process inevitably leads to new ways to evaluate prospects.

This year is no different. There are additions and adjustments throughout the guide that I think you'll really enjoy.

But at the center of it all is the same guiding principle it's always been: The goal isn't to be certain. It's to be directionally right.

Prospect models aren't meant to totally replace evaluation. They're meant to challenge it. To nudge us away from bad bets, toward better ones, and closer to the right questions — even when the answers remain frustratingly unclear.

In a process this uncertain, that edge matters.

The ZAP Model

Overview

The goal of the ZAP Model hasn't changed, but the way it gets there continues to evolve.

At its core, it's designed to estimate *how effective* an offensive player will be for fantasy football purposes over the *first three years* of his NFL career.

The reasoning is simple: by the end of Year 3, we usually have a pretty good idea of who a player is. Late-career breakouts do happen, but they're rare enough that they shouldn't drive a prospecting process. If we're trying to identify future fantasy contributors, the first three years are where the signal is strongest.

That naturally raises the question of how early-career success should be defined.

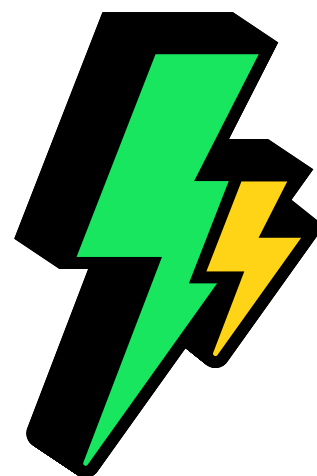
You could look at cumulative fantasy points. You could focus on average points per game. You could even weigh peak seasons more heavily than consistency. There's no single correct answer. But, over time, I've landed on a metric that balances upside, sustainability, and fantasy usability.

That metric is called B2S.

(Yes, another acronym. I'm sorry. Or you're welcome.)

B2S stands for "Best Two Seasons." For each player, we look at his first three NFL seasons and identify his two best years in points per game in point-per-reception formats. Those two seasons are then averaged together.

Imagine a wide receiver who averages 11.0 PPR points per game



as a rookie, 12.0 points per game in Year 2, and 15.0 points per game in Year 3. Under B2S, the rookie season would be discarded, and the 12.0 and 15.0 seasons would be averaged, resulting in a B2S of 13.5.

This approach rewards players who reach meaningful fantasy relevance, even if it takes time, and it avoids over-penalizing prospects who start slow but ultimately develop into usable assets.

Of course, points per game can be misleading in small samples. A player who averages 21 points per game across three contests before suffering a season-ending injury probably shouldn't be treated the same as someone who sustains that level of production across a full season.

To account for that, a season only qualifies for B2S if the player appears in at least seven games. If he fails to meet that threshold, the season is treated as a zero for B2S purposes.

And since the final week of the NFL season is often filled with backups and teams playing for very little, Week 18 is removed from the B2S sample as well. In other words, B2S is only evaluating relevant fantasy weeks.

So, going back to our example: if that wide receiver played only five games in his second season — the one where he averaged 12.0 points per game — but cleared the seven-game threshold in his rookie (11.0 PPR points per game) and third (15.0) years, then his B2S wouldn't be 13.5. Instead, the injury-shortened season would be pushed aside, and the rookie and third-year numbers would be averaged, producing a B2S of 13.0.

That's B2S. And that's what the ZAP Model is attempting to predict.

So how does the model get there?

Over the years, I've worked extensively with college production, athletic testing, and draft data. Through that process, I've developed separate prospect models for running backs, wide receivers, and tight ends, each tailored to the nuances of the position.

But building a model is easy. Proving it's useful is not.

Anyone can throw variables into a spreadsheet and generate a score. If that score doesn't meaningfully improve our understanding — if it doesn't outperform something we already have access to — **then it isn't adding value.**

Which brings us to draft capital.

Draft capital is always the first benchmark I test against. If a prospect model can't do a better job predicting B2S than where a player was selected in the NFL Draft, then the model isn't worth using.

Thankfully, that hurdle is cleared. Every positional ZAP Model included in this guide is more predictive of B2S than draft capital alone.

Much more.

As for the player pool that's being evaluated, each model analyzes all players who were drafted or invited to the NFL Combine since 2011. There's typically significant overlap there, but each year a handful of prospects slip through one channel or the other.

Even though the ZAP Models outperform draft capital on their own, draft capital still plays a central role within them. That's intentional.

The goal here isn't to predict where a player should be drafted in the NFL. Plenty of analysts do that extremely well.



The goal is to help **you win** at fantasy football.

There's no medal awarded for ignoring draft capital during fantasy football rookie drafts. NFL teams invest millions of dollars — and enormous resources — into their draft decisions. Treating that information as irrelevant would be irresponsible.

As a result, draft capital is the single most important input in every ZAP Model. That naturally creates a strong relationship between where a player is drafted and his overall ZAP score.

This isn't a flaw. It's the foundation.

The real value of the model lies in identifying when and where it makes sense to **deviate from draft capital.**

And ultimately, the competition we're trying to beat isn't the NFL. It's our leaguemates.

Every ZAP Model is not only more predictive of B2S than draft capital alone — it's also more predictive than rookie average draft position. In other words, blindly following ZAP scores would outperform blindly following market consensus over time.

That's the edge.

We all on the same page?

Now let's get into what actually goes into these things.

The Wide Receiver ZAP Model

The ZAP Models are adjusted every offseason. Not to retroactively fix misses — players from the most recent class aren't even eligible for testing yet, since they haven't completed three NFL seasons.

The updates happen for a simpler reason: the landscape keeps changing. New data becomes available. Better ways of analyzing that data emerge. And over time, my own approach to prospect evaluation evolves.

This year is no different. The wide receiver model has changed.

A couple of offseasons ago, I introduced the concept of Breakout Score to the prospect models. Breakout Age is a commonly referenced metric in analytically driven prospect evaluation, and it used to play a role in the ZAP Model as well.

But I've always had issues with it.

For those unfamiliar, Breakout Age represents how old a player was when he first reached a certain Dominator Rating threshold. Dominator Rating, to anyone unaware, measures the percentage of a team's receiving production a player accounted for during his college career.

The intuition behind Breakout Age is sound. Early production matters. When a player earns a significant role at a young age, it's usually a sign that he's simply better than his peers.

If a 10-year-old can play Canon in D on the piano the same way a 17-year-old can, odds are that when both pianists turn 20, the younger one is going to be ahead.

(I use that analogy every year in this guide, and it's not going anywhere. Sorry.)

Breakout Age isn't useless, but it is flawed.

Its biggest issue is that it's far too binary. A player either clears

the threshold or he doesn't. There's no room for nuance.

A wide receiver can fall just short of the breakout mark and be treated the exact same way as someone who barely contributed at all. The metric doesn't care how close you were. It only cares whether you crossed an arbitrary line.

Another way to think about it: imagine evaluating wide receivers solely by whether they reached 500 receiving yards in a season. A player with 499 yards and a player with 20 yards would be treated identically, despite clearly not being the same caliber of prospect.

That's the fundamental problem with Breakout Age. It captures when a player produced, but not how much he actually produced when explaining that breakout.

And when you're trying to separate good prospects from great ones, that distinction can be important.

That frustration with Breakout Age ultimately led to Breakout Score.

Like Breakout Age, Breakout Score is designed to capture age-adjusted collegiate production. Unlike Breakout Age, it doesn't rely on a single threshold. And it doesn't lean on Dominator Rating, a metric that comes with its own set of limitations.

Instead, Breakout Score evaluates a player's receiving yards per team pass attempt at multiple points throughout his collegiate career, adjusting for both age and competition level.

Let me explain.

Receiving yards per team pass attempt is exactly what it sounds like: a player's receiving yards divided by the number of pass attempts his team recorded. The ZAP Model uses a prorated version of the stat, so if a player misses some time, that's accounted for. However, if he appears in fewer than six games in a season, that year is excluded from the Breakout Score



calculation.

The “adjusted” portion of Breakout Score comes from two inputs: strength of schedule and age.

For strength of schedule, the model uses team-level data from Sports Reference. Those numbers are translated into a multiplier and applied to a player’s receiving yards per team pass attempt for each season. The idea is simple: production against stronger competition should carry more weight than production against weaker opponents.

It’s easier to rack up numbers at South Alabama than it is at Alabama.

Once that schedule-adjusted number is established, Breakout Score then evaluates it through the lens of age. The younger a player is when he posts a strong schedule-adjusted receiving yards per team pass attempt, the more favorably he grades within the metric.

In short, Breakout Score rewards early, efficient production without forcing players into arbitrary buckets.

Breakout Score shows a much stronger relationship to B2S than Breakout Age, and it greatly improves the effectiveness of the ZAP Model.

The wide receiver model also accounts for rushing production. That might sound a little strange at first, but when a receiver is used as more than just a pass-catcher, it’s usually a signal of genuine talent. Coaches don’t manufacture touches for players they don’t trust. If a wideout is getting handoffs or schemed runs, it’s because the offense wants the ball in his hands as often

as possible.

Within the model, rushing production is capped. The goal isn't to turn gadget usage into a cheat code. Instead, modest rushing totals act as a proxy for versatility and, more broadly, for being good at football.

The final production-related input in the wide receiver model is best-season adjusted fantasy points per game, a new addition this year. The concept is straightforward: it takes a player's best collegiate season in fantasy points per game (with a minimum of six games played) and adjusts that output for both age and strength of schedule.

That covers the production side of the wide receiver model. But several inputs have nothing to do with what a player did on the field on Saturdays.

Early-declare status is the most notable.

It's a concept that's been debated in dynasty circles for years, and the logic behind it isn't all that different from metrics like Breakout Age. When a player chooses to leave school early and enter the NFL Draft, it's usually because he's good enough to do so. NFL teams are showing interest, and the player is responding.

If that's the case, he's probably pretty good at playing the position.

That's why early-declare status carries weight in the model.

There's also a practical consideration. Early-declare receivers have fewer collegiate seasons on their résumé. That puts them at a slight disadvantage in pure production metrics, since they don't get the benefit of padding their profile with a fourth or fifth year of college production.

Most early-declare wideouts still post strong age-adjusted numbers, of course. But older prospects can sometimes inflate their statistical profiles by simply sticking around longer. Early

declaration helps correct for that imbalance.

The common question people have with early-declare status these days relates to name, image, and likeness (NIL) deals. Players can make real money while staying in school, and they can buy themselves more time to develop before stepping into the NFL.

And it's true: wide receivers are leaving early at a lower rate than they were before. From 2023 through 2025, for example, 15% of the wide receivers in the ZAP Model were early declares. In the 12 years prior, that number was closer to 26%.

But a lower early-declare rate doesn't mean early declaration suddenly stopped mattering. It just means the environment changed.

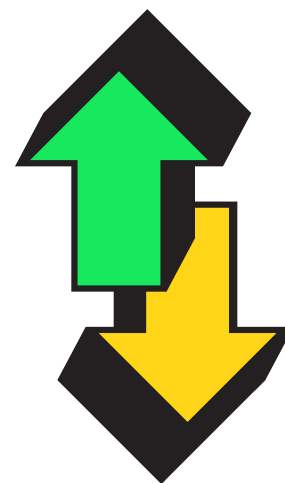
If anything, NIL raises the bar for leaving early. When staying in school comes with both financial incentives and the comfort of a familiar situation, the players who still choose to declare early are often doing so because the NFL feedback is strong enough to outweigh those benefits. In other words, the "why" behind an early declaration hasn't gone away — the decision is just being made under different circumstances.

So no, early-declare status isn't something to ignore. It's something to interpret correctly. It's not a trump card, and it's not a deal-breaker. It's a signal — one piece of a larger puzzle — and the model treats it that way.

There's also Teammate Score. When a wide receiver plays alongside other pro-caliber players, it matters. Intuitively, that makes sense: it's harder to command a large share of an offense when you're competing for targets with legitimate NFL talent.

Teammate Score isn't perfect, but it's built using the draft capital of a player's college teammates from the current draft class and recent seasons. As a result, a receiver's ZAP score can shift slightly as the NFL Draft unfolds, depending on where those teammates are selected. The changes are usually small, but the signal is real.

The final non-production-related input in the wide receiver ZAP Model is size.



Smaller wideouts aren't incapable of posting useful fantasy seasons, but they do tend to face steeper odds when it comes to reaching true ceiling outcomes. There are situations where a player will be dinged for being on the smaller side, not because success is impossible, but because history shows it's harder to get there.

So, to recap, the wide receiver model incorporates Breakout Score, rushing production, best-season adjusted fantasy points per game, early-declare status, Teammate Score, and size. Draft capital is then layered on top — and, once again, it's the single most important piece of the puzzle — to create a player's ZAP score.

And no, athletic testing from the NFL Combine isn't part of the model.

When people hear that prospect models exist, they often assume they're driven primarily by NFL Combine numbers. That makes sense on the surface — bigger, faster, stronger sounds better than the alternative.

But in practice, athleticism is already doing a lot of its work through draft capital.

Truly unathletic wide receivers rarely get selected highly in the first place.

And if a player completely bombs the Combine, that usually shows up elsewhere: weaker draft capital, a thinner production profile, or both.

Beyond that, wide receivers win in different ways. Rome Odunze doesn't succeed the same way Ladd McConkey does. Asking a model to enforce one athletic archetype would ignore the reality of how the position actually functions.

If anything, there's a reasonable argument that athleticism at wide

receiver is often overrated. From a modeling perspective, though, it doesn't need to be debated. The information is already baked in.

The Running Back ZAP Model

We just spent a lot of time talking about wide receivers. So naturally, let's talk about running backs and the thing that matters most for them as they transition from college to the NFL.

Receiving.

Last year, it felt a bit like an episode of *Maury* when I revealed that the running back ZAP Model didn't include a single rushing statistic. Every production-related input was tied to pass-catching.

That wasn't an oversight. It was intentional.

And after more testing, that hasn't changed much in 2026.

Receiving still rules all at the running back position.

Look, these prospect models aren't built to help me run an NFL franchise. They're built to help us win at fantasy football. Draft capital remains the foundation of everything here, but when it comes to identifying when and where to diverge from a player's draft slot, receiving metrics consistently tell the most useful story for running backs.

One of the core inputs in the running back model is reception share, a metric I've leaned on for years. It's simply the percentage of a team's completions that went to a running back, prorated to account for missed time. Reception share tends to be most informative at the top of the draft, where it works alongside draft capital to separate similar profiles, but it still carries signal deeper into drafts as well.

In last year's version of the model, Breakout Score was also used at running back, not just at wide receiver. As a reminder, that metric is derived entirely from receiving yards per team pass attempt. Receiving yards per team pass attempt remains part of the running back model today, but it's no longer bundled into

Breakout Score for the position. Instead, the model now looks at a player's best season in age- and schedule-adjusted receiving yards per team pass attempt.

What's new this year is that some rushing production has been allowed back into the conversation.

Some.

The model now incorporates age- and schedule-adjusted total yards per team play, calculated in the same way as receiving yards per team pass attempt, but using all offensive yards and all team plays. This gives rushing production a voice without letting it drown out the more predictive receiving signals.

I alluded to this a second ago, but one of the more meaningful tweaks in 2026 is how these production metrics are weighted depending on where a player is selected in the NFL Draft. For example, a late-round pick's yards per team play may matter more for his ZAP score than his reception share, whereas the opposite is often true for early-round selections.

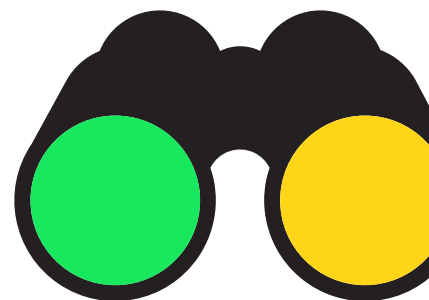
Each of these production metrics are useful on their own. But they become far more powerful once we know exactly where a player is drafted.

Keep that interaction in mind as you read through this year's running back profiles.

Collegiate production isn't the only thing the running back ZAP Model is concerned with.

We've looked at some age-related production metrics at the position, but age itself is a factor here, too. It's certainly not everything, and NIL deals are shifting this landscape a tad, but older running backs are usually worse bets to make compared to younger ones. Production will always trump age, though.

Teammate Score is an input in the running back model, too, just like the wide receiver one. This seems a little counter-intuitive, but there's actually less weight given to Teammate Score for running backs compared to wideouts – you'd figure a split backfield with a legitimate pro would boost a running back's score



more than it does. But, in the end, the ZAP Model does still care about teammate competition, even if it's a little less than at wide receiver.

The final two non-production inputs in the running back ZAP Model are also the most controversial: size and Speed Score.

Running back size appears to matter less and less in today's NFL. We watch players like James Cook, De'Von Achane, Jahmyr Gibbs, and Kyren Williams put up big fantasy numbers on a weekly basis, and none of them fit the traditional mold of a "big" running back.

Because of examples like those, it's easy to dismiss the idea that size matters at all. But they're better viewed as exceptions than proof that the rule no longer exists.

It's also important to be clear about how the ZAP Model treats size. Weight is not evaluated in a vacuum.

Take Jahmyr Gibbs. He entered the league at 199 pounds, which led to a bizarre fixation on an arbitrary 200-pound threshold. Some film evaluators understandably pushed back, pointing out how silly it is to treat a one-pound difference — something that could be dictated by what a player ate earlier that day — as meaningful.

The ZAP Model agrees. A strict cutoff like that is bad analysis.

But Gibbs is on the smaller side. That fact simply doesn't matter much when everything else checks out. Draft capital. Receiving profile. Yards per team play. When all of those boxes are checked, size becomes a footnote, not a deal-breaker.

That's why Gibbs owns one of the highest ZAP scores the model has ever produced. The same logic applies to De'Von Achane. Yes, he's small, but he also posted an absurd college production profile. The model accounts for both.

Size isn't irrelevant — larger backs, all else equal, have historically been more reliable fantasy producers — but it's nowhere near sufficient on its own to forecast NFL success. And it never operates alone within the model.

The other debated input is Speed Score.

Speed Score, originally developed by Bill Barnwell, recognizes that not all 40-yard dashes are created equal. Running a 4.40 at 200 pounds isn't the same thing as running a 4.40 at 230. When adjusted for weight, faster backs generally produce better fantasy outcomes.

Generally.

Once again, the mistake is treating a single metric as definitive. Kareem Hunt is a good example. His Speed Score was unimpressive, but the rest of his profile was strong. He entered the league before his 22nd birthday, had solid size, and posted excellent age- and schedule-adjusted production numbers. As a result, he still graded well in the ZAP Model despite lacking straight-line speed.

If it were entirely up to me, running back size wouldn't matter much at all. But it does matter to NFL teams. Smaller backs are less likely to be handed massive workloads, and in fantasy football, volume still drives everything.

The good news is that smaller backs can absolutely offset that disadvantage with elite production and receiving profiles. The model allows for that flexibility.

That's the running back ZAP Model, though.

On the production side, it uses reception share, receiving yards per team pass attempt, and yards per team play. On the profile side, it incorporates age, weight, Teammate Score, and Speed Score. Layer draft capital on top, and you've got the full picture.

Well — maybe not the entire picture.

Draft capital is obviously a key part of the model, but it's calculated a little differently than it is at wide receiver and tight end. After doing some investigating last year, I found that combining NFL Mock Draft Database's consensus mock drafts with actual draft capital gave the running back ZAP Model more

signal — it made it more predictive.

In practice, that means the model uses a slight blend of real and projected draft capital — about an 83/17 split between actual draft capital and consensus projections.

Why would this help?

For one, it introduces a data point that isn't tied to a single team's decision. And it may simply be that the collective football brain — the analysts, scouts, and evaluators contributing to those mock drafts — does a pretty good job identifying running back talent. Interestingly, that same signal doesn't appear to hold as strongly for wide receivers and tight ends.

This might sound like a big change, but it really isn't. In most cases, projected and actual draft capital aren't drastically different.

But in the name of transparency, I wanted you to know.

The Tight End ZAP Model

Over the last couple of years, I've been building a tight end version of the ZAP Model. And it hasn't been easy.

The results have been solid — you saw some of that in last year's guide — but tight end is a different animal. Unlike wide receivers, tight ends don't run as many routes. There are fewer players putting up flashy receiving totals. They block more. And NFL teams draft them not just to catch passes, but to function as an extension of the offensive line.

In other words, what we're trying to solve in fantasy football isn't always what an NFL team is trying to solve.

That disconnect makes prospecting at the position more difficult. Draft capital, for example, doesn't carry quite the same weight for tight ends as it does for running backs and wide receivers.

At the start of the year, Brandon Gdula joined Late-Round Fantasy Football as a Senior Analyst. Brandon and I go way back to our numberFire and FanDuel days, and we've worked together in different capacities for years. As Late-Round has grown, I've needed support. Brandon brings deep data experience, he's a strong writer, and he's just an incredibly sharp thinker. When the opportunity came to bring him on board, I jumped at it.

Since he started, we've built a brand-new tight end model. More accurately, I oversaw the project while Brandon handled much of the heavy analytical lifting. And I can confidently say the new tight end ZAP Model is freaking awesome.

Like the other ZAP Models, this one predicts B2S — a player's best two-season average across his first three NFL years. And like the others, it looks at every tight end who was drafted or invited to the NFL Combine since 2011.

But this model works a little differently.

Instead of primarily leaning on draft capital and adjusting from there, the tight end model focuses on how three areas interact: draft capital, athleticism, and collegiate production.

Draft capital is straightforward — it's where the player was selected. Athleticism, in this model, is height-adjusted Speed Score. It's traditional Speed Score, but adjusted for height, and it carries more weight here than it does in the running back model.

On the production side, we're looking at Breakout Score, calculated similarly to the wide receiver model through age- and schedule-adjusted receiving yards per team pass attempt.

Technically, the model also incorporates best-season receiving yards per team pass attempt along with height and weight, but those three core areas are the easiest way to understand what's going on.

Here's the key difference with tight ends: athleticism fundamentally changes what draft capital means.



Through a lot of research, Brandon found that draft capital doesn't operate in isolation at this position. Its signal shifts depending on the athlete.

Take Jordan Reed as an example. Reed entered the NFL as a below-average athlete but was a Day 2 pick with legitimate college production. The model really likes him. When a tight end lacks high-end athleticism, early draft capital becomes more informative. It suggests the team saw something else — route-running, spatial awareness, technical refinement — that testing numbers don't capture. A less athletic player who still produced in college is likely winning in ways that raw speed doesn't show, and if a team invests meaningful draft capital in that profile, that investment carries real signal.

Teams won't always be right. But when they draft a mediocre athlete early, and that player has strong production, the model recognizes that combination as meaningful.

On the flip side, the model doesn't automatically reward tight ends just for being elite athletes. We often assume that a freakishly athletic Day 2 tight end must have a big fantasy future because a team “has plans” for him. But if the college production profile is weak, that player will take a significant hit in the ZAP Model. Athleticism is part of the puzzle, not the entire picture.

There's a balance between investment, traits, and production, and that's what the model is trying to capture.

A good example of this balance is the gap between Hunter Henry and Michael Mayer. Henry has a ZAP score of 85.6 in the model. Mayer's is 73.0. That's a meaningful difference, even though the two players were nearly identical across most inputs. Both were selected 35th overall. Their height and weight were almost the same. Their best-season yards per team pass attempt differed by just 0.01. Their Breakout Scores were essentially no different.

The main delta was athleticism. Mayer posted a height-adjusted Speed Score of 103.4, while Henry's was 96.2.

That's not backwards.

The model prefers Henry, the slightly weaker athlete, because when two players look nearly identical in draft capital and production, lower athleticism paired with that same level of investment suggests that the draft capital is signaling other translatable traits.

The team wasn't just drafting traits. The team was drafting a complete profile.

Keep all of that in mind as you read through this year's tight end profiles — which Brandon wrote for the guide. This model isn't about adding up traits and hoping for the best. It's about understanding how those traits interact, and what that interaction tells us about future opportunity and fantasy production.



Interpreting the Data

There were snow and ice storms hitting my corner of North Carolina toward the end of January, and at times, the local forecasts missed the mark. We'd hear projections of three-quarters of an inch of ice and end up with a quarter. Power outages were warned about that never materialized.

People were not thrilled.

A big part of that frustration comes down to misunderstanding. Most of us — myself included — don't really grasp the complex atmospheric processes that create winter precipitation. And when probability-driven forecasts are treated as promises, disappointment is almost inevitable.

In this metaphor, I'm the meteorologist. You're coming to me for a forecast on prospects.

But I'm not interested in just throwing a number on the screen and moving on. If I'm going to give you an outlook, it's my responsibility — not yours — to explain what that forecast actually means, where it can go wrong, and how to properly use it.

That's why the ZAP Model got a bit of a makeover this offseason.

Staying in the spirit of transparency, it's important to point out that the ZAP score you've historically seen on a player's profile isn't the raw number the model generates. Behind the scenes, the model produces a score based on its inputs that lives in a relatively narrow range — roughly the low 20s to high 40s at wide receiver, and single digits to the high 20s at running back.

Those raw numbers aren't particularly intuitive on their own. Without context or scaling, they're difficult to interpret.

In the past, I addressed this by converting scores into percentiles. That worked fine at first, but over time, it became clear that percentiles introduced their own problems. They force the data into a linear distribution and can obscure meaningful gaps between prospects who shouldn't feel interchangeable.

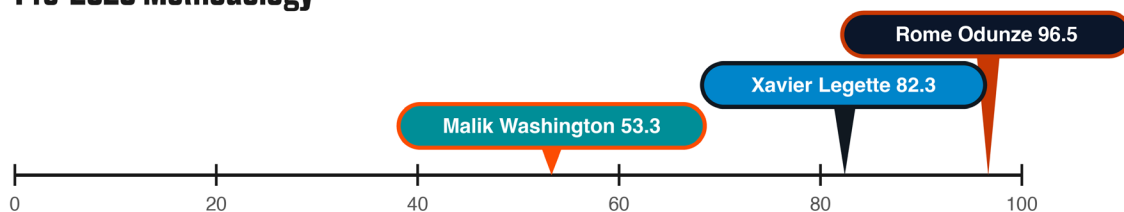
In turn, last year, categories were added as a step toward solving that problem. Players were grouped based on their raw model scores rather than their percentile rank, which helped frame expectations more realistically.

But even that solution never fully sat right with me. The raw score was still doing the real work behind the scenes, and it still wasn't being presented in a way that felt clear or intuitive enough.

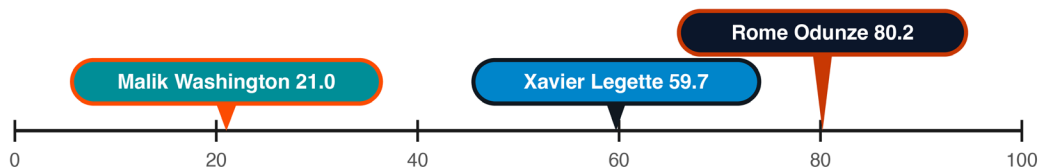
So this year, that changes.

Player scores are now scaled in a more intuitive way to better reflect true talent gaps between prospects. Rather than compressing players into overly similar ranges, the updated presentation makes it easier to see where meaningful separation actually exists, as you can see in the visual below:

Pre-2026 Methodology



2026 Methodology



As part of this update, a new top-end category has also been added: **Legendary Performer**.

Below is a general breakdown of the categories and the ZAP score ranges you can expect for each tier:

Legendary Performer (90–100):

Real potential to be a generational talent. These players hit at an outstanding rate historically and profile as cornerstone dynasty assets.

Elite Producer (75–90):

Capable of reaching ceilings similar to Legendary Performers, but with meaningfully lower odds.

Weekly Starter (60–75):

Players you can usually trust in your lineup — think RB2s and WR2s.

Flex Play (40–60):

Unlikely to become league-winners, but capable of providing usable fantasy production.

Benchwarmer (30–40):

Best suited as bench depth or insurance.

Waiver Wire Add (20–30):

Generally not roster-worthy, but occasionally useful in the right situation.

Dart Throw (0–20):

Little chance of sustained fantasy success.

This new scaling does a much better job showing how separated one prospect truly is from another — and that separation is helpful when analyzing a draft class.

With that framework in place, let's look at how the running back ZAP Model has performed historically through the lens of these categories.

Running Back (Best Two-Year Average; Years 1-3)

	>10	>12	>14	>16	>18	>20
Legendary Performer	100.0%	100.0%	87.5%	87.5%	75.0%	75.0%
Elite Producer	85.7%	71.4%	71.4%	21.4%	14.3%	7.1%
Weekly Starter	62.5%	45.0%	32.5%	22.5%	12.5%	5.0%
Flex Play	36.6%	14.6%	7.3%	7.3%	4.9%	0.0%
Benchwarmer	14.8%	9.8%	4.9%	3.3%	0.0%	0.0%
Waiver Wire Add	6.7%	3.3%	1.7%	1.7%	1.7%	0.0%
Dart Throw	3.7%	2.6%	1.1%	0.0%	0.0%	0.0%

The table above includes all running backs in the ZAP Model drafted between 2011 and 2023. We need the full three-year window to calculate B2S, which is why more recent classes aren't included.

The leftmost column shows the ZAP categories. Moving across the table, you'll see the percentage of players within each category who reached specific B2S thresholds.

For example, 85.7% of Elite Producers recorded a B2S of at least 10 PPR points per game. In other words, the vast majority of players in that tier delivered baseline fantasy usefulness. Meanwhile, every Legendary Performer reached that same threshold — though it's worth noting that the sample size is understandably small, given how difficult it is to earn that label.

At a high level, this table is showing us that the model works.

Of course, it isn't perfect. Occasionally, a Waiver Wire Add will spike a B2S north of 16 points per game. Sometimes, a Weekly Starter will completely flame out. That's the nature of probabilistic modeling.

What matters is that the model has been back-tested, and that both the scores and the categories derived from them are reliable over time.

Now let's look at the same breakdown for wide receivers.

Wide Receiver (Best Two-Year Average; Years 1-3)						
	>10	>12	>14	>16	>18	>20
Legendary Performer	88.9%	77.8%	66.7%	33.3%	22.2%	5.6%
Elite Producer	58.8%	38.2%	23.5%	11.8%	5.9%	2.9%
Weekly Starter	33.3%	22.2%	11.1%	6.3%	1.6%	0.0%
Flex Play	25.7%	20.3%	13.5%	6.8%	1.4%	0.0%
Benchwarmer	8.7%	4.3%	2.9%	2.9%	1.4%	1.4%
Waiver Wire Add	3.7%	0.9%	0.0%	0.0%	0.0%	0.0%
Dart Throw	1.6%	0.8%	0.0%	0.0%	0.0%	0.0%

Wide receivers have a harder time reaching truly elite B2S thresholds, but the trend remains clear. As the ZAP category improves, so do the hit rates. The signal is consistent, even if the position behaves a little differently.

The same story exists at tight end.

Tight End (Best Two-Year Average; Years 1-3)						
	>7	>8	>9	>10	>11	>12
Legendary Performer	100.0%	100.0%	100.0%	71.4%	42.9%	14.3%
Elite Producer	60.0%	46.7%	40.0%	13.3%	13.3%	13.3%
Weekly Starter	35.7%	35.7%	35.7%	28.6%	14.3%	7.1%
Flex Play	22.5%	20.0%	7.5%	5.0%	5.0%	5.0%
Benchwarmer	11.1%	3.7%	3.7%	3.7%	3.7%	3.7%
Waiver Wire Add	2.7%	0.0%	0.0%	0.0%	0.0%	0.0%
Dart Throw	0.0%	0.0%	0.0%	0.0%	0.0%	0.0%

Tight end can act a little goofier with these hit rate tables, mostly because we'll see a wide variety of archetypes selected at the position. Because Weekly Starters may look better than Elite Producers at certain thresholds doesn't mean that category is

better. And it certainly doesn't mean the model isn't working.

It's just showing us that the category is still capable, and perhaps the lines aren't as clear-cut between those two groups. Nevertheless, Elite Producers have still provided a much higher ceiling.

Draft Capital Delta

You may have noticed a glaring outlier in the wide receiver hit-rate table — a Benchwarmer who posted a B2S north of 20 PPR points per game.

That player was — is — Puka Nacua.

The model labeled him at the top of the Benchwarmer category.

Holy L.

Or... maybe not.

Draft capital anchors ZAP scores by design. And historically, Day 3 wide receivers — players drafted on the third day of the NFL Draft — simply haven't been very fantasy relevant. Since 2011, the list of wideouts selected after Pick 100 who've averaged at least 14 PPR points per game in B2S is extremely short: Puka Nacua, Tyreek Hill, Amon-Ra St. Brown, and Martavis Bryant. Bryant didn't even provide production in Year 3.

That's the list.

Nacua was drafted 177th overall. No sane model is going to treat a player with that type of draft capital as a top-tier prospect. And if a model does rank a Day 3 wide receiver near the top of a class, there's almost certainly some overfitting happening.

So yes — a low ZAP score for a late-round pick is common. But that doesn't mean the model is telling us to completely ignore those players.

That's where Draft Capital Delta comes in.

Every prospect has two things: a ZAP score, and an implied score based solely on his draft capital. A first overall pick might carry a draft-capital score near 100. An undrafted player would be close to zero.

Draft Capital Delta measures the difference between those two values. In effect, it asks: How does the model view this player once we strip away what the NFL told us?

In Nacua's case, his ZAP score came in at 40.5. Based on his draft position, his score "should've" been closer to 33.9.

That seven-point gap is meaningful, especially for a Day 3 pick. It tells us that, while his profile wasn't pristine, there were still positive indicators — a respectable Breakout Score, some rushing involvement, and enough underlying production to separate him from a typical 177th-overall selection.

Draft Capital Delta buckets players into three risk tiers: low risk, neutral, and high risk. Low-risk players are those the model likes more than their draft capital would suggest. High-risk players are the opposite — prospects whose ZAP scores lag behind how the dynasty market is likely valuing them.

As you'd expect, low-risk players outperform their expected B2S at a much higher rate than high-risk players.

It's not foolproof. There will always be exceptions. But Draft Capital Delta adds valuable context — especially when you're deciding whether a late-round prospect is worth taking a swing on, or whether an early pick carries more downside than the market realizes.

Adding Subjectivity

Some people make New Year's resolutions about going to the gym more. Others want to read more books. Some try to drink less.

Me? One of my New Year's resolutions is to put more faith in the ZAP Model.

This process is mostly objective. I say “mostly” because I’m human, and humans bring biases with them whether they like it or not. Total objectivity is a myth.

But modeling does give us something incredibly valuable: a baseline. A way to stay grounded when narratives start to creep in and rookie drafts get chaotic.

That baseline isn’t the end-all.

There are times when I disagree with the model and lean more heavily on subjective evaluation. Historically, that hasn’t always gone well for me — hence the resolution — but the ZAP Model isn’t flawless. You’ve already seen that. Misses are part of the deal.

My goal isn’t to tell you exactly what to do. It’s to give you tools. To offer a framework that helps you think differently about prospects and make more informed decisions.

Fantasy football is about winning — mostly. But it’s also about enjoying the process. Digging into players. Debating evaluations. Getting your hands dirty.

You don’t need to follow the ZAP Model blindly.

In fact, I don’t want you to.

Use this guide as another weapon in your arsenal. Read other analysts. Listen to other podcasts. Check out what pure film-based evaluators have to say. There are a lot of sharp people doing great work.

Just don’t completely ignore what the ZAP Model is telling you.

Because having that baseline — that anchor — can give you a very real edge.

2026 Prospect Profiles

Overview

It's rare for a running back or wide receiver to become a fantasy football star without an NFL Combine invite. It certainly happens — Austin Ekeler and Adam Thielen both became studs after being skipped over. But exceptions don't invalidate the rule.

From a probability standpoint, if we're playing fantasy football, we should care most about the players who were invited to the NFL Combine. Period.

That's the focus of these prospect profiles.

There were 46 wide receiver invites to this year's NFL Combine. There were 20 running backs — well, 20 running backs and a fullback — who were awarded the same honor. And we've got 27 tight ends this year, too.

**Late-Round Fantasy Football Senior Analyst
Brandon Gdula and yours truly profiled them. All
of them.**

We studied their profiles, and we analyzed the type of players they may become at the next level.

These outlooks are going to change after the draft — and, when they do, I'll send you an updated version of this guide. But understanding a class before draft capital and landing spots enter the equation is part of the edge.

Key Terms

ZAP Score: The score given to an incoming rookie in the ZAP Model. It's based on the factors outlined in the ZAP Model Overview section of this guide. For pre-draft scores, the draft capital input is based on projected draft capital from NFLMockDraftDatabase.com. All scores range from 0 to 100.

ZAP Score Category: Every player's ZAP score coincides with one of seven categories, which were talked about earlier. Those categories will be listed on every player's prospect page.

Breakout Score: The score given to a wide receiver and tight end for his age-adjusted production. This is based on yards per team pass attempt. All scores range from 0 to 100.

B2S: The ZAP Model attempts to predict how well a player will do in fantasy football across his first three years in the league. In doing this, it tests against the average of a player's top-two seasons in PPR points per game during his first three years as a pro. This is referred to as B2S (Best Two Seasons).

Draft Capital Delta: The difference between a player's ZAP score versus where he was drafted in the actual NFL Draft. A very low Draft Capital Delta will be displayed as a "high risk" profile. A very high one will be shown as a "low risk" profile. Most players will simply be "neutral". *Draft Capital Deltas will be published in the post-draft version of the guide.*

Speed Score: A concept developed by Bill Barnwell to help appropriately weight 40-yard dash times based on a player's size.

Statistical Comparables: Players in history who appear to have similar analytical profiles to the player being analyzed. This is based on things like size, age, Breakout Score, and other production metrics.

Wide Receiver



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Jordyn Tyson • WR

 **96.2**

ZAP Score

ARIZONA STATE

LEGENDARY PERFORMER

Low Risk **Neutral** High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height: 6'2 Weight: 203 NFL Team: Saints

Statistical Comps: CeeDee Lamb ▪ Marvin Harrison Jr. ▪ Corey Davis

Update: There's a real chance the ZAP Model is too bullish on Jordyn Tyson – but within the predictive analytics we care about, he looks the part.

Outside of draft capital, Breakout Score carries the most weight in the wide receiver ZAP Model by a wide margin. Tyson's mark checks in at 95.1, the best in this year's class and good for the 99th percentile.

That's largely because he produced at a high level throughout his collegiate career. As a young freshman at Colorado, Tyson led the team in receiving in just nine games. A devastating knee injury cut that season short and wiped out his second year, but he bounced back in Year 3 with a prorated adjusted receiving yards per team pass attempt rate of 3.58 – the best top-season mark in this class.

This is a rare kind of Breakout Score. Only nine ZAP Model wide receivers drafted in the top 20 have posted a mark above 90: Mike Evans, Sammy Watkins, Amari Cooper, Corey Davis, CeeDee Lamb, Ja'Marr Chase, Chris Olave, Jaxon Smith-Njigba, and Malik Nabers. That's elite company – and Tyson got there as a four-year player, a distinction only Olave and Davis share.

The elephant in the room is the injury history. There's the knee, a broken collarbone, and a hamstring issue. You can subjectively ding his ZAP score because of it, but he's already returned from the knee and collarbone injuries, and the hamstring appears to be behind him.

Some of the peripherals aren't perfect, either. Tyson has a bit of a yards-after-the-catch problem, and per PFF, he ranks in just the 7th percentile in avoided tackles per reception. That's not disqualifying – players like Chris Olave and DeVonta Smith graded poorly there, too – but it's not a plus.

The Saints selected Tyson eighth overall, and it's a solid landing spot. He can line up all over the formation – he posted a 31% career slot rate in college – and, as Matt Harmon has shown with Reception Perception, Tyson thrives against zone coverage. Olave wins against man. That combination could stress defenses, and with little proven depth behind them, both receivers have a path to meaningful volume. Kellen Moore's offenses have also tended to play fast, which helps on the volume front.

As an Olave truther, it's wild to say this, but Tyson has a path to eventually being the more impactful fantasy player. It probably won't happen right away, but the ceiling is there.



Carnell Tate • WR

 **88.3**

ZAP Score

OHIO STATE

ELITE PRODUCER

Low Risk **Neutral** High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height: 6'2 Weight: 192 NFL Team: Titans

Statistical Comps: George Pickens ▪ Calvin Ridley ▪ Will Fuller

Update: We've seen Chris Olave, Garrett Wilson, Jaxon Smith-Njigba, Marvin Harrison Jr., and Emeka Egbuka go in Round 1 out of Ohio State over the last five years. Now we can add Carnell Tate to that list.

Tate went fourth overall to Tennessee, and while that draft capital is as strong as any Buckeye receiver in this run, his ZAP score ranks second-lowest among them, ahead of only Egbuka. That's not necessarily a knock – his 65.3 Breakout Score sits in the 87th percentile – it's just that the others brought slightly stronger analytical profiles to the table.

The biggest concern with Tate is volume, which obviously matters for fantasy. Yes, he played alongside Jeremiyah Smith, but his best-season target share still maxed out at just 21.7%. Among first-round wide receivers since 2018 (36 entering this year), that number only beats Henry Ruggs, Jaylen Waddle, Kadarius Toney, Jameson Williams, and Matthew Golden.

It doesn't stop there. Tate earned a target on fewer than 20% of his routes run across his collegiate career. Among that same first-round cohort since 2018, the only others to hit that low of a targets per route run rate are Ruggs, Williams, Brian Thomas, Xavier Legette, Ricky Pearsall, Golden, and Travis Hunter.

It's not all doom and gloom, though. Top-10 draft capital matters – a lot. Since 2011, wide receivers drafted in the top half of Round 1 who played at least three seasons have averaged a best-season output of 13.9 PPR points per game within their first three years. When you filter for players with Breakout Scores above 60, that jumps to 15.0. That gives Tate a strong, high-end median outcome.

The landing spot in Tennessee isn't bad, either. Cam Ward is still a bit of a question mark, but the arm talent is there. Tate wins downfield and in contested situations – his collegiate contested catch rate ranked in the 98th percentile among ZAP Model wideouts since 2020. That should mesh well with Ward.

And there's a path to volume. The Titans added Wan'Dale Robinson this offseason, but he'll operate more underneath. Elic Ayomanor flashed as a rookie, but Tate can take over the field-stretching role right away. And Calvin Ridley – ironically one of Tate's ZAP comps – looks closer to the end than the peak at this point.

All told, a ZAP score of 88.3 is really good – like, really good. He's not quite a Legendary Performer, but this is a profile you can work with, even if there are some analytical concerns.



Makai Lemon • WR

 **77.4**

ZAP Score

SOUTHERN CALIFORNIA

ELITE PRODUCER

Low Risk **Neutral** High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height: 5'11 Weight: 192 NFL Team: Eagles

Statistical Comps: Nelson Agholor ▪ Odell Beckham ▪ Jayden Reed

Update: The Amon-Ra St. Brown comp for Makai Lemon may be a little played out, but it's still a quick way to frame his ceiling in fantasy. Both are technicians with elite short-area quickness and a relentless edge. Like St. Brown, Lemon has that dog in him.

And like St. Brown, Lemon lived in the slot in college. His 75.8% career slot rate ranks in the 88th percentile among ZAP Model wideouts since 2020. That's rare territory for a first-rounder, too – only Jaylen Waddle, Kadarius Toney, Treyton Burks, Jaxon Smith-Njigba, and Emeka Egbuka have cleared a 70% slot rate since 2018.

Fortunately, Lemon's profile separates from someone like Toney's pretty quickly. His career yards per route run sits at 3.02 (96th percentile), his first downs per route run is also in the 96th percentile, and he actually posted the best perimeter yards per route run in this year's class. On paper, that suggests he can win outside.

The caveat: we've technically seen this archetype bust before.

Since 2018, nine wideouts in the ZAP Model database picked in the top-100 have paired a 65% or better career slot rate with a perimeter yards per route run of at least 3.0. Lemon clears both with room to spare. Jaxon Smith-Njigba and Drake London are in that group – great. But so are Treyton Burks, Tutu Atwell, Elijah Moore, Mecole Hardman, Malachi Corley, Rondale Moore, and Jalin Hyatt. That's a mixed bag at best.

The good news is that among first-rounders, the real comps are Burks, Smith-Njigba, and London. Two of those three have become elite NFL players. Lemon's peripherals also look stronger than Burks' did coming out.

The bigger question is fit in Philadelphia. Jalen Hurts hasn't historically targeted the middle of the field at a high rate, which is where Lemon would ideally thrive. And since Hurts became the starter, the Eagles haven't posted a positive pass rate over expected in any season – volume isn't guaranteed. Philadelphia also drafted pass-catching tight end Eli Stowers in Round 2, and he'll likely occupy a similar area of the field as Lemon, limiting target upside.

This pick does strongly signal that AJ Brown is on the way out, though. Lemon could step in as a top-two target alongside DeVonta Smith immediately. The pairing makes sense on paper, since Smith is a great field-stretcher and Lemon can win underneath. We just need the offense to evolve a bit for Lemon to truly hit, and that's no guarantee – it'd be nice to have a cleaner landing spot for such a talent.



KC Concepcion • WR

 **75.4**

ZAP Score

TEXAS A&M

ELITE PRODUCER

Low Risk Neutral High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height: 6'0 Weight: 196 NFL Team: Browns

Statistical Comps: Christian Kirk ▪ Emeka Egbuka ▪ Randall Cobb

Update: The fantasy football world probably won't love KC Concepcion landing in Cleveland, but there were definitely worse spots.

The Browns have a beatable depth chart, even with Denzel Boston, so Concepcion could realistically lead the team in target share as early as this season. And new head coach Todd Monken is coming off a three-year run as Baltimore's offensive coordinator, where he helped Zay Flowers produce multiple fantasy-relevant campaigns. Flowers, like Concepcion, was a versatile playmaker in college who didn't fit the traditional NFL wide receiver mold.

And make no mistake: the ZAP Model likes Concepcion more as a prospect than it liked Flowers. Concepcion is an early declare with a 54.3 Breakout Score (78th percentile), while Flowers posted a lower mark as a four-year player.

For a first-round wideout, though, Concepcion's Breakout Score sits right on the line between hit and miss. Among back-half-of-the-first-round receivers in ZAP Model history, nine have posted a score between 45 and 65. That group includes AJ Jenkins, Nelson Agholor, Phillip Dorsett, Laquon Treadwell, and Jalen Reagor – but also Calvin Ridley, Brandon Aiyuk, Zay Flowers, and Brian Thomas. That range alone doesn't give us a clear answer.

Other factors help. One is age – as an early declare, Concepcion still isn't 22 years old. Another is versatility, specifically his rushing usage, which feeds into the model.

Among 10 wideouts since 2011 in Concepcion's age bucket who were drafted between Picks 16 and 50 and saw their ZAP scores boosted by rushing production, all but two have produced at least one 10-PPR-point-per-game season. The exceptions are Jalen Reagor and Luther Burden, and Burden's only played one NFL season so far. Three players in that cohort – Brandin Cooks, DJ Moore, and Jordan Addison – delivered fringe WR1 seasons, with Robert Woods and Wan'Dale Robinson also in the mix.

There are real concerns, though. Concepcion never posted a dominant peak in college – his best season in receiving yards per team pass attempt was just 2.25. Prior to this year's draft, first-round wideouts in the ZAP Model database who failed to hit 2.50 include Henry Ruggs, Kadarius Toney, Zay Flowers, Ricky Pearsall, and Matthew Golden. Concepcion also ran over 70% of his routes from the slot in college, but I'd be less concerned with that given his 2025 campaign with Texas A&M saw him line up in the slot at a 34% rate. And that's when we saw him have his most productive season.

This isn't a flawless profile. There are signals pointing in both directions. But the combination of versatility and age-adjusted production gives him a legitimate path to becoming a meaningful NFL and fantasy contributor. Even in Cleveland.



Omar Cooper • WR

 **65.2**

ZAP Score

INDIANA

WEEKLY STARTER

Low Risk Neutral High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height: 6'0 Weight: 199 NFL Team: Jets

Statistical Comps: Rashee Rice ▪ Deebo Samuel ▪ Carlos Henderson

Update: The best tackle-breaker in this wide receiver class is probably Omar Cooper. He avoided an absurd 0.31 tackles per reception across his career, a 97th percentile mark among ZAP Model wideouts since 2020.

His efficiency profile is solid, too. Cooper posted a 79th percentile career yards per route run and an 82nd percentile first downs per route run. He split time between the slot and perimeter – a 48% career slot rate, per PFF – but was similarly effective in both alignments.

The analytical concern comes from his trajectory. Cooper is a four-year player who didn't produce early, finishing with a 41.7 Breakout Score (55th percentile). That's not bad, but for a first-rounder, it's concerning. Of the 14 first-round wide receivers in the ZAP database with a Breakout Score below 50, just one has posted a 14-plus PPR points-per-game season within his first three years. And it was Kelvin Benjamin.

To be fair, with 30th overall draft capital, Cooper is just as similar to earlier second-round picks as he is some first-round ones. And once you move into that range, the Breakout Score hit rate improves. Rashee Rice is a strong comp, and Deebo Samuel is another – Cooper is smaller, but several of his production metrics line up favorably with Samuel's collegiate profile.

There's some minor versatility here, too. Cooper logged 97 rushing yards and a pair scores over his final two seasons and even returned a few kicks as a freshman at Indiana. He's unlikely to have that role in the NFL, but it's at least a signal of his athleticism.

The bigger issue is landing spot. Cooper goes to the Jets – and, well, it's the Jets. Garrett Wilson is already a target hog there, and the team also spent a first-round pick on tight end Kenyon Sadiq. Geno Smith is projected to start in 2026, and while he should improve behind a better offensive line compared to last year, this still isn't an offense you're banking on for volume or efficiency.

Cooper's profile looks more like a second-rounder than a true first, but it's workable. The concern is the short-term outlook – both in terms of earning targets and the quality of those targets. He just doesn't have the same kind of allure as the top-four wide receivers in this class. Analytically, at least.



Germie Bernard • WR

 **64.8**

ZAP Score

ALABAMA

WEEKLY STARTER

Low Risk Neutral High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height: 6'1 Weight: 206 NFL Team: Steelers

Statistical Comps: Parris Campbell ▪ Mohamed Sanu ▪ Lynn Bowden

Update: Pittsburgh has needed a reliable slot option, and they got one in Alabama's Germie Bernard. Honestly, it's one of the most Steelers picks imaginable.

Bernard is tough. He's a solid 206 pounds and forced missed tackles at an 84th percentile rate across his collegiate career. Coaches moved him around, too – he logged 36 rush attempts for 184 yards, including an 18-carry, 101-yard, 2-touchdown performance in 2025 at Alabama.

Bernard dealt with strong competition at every stop of his career, which probably had some impact on his overall production. In 2022 at Michigan State, he played alongside Keon Coleman and Jayden Reed. In 2023 at Washington, it was Rome Odunze, Ja'Lynn Polk, Jalen McMillan, and Denzel Boston – and Bernard actually outproduced Boston in that offense. Over the last two years at Alabama, he shared the field with Ryan Williams, a probable first-rounder in 2027.

Despite all that, Bernard still posted a 40.4 Breakout Score, which lands in the 52nd percentile. It's not ideal for a second-round pick, but given the context, it's at least understandable.

The bull case is straightforward here: Bernard can step in as a go-to slot option and fill a needed role alongside DK Metcalf and Michael Pittman. And he may have a little bit of juice to play outside – his efficiency metrics were better on the perimeter throughout his career than in the slot.

The bear case is unfortunately a little easier to make.

Bernard finished with a career yards per route run below 2.0, and 22% of his targets came behind the line of scrimmage. Since 2018, the list of top-100 wide receivers with both a sub-2.0 yards per route run and a behind-the-line target rate above 20% includes Jalen Hurd, Lynn Bowden, Amari Rodgers, Velus Jones, and Kyle Williams. If you loosen the yards per route run threshold to 2.2, you get more viable names – Christian Kirk and Zay Flowers, for example – but Bernard's 1.90 career mark still raises concern.

Then there's the comp list. It's light on hits, even beyond the three that are provided above. That's not everything, but it's also not something that boosts confidence.

Overall, Bernard is fine. The versatility matters, but this looks like more of a higher-floor, lower-ceiling player for fantasy. Pittsburgh does have potential outs with both Metcalf and Pittman's contracts next season, though, which could make things more interesting in 2027.



Denzel Boston • WR

 **62.3**

ZAP Score

WASHINGTON

WEEKLY STARTER

Low Risk Neutral High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height: 6'4 Weight: 212 NFL Team: Browns

Statistical Comps: Jayden Higgins ▪ Courtland Sutton ▪ Mike Williams

Update: The expectation was that Denzel Boston would be a first-round pick. He didn't get that top-32 capital, but he still landed early in Round 2 with Cleveland.

Boston spent all four years at Washington, sharing the field with Rome Odunze, Jalen McMillan, and Ja'Lynn Polk during his first two seasons. Naturally, his production was limited during that stretch.

Even accounting for that, his eventual breakout was a bit underwhelming. In 2024, Boston posted a 2.00 receiving yards per team pass attempt rate. That climbed to 2.58 the following season – 2.75 when adjusted for strength of schedule. The result was a 43.8 Breakout Score, which sits around the 60th percentile.

That's more acceptable for a second-rounder than a mid-first-round prospect, where some projected him back in March. But you'd still prefer to see a stronger mark.

Beyond Breakout Score, the analytical profile doesn't offer much help. Boston's career yards per route run is just 2.02, a 48th percentile figure. Since 2020, 29 Day 2 wide receivers have posted a career mark below 2.20. Only Nico Collins and Jayden Reed from that group managed to score more than 13 PPR points per game in one of their first three seasons.

The landing spot doesn't do him many favors, either. Cleveland used a first-round pick on the more well-rounded KC Concepcion, and Boston will have to compete with him throughout his rookie contract. It's also an offense with a featured tight end and, most likely, an unsettled quarterback situation.

Boston would've been an easy fade had he gone in Round 1, given where his rookie draft cost would've landed. Now, the market will probably be less aggressive. Just understand that this is a highly volatile profile.



De'Zhaun Stribling • WR

 **58.7**

ZAP Score

MISSISSIPPI

FLEX PLAY

Low Risk Neutral High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height: 6'2 Weight: 207 NFL Team: 49ers

Statistical Comps: Charone Peake ▪ Jordan Payton ▪ Cornelius Johnson

Update: In the pre-draft version of the prospect guide, De'Zhaun Stribling's blurb read, "Unless draft capital surprises in a meaningful way, Stribling isn't someone you'll need to prioritize in rookie drafts."

Well, about that...

Stribling going 33rd overall to San Francisco was one of the biggest surprises of the draft – at least among skill position players. Because his profile, quite frankly, doesn't match that kind of capital. It may not even be a Day 2 profile.

The analytics are underwhelming. He posted a 28.5 Breakout Score, driven largely by a 2024 season at Oklahoma State where his adjusted receiving yards per team pass attempt barely cleared 2.0. That ended up being his peak. In 2025 at Ole Miss, that number dropped to 1.70. Across five collegiate seasons, his best mark ranks in just the 32nd percentile among ZAP Model wide receivers.

If there's something working in his favor, it's after the catch. Stribling posted a 60th percentile yards-after-catch-per-reception rate, and he forced missed tackles at an above-average clip. That fits what Kyle Shanahan tends to value, and it likely played a role in the selection.

And to be fair, we *have* seen Day 2 hits from older prospects with poor Breakout Scores – Rashee Rice, Michael Thomas, and Terry McLaurin are examples. But the difference is what's under the hood. Since 2018, 12 Day 2 wide receivers have entered the league with career yards per route run below 2.0, per PFF data. Only one of them – McLaurin – has delivered a truly fantasy-relevant season across his first three years.

Stribling's career yards per route run sits at just 1.68.

There may be some opportunity in San Francisco as early as 2026, but it's not a situation where you're expecting an immediate return. Mike Evans and Ricky Pearsall are in place, and Christian McCaffrey will continue to command targets out of the backfield. Maybe things open up in 2027 – Evans could be gone – but that would mean holding a shaky profile on your bench for a while.

Chances are, Stribling won't go as early in rookie drafts as he did in the NFL Draft. And analytically, he shouldn't.



Ja’Kobi Lane • WR

 **54.4**

ZAP Score

SOUTHERN CALIFORNIA

FLEX PLAY

Low Risk Neutral High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height: 6'4 Weight: 200 NFL Team: Ravens

Statistical Comps: Justin Hunter ▪ Terrace Marshall ▪ Adonai Mitchell

Update: Ja’Kobi Lane is one of just five early-declare wide receivers in this year’s class, spending all three collegiate seasons at USC. After catching just seven passes in six games as a freshman, he jumped to 43 and then 49 receptions over the next two years.

The production profile, though, is underwhelming. His 2024 adjusted receiving yards per team pass attempt was just 1.14, rising to 2.35 as a junior. Even that peak ranked outside the top 20 in the class. The result is a 35.9 Breakout Score – a below-average mark in the ZAP Model.

To be fair, Lane shared the field with likely first-rounder Makai Lemon, so Teammate Score gives him a modest boost. But even with that context, the résumé looks pretty ordinary. His career yards per route run, per PFF, ranks 26th in the class. He was fine at generating first downs, but nothing here signals a difference-maker.

While he has length, Lane’s frame is leaner than you’d expect for a true contested-catch specialist – and that was a big part of his profile. Among this year’s Combine invitees, he ranked first with a near 33% contested target rate. With top-100 draft capital, he’s just the fourth wide receiver since 2020 to enter the league with a contested target rate above 30%.

The other three are Josh Palmer, Nico Collins, and Alec Pierce – not bad company. But each of those players had stronger Breakout Scores and more size to support that play style. Lane’s contested usage seems to stem more from an inability to separate.

In Baltimore, Lane is likely buried early. Zay Flowers and Rashod Bateman are ahead of him, with Bateman under contract through 2027 and Flowers potentially there long-term as well. The Ravens also drafted Elijah Sarratt, who may just be the better player.

And even with a new coordinator, this is still an offense that hasn’t posted a positive pass rate over expected since Lamar Jackson became the starter in 2019. Volume is unlikely to be a strength.

There are a couple of things to like – mainly his age and early declare status – but this isn’t a profile that demands attention in rookie drafts.



Antonio Williams • WR

 **53.3**

ZAP Score

CLEMSON

FLEX PLAY

Low Risk Neutral High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height: 6'0 Weight: 187 NFL Team: Commanders

Statistical Comps: Ladd McConkey ▪ Markus Wheaton ▪ Roman Wilson

Update: In an underwhelming rookie class, Antonio Williams is at least somewhat interesting.

Williams spent his entire collegiate career at Clemson and produced right away. As a freshman, he caught 56 passes for 604 yards and 4 touchdowns, leading the team in receiving. Clemson was fairly pass-heavy that season, though, so his 1.26 receiving yards per team pass attempt wasn't especially notable.

Injuries limited him to five games as a sophomore. Then, over his final two seasons, Williams never exceeded 1.70 receiving yards per team pass attempt. Even when adjusted, his peak was just 1.82.

Put differently, he was consistently productive, but never dominant. You'd like to see at least one standout season. His 38.4 Breakout Score reflects that – it's basically average.

Historically, that kind of production hasn't translated well. Among Day 2 wide receivers since 2011, just 15 entered the league with a best-season adjusted receiving yards per team pass attempt below 2.0. Only Terry McLaurin and Ladd McConkey have become hits from that group. And McConkey – notably Williams' top comp – was incredibly efficient on a per-route basis. Williams doesn't have that going for him, which makes the profile harder to buy.

Williams ran 78% of his routes from the slot, but Clemson did use him on the ground, which gives him a small bump in the ZAP Model. Top-100 picks with that kind of versatility tend to outperform expectation at a higher rate.

The landing spot helps, especially in a class like this one where there aren't obvious directions to go in rookie drafts. Washington has very little established at wide receiver outside of Terry McLaurin, who turns 31 in September. Williams has a real chance to step in as the primary slot option right away and become an easy outlet for Jayden Daniels. And maybe there's a path to more – someone like McConkey has shown that a player with a similar frame can play inside and out at the next level.

I just wouldn't bet on it.



Zachariah Branch • WR



49.1

ZAP Score

GEORGIA

FLEX PLAY

Low Risk Neutral High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height: 5'9 Weight: 177 NFL Team: Falcons

Statistical Comps: Mecole Hardman ▪ Tre Tucker ▪ Phillip Dorsett

Update: Back in March, I thought Zachariah Branch might be the player I'd fade most in rookie drafts this year. But given how this class shook out, he's almost...interesting.

There are some positives. Branch is an early declare, and the model gives him credit for his versatility and unique usage. He's explosive, shifty, and can operate in short areas.

The negatives? There are plenty.

Branch never truly produced at a high level. His raw receiving yards per team pass attempt failed to reach 2.0 in a season, and even when adjusted for strength of schedule, his peak was just 2.11. That led to a below-average 31.2 Breakout Score.

The usage profile is even more concerning. A massive 45.5% of his career targets came behind the line of scrimmage. That doesn't mean he can't develop into something more, but it does mean you're betting on a significant leap.

Historically, that's been a dangerous bet. With top-100 draft capital, Branch becomes the 11th wide receiver since 2020 to enter the league with a career behind-the-line target rate above 30% – and the first to exceed 40%. Only two players in that group, Wan'Dale Robinson and Luther Burden, posted Breakout Scores above 75. The rest? Lynn Bowden, Amari Rodgers, Anthony Schwartz, Kadarius Toney, Rondale Moore, Velus Jones, Tre Tucker, and Malachi Corley.

A big reason for that is screen-heavy usage. Over 35% of Branch's career yards came on screens. Among top-100 picks since 2020, only two receivers have cleared 30% of their career yardage from screens: Malachi Corley and Anthony Schwartz.

This is an archetype that's burned teams before.

To be fair, though, the athleticism is intriguing, and the landing spot could've been worse. Atlanta's depth chart entering the draft featured Drake London (a stud), Jahan Dotson (not a stud), and Olamide Zaccheaus (not a stud). Branch will likely start in a gadget role, but it wouldn't be surprising if he earns more meaningful reps by the end of the 2026 season than he would have on most teams.

Still, this is a tough profile to buy into. In a stronger class, Branch would be closer to an avoid than a target. But in this one, where you're throwing darts earlier than usual, he's at least in the mix.



Caleb Douglas • WR

 **47.2**

ZAP Score

TEXAS TECH

FLEX PLAY

Low Risk Neutral High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height: 6'4 Weight: 206 NFL Team: Dolphins

Statistical Comps: Mekale McKay ▪ Geronimo Allison ▪ Kaden Prather

Update: Entering the draft, Miami's wide receiver depth chart was arguably the weakest in the league. Taking Caleb Douglas in Round 3 didn't do much to change that.

Maybe Douglas proves the ZAP Model wrong, but there's not a lot to like here. He was projected to go outside the top 200, according to NFL Mock Draft Database, and the underlying metrics reflect that. Douglas posted a 25th percentile Breakout Score, a 28th percentile career yards per route run, a 15th percentile best-season yards per route run, a 23rd percentile first downs per route run, a...you get the idea.

One of the bigger concerns is where and how he wins. Douglas ran just 15% of his routes from the slot, but his efficiency on the perimeter was especially poor – just 1.65 yards per route run, a 21st percentile mark. At 6'4", 206 pounds, he's almost certainly going to be asked to play outside in the NFL.

According to PFF data, Douglas is just the ninth Day 2 wide receiver to enter the league since 2020 with a career perimeter yards per route run below 1.80. None of the previous eight have produced more than 12.5 PPR points per game in any of their first three seasons.

He'll get a chance to see the field – that depth chart all but guarantees it. But if you're throwing a dart at a Miami wide receiver from this draft, Chris Bell offers a more appealing ceiling. We'll just have to see where the dynasty market places Douglas to know if he's a clear target or avoid – all we do know is that this is clearly a high-risk profile.



Malachi Fields • WR

 **46.7**

ZAP Score

NOTRE DAME

FLEX PLAY

Low Risk Neutral High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height: 6'5 Weight: 218 NFL Team: Giants

Statistical Comps: Mack Hollins ▪ Miles Boykin ▪ Michael Pittman

Update: Malachi Fields' production profile is lacking.

He began his collegiate career at Virginia in 2021, catching just 11 passes as a true freshman before a foot injury limited him to one game as a sophomore. His junior season showed some promise – 58 receptions for 811 yards and 5 touchdowns – resulting in a 2.24 adjusted receiving yards per team pass attempt mark.

That ended up being his best year.

Fields played two more seasons – one at Virginia and one at Notre Dame – but neither produced a stronger campaign.

Now, a little behind-the-scenes note: in the pre-draft version of the guide, Fields had the wrong birthday in the ZAP Model, which lowered his Breakout Score by about 10 points. So, yes, he looks better now than he did then.

He still doesn't look great.

Fields' Breakout Score comes in at a very average 43.1, and the ZAP Model still tags him as a high-risk prospect. The advanced metrics back that up. His career yards per route run sits at 1.94 – a major concern. Since 2020, 18 Day 2 wide receivers have entered the league with a career mark below 2.0. None of them have produced more than 12.5 PPR points per game in any of their first three seasons.

There are some positives. Fields has prototypical size, and there's opportunity in the Giants offense, where Malik Nabers is the only long-term fixture. If you really want to stretch for an outcome, you can squint and see something like Michael Pittman, one of his top-three comps.

But that's closer to a ceiling than an expectation. Fields is a risky bet.



Chris Brazzell • WR

 **46.5**

ZAP Score

TENNESSEE

WEEKLY STARTER

Low Risk **Neutral** High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height: 6'4 Weight: 198 NFL Team: Panthers

Statistical Comps: Josh Reynolds ▪ Denzel Mims ▪ George Pickens

Update: Chris Brazzell slipped a bit on draft weekend, landing with Carolina at Pick 83. As a second-round prospect, there were questions. As a late Day 2 pick? The upside becomes easier to chase.

Brazzell played in Tennessee's offense under Josh Heupel, which hasn't always translated cleanly to the ZAP Model. It's burned us before, so there's some inherent risk here.

At 6'4", 198 pounds, Brazzell has the prototypical vertical build. He used it to stretch defenses, too. Among receivers in this class, he saw deep targets at a top-15 rate, and nearly 18% of his receptions came on those throws – a top-10 figure. His career average depth of target, per PFF, ranked top-five.

The usage aligns with that role. Brazzell lined up in the slot on fewer than 7% of his snaps, the lowest rate in the class. He's a true boundary receiver tasked with winning downfield.

From a ZAP Model standpoint, the profile is solid, but not overwhelming. After starting at Tulane, Brazzell transferred to Tennessee in 2024, with his breakout coming in his final season – the first time he cleared a 2.0 adjusted receiving yards per team pass attempt mark. That led to a 45.7 Breakout Score, good for the 63rd percentile.

We've seen this archetype hit before. Bigger-bodied vertical receivers taken on Day 2 – players like Nico Collins, Tee Higgins, George Pickens, and Christian Watson – show the ceiling that exists here.

The issue is that most of those hits had stronger efficiency profiles than Brazzell's 2.09 career yards per route run. Once you get into that range, the comps start to look more like Denzel Mims or Cedric Tillman.

Then you factor in the landing spot. Carolina isn't built to support multiple fantasy-relevant wide receivers right now – they ranked 20th in wide receiver PPR production last season. Tetairoa McMillan should command targets, and Jalen Coker looks like a legitimate volume earner as well.

This move feels more like a real-life fit than a fantasy-friendly one. Brazzell can help stretch the field and open things up underneath for McMillan and Coker – a role Carolina didn't really have. That could matter for the offense, but it may limit his immediate fantasy ceiling, even if there's maybe some longer-term upside.



Ted Hurst • WR

 **45.6**

ZAP Score

GEORGIA STATE

FLEX PLAY

Low Risk Neutral High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height: 6'4 Weight: 206 NFL Team: Buccaneers

Statistical Comps: Josh Malone ▪ Romeo Doubs ▪ Nico Collins

Update: Ted Hurst gained a lot of steam during the pre-draft process, rising from a projected 180th overall pick in mid-January to a top-80 selection by April. He ultimately went 84th overall – a big win for a small-school prospect.

Analytically, Hurst is tough to pin down. His Breakout Score sits around 42, which is basically average, but he's a younger prospect (still under 22) with good length. He was also used aggressively downfield in college. His 28.6% career deep target rate ranks top-10 in this class, and more than 21% of his receptions came on deep throws – fourth-highest among Combine invites. That usage drove a top-10 average depth of target.

That all sounds fine, but we should keep in mind that it came against weaker competition. His best season in adjusted receiving yards per team pass attempt was just 2.08. Among 26 Day 2 wide receivers in the ZAP Model database with a mark below 2.2, only 5 have produced a best season above 10 PPR points per game within their first three years. It's not an awful hit rate when you consider context, but it's not encouraging either.

Layer in the deep-ball profile, and the risk increases. Since 2020, 22 non-first-round wide receivers have entered the league with at least 20% of their receptions coming on deep targets and a deep target rate above 25%. Only one – Nico Collins – has produced a season above 12 PPR points per game within his first three years.

At least Collins shows up as a comp!

In a class without many obvious targets, Hurst offers some intrigue. Tampa Bay wouldn't be the most ideal landing spot for fantasy, but there's a path. Mike Evans, their primary perimeter downfield threat, is gone. Chris Godwin could be out next year given his contract. Jalen McMillan has flashed, and Tez Johnson has shown something as well, but Hurst's range of outcomes includes being the best of that trio.

There's at least a scenario – and it's not the most likely one – where Hurst is earning targets behind only Emeka Egbuka for the Buccaneers by 2027.

Just don't draft him as if that outcome is guaranteed. And certainly don't draft him with the expectation that he'll have a monster 2026 campaign. You're getting him for 2027 and beyond.



Chris Bell • WR

 **42.9**

ZAP Score

LOUISVILLE

FLEX PLAY

Low Risk Neutral High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height: 6'2 Weight: 222 NFL Team: Dolphins

Statistical Comps: Jonathan Mingo ▪ JJ Arcega-Whiteside ▪ DK Metcalf

Update: Some respected draft analysts believe Chris Bell has first-round talent, and that a late-season ACL tear was the main reason he didn't get that kind of capital. The film is enticing – he's built like AJ Brown, and the upside is obvious.

Seeing him fall to Pick 94 is at least a little concerning.

That said, among the run of Round 3 wide receivers in this class, Bell offers one of the better analytical profiles. It's not elite, but his 48.2 Breakout Score lands in the 68th percentile – and it tops every other Day 2 wideout in this class.

Historically, this combination of size and Breakout Score has been boom-or-bust. In the ZAP Model database, 10 wide receivers drafted after Round 1 and before Pick 100 weighed at least 215 pounds and posted a Breakout Score between 40 and 60. That list includes Courtland Sutton, DK Metcalf, Michael Pittman, and Tee Higgins – but also Greg Little, Devin Funchess, Dorial Green-Beckham, Chase Claypool, and Jonathan Mingo.

This is a classic swing-for-the-fences profile.

Bell spent all four seasons at Louisville, with production climbing each year: 0.29, 1.00, 1.73, and 2.59 in receiving yards per team pass attempt. That steady progression – along with a tougher senior-year schedule – is doing a lot of the work in his Breakout Score.

One area of concern is how he earned his targets. Bell finished with a 57% short target rate, meaning most of his looks came within 10 yards of the line of scrimmage. At the same time, his contested target rate was in the 92nd percentile. He converted those opportunities well – his contested catch rate was in the 86th percentile – but that combination can point to separation issues. And if that's the case, you're looking at more of a Jonathan Mingo outcome than a DK Metcalf one.

The landing spot in Miami is a bit tricky. In some ways, it might've been better for Bell to land on a deeper roster, where he could ease back from the ACL and develop during his rookie year. Instead, he now may see the field relatively early with the Dolphins, despite still being somewhat of a developmental player.

Even if the ZAP score doesn't fully reflect it, Bell offers more upside than his new teammate Caleb Douglas. There's just more to work with here, even if the floor is really low.



Zavion Thomas • WR

 **40.7**

ZAP Score

LOUISIANA STATE

FLEX PLAY

Low Risk Neutral High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height: 5'10 Weight: 190 NFL Team: Bears

Statistical Comps: Jeremy Kerley ▪ Ray-Ray McCloud ▪ Isaiah Burse

Update: Zavion Thomas was one of those picks that had me doing the confused Nick Young meme. I even mentioned him on a podcast recently as an interesting late-round dart throw in rookie drafts, but never in a million years did I expect Day 2 draft capital. The only reason he came up at all was because this class lacks clear later-round wide receiver targets.

There are a couple of positives. Carnell Tate is the only receiver in this class younger than Thomas. He's not an early declare, though – he spent two seasons at Mississippi State and two more at LSU.

Thomas also brings speed and versatility. He logged 40 carries for 198 yards in college and handled 60 punt returns and 35 kick returns. That kind of usage screams gadget player – someone who can carve out a role and occasionally give you a spike week.

That's likely what Ben Johnson and the Bears had in mind. Because Thomas doesn't profile as a traditional wide receiver. He failed to register a Breakout Score despite being one of the youngest players in the class. His best season in receiving yards per team pass attempt didn't even reach 1.60 – a mark that all but five receivers in this class surpassed.

That's a tough starting point. Historically, just three wide receivers in ZAP Model history have reached 12 PPR points per game in one of their first three seasons without ever posting a Breakout Score.

The efficiency metrics don't help. Thomas posted a 1.52 career yards per route run, per PFF, the sixth-worst mark in this class. On the perimeter, he was even less effective, ranking fourth-worst among Combine invites in yards per route run.

All in all, this looks like a move by Chicago to add a player who can make things happen with the ball in his hands, but he's also one who may not have the ball very often. Especially in an offense loaded with young talent. As my friend Matt Harmon said to me after the pick was made, this could be Ben Johnson's Kalif Raymond role replacement. (Raymond is currently a Bear, for the record.)

That's a great way to view Thomas.

Despite the draft capital, Thomas is still just a dart throw. But I'm sure most fantasy gamers feel that way, so maybe he'll find himself onto some of our teams.



Elijah Sarratt • WR



40.1

ZAP Score

INDIANA

FLEX PLAY

Low Risk Neutral High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height: 6'3 Weight: 210 NFL Team: Ravens

Statistical Comps: Michael Thomas ▪ Pat Bryant ▪ Rome Odunze

Update: The Ravens took Ja'Kobi Lane on Day 2 and followed it up with Elijah Sarratt in Round 4. That's later than his projected Round 2 to Round 3 capital, so his statistical comps may look a bit more optimistic than they should.

There's a real argument that Sarratt is the better prospect, though. After beginning his career at Saint Francis as a zero-star recruit, he finished with a 51.8 Breakout Score – a 71st percentile mark and one of the stronger figures in this class.

That's largely due to his consistency. Across his three non-Saint Francis seasons – one at James Madison and two at Indiana – Sarratt posted an adjusted receiving yards per team pass attempt between 2.58 and 2.75 each year. He's one of just three receivers in this class with multiple seasons above 2.5 – and the only one to do it three times.

The efficiency metrics back it up. Sarratt had a 2.56 career yards per route run, a top-six mark in the class, and generated a first down on 12.5% of his routes, trailing only Makai Lemon.

There may be some separation concerns, though – similar to what you could argue with his new teammate, Ja'Kobi Lane. And that's highlighted in a high (95th percentile) rate of seeing contested targets.

That likely explains some of the comps, like Michael Thomas and Pat Bryant – bigger receivers who have spent time operating from the slot in the NFL. Thomas obviously became much more than that, but it's fair to wonder if Sarratt settles into a big-slot type of role.

Overall, in a class full of middling age-adjusted production profiles, Sarratt's stands out. The issue is the landing spot. Baltimore hasn't posted a positive pass rate over expected in any season since Lamar Jackson became the starter, and the target competition is just strong enough to limit Sarratt's path to volume. Just don't be surprised if Sarratt ends up being the best wide receiver from this 2026 class for the Ravens.



Reggie Virgil • WR

 **35.2**

ZAP Score

TEXAS TECH

BENCHWARMER

Low Risk Neutral High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height: 6'3 Weight: 187 NFL Team: Cardinals

Statistical Comps: Ihmir Smith-Marsette ▪ Devontez Walker ▪ Tai Felton

Update: Reggie Virgil spent three seasons at Miami (OH) before transferring to Texas Tech in 2025. The early production was minimal – just two receptions across his first two years. As a junior, though, he flashed with a 2.20 receiving yards per team pass attempt mark, leading to a respectable 40.9 Breakout Score.

The issue is that the production didn't meaningfully improve after the move to the Big 12.

Virgil has a lean frame and was used primarily as a vertical threat. Among the 46 Combine invitees, his career deep target rate and average depth of target both ranked third. That role helps explain why his first downs per route run was so low – he operated in a true boom-or-bust capacity.

From a fantasy perspective, that's concerning. Since 2020, 12 wide receivers in the ZAP Model have posted a career deep target rate above 30% alongside a first downs per route run rate below 8%. None have come close to becoming fantasy relevant.

Could Virgil buck that trend and carve out a field-stretching role? Sure. NFL teams always need players who can stretch defenses. But historically, that archetype hasn't translated into consistent fantasy production.

The landing spot doesn't help much in the short term. Marvin Harrison Jr. is locked in, Trey McBride isn't going anywhere, and Michael Wilson could still be around. Even if Wilson leaves as a free agent next year, Virgil isn't a direct replacement stylistically.

On top of that, Arizona's quarterback situation remains unsettled.

The ZAP Model doesn't mind Virgil at his draft cost, but this looks more like a depth piece than a priority target. He's someone to monitor, not someone you need to chase in rookie drafts.



Skyler Bell • WR

 **34.3**

ZAP Score

CONNECTICUT

BENCHWARMER

Low Risk **Neutral** High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height: 6'0 Weight: 192 NFL Team: Bills

Statistical Comps: Ricky Pearsall ▪ Luke McCaffrey ▪ Jaylin Lane

Update: Skyler Bell played just one game as a freshman at Wisconsin, but broke out in Year 2 with 30 receptions for 444 yards and 5 touchdowns. After a dip as a junior, he transferred to UConn.

The production improved, as expected. Over his two seasons with the Huskies, Bell posted prorated receiving yards per team pass attempt marks of 2.17 and 2.82. The issue is that UConn's strength of schedule dragged those numbers down after adjustment, and because his peak came later in his career, his Breakout Score sits at a mediocre 22.2.

Bell is slightly undersized, but he showed some flexibility by playing both inside and outside. Interestingly, his perimeter yards per route run ended up a bit stronger than his slot mark.

His 2025 season is doing a lot of the work in his profile. That 2.82 receiving yards per team pass attempt ranked top-10 in the class, and his 3.13 yards per route run was a top-five single-season mark among Combine invites.

There's also some added versatility. As a redshirt freshman at Wisconsin, Bell logged 13 carries for 160 yards. That role didn't carry over to UConn, but it points to his athletic profile – something that also shows up in a fringe top-10 yards-after-the-catch mark. That said, he wasn't especially strong at forcing missed tackles, per PFF.

Can he carve out a role in Buffalo? Entering the draft, the Bills' top wide receivers were DJ Moore, Josh Palmer, and Khalil Shakir, with Shakir operating in the slot. Bell's ability to line up everywhere gives him a path to back up multiple roles, which likely factored into the selection.

There's something to work with here. Analytically, Bell looks a bit like Ricky Pearsall – an older prospect (he's nearly 24) who offers some versatility beyond traditional receiver usage. And in this class, attaching a late rookie pick to an elite quarterback situation isn't bad process.



Brenen Thompson • WR

 **33.8**

ZAP Score

MISSISSIPPI STATE

BENCHWARMER

Low Risk Neutral High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height: 5'9 Weight: 164 NFL Team: Chargers

Statistical Comps: Tank Dell ▪ Calvin Austin ▪ JJ Nelson

Update: The ZAP Model doesn't love Brenen Thompson because he's 164 pounds and had a Breakout Score of 35.4, a 41st percentile tally. In the ZAP Model database, the only sub-180-pound wide receivers to post a 15-plus PPR points-per-game season within their first three years are first-rounders DeVonta Smith and Jordan Addison. Smaller receivers can still offer usable production – think Josh Downs or Darnell Mooney – but many of those mini-hits came with significantly stronger Breakout Scores than Thompson's.

But screw it. This is a fun player.

Thompson spent one year at Texas, two at Oklahoma, and one at Mississippi State, where he finished his college career. He didn't eclipse 250 receiving yards in a season until that final campaign, when he broke out for 57 receptions, 1,054 yards, and 6 touchdowns.

His size also shouldn't automatically remove him from consideration. Interestingly, he barely played in the slot in college, running just 12.2% of his routes there, per PFF. On only 86 slot routes, though, he posted a ridiculous 4.15 yards per route run, the highest mark in the class. It's a small sample, but it hints at some untapped deployment flexibility.

And then there's the 4.26 speed. Thompson's ability to stress defenses vertically – he posted the fifth-highest deep-ball target rate in the class – is something the Chargers will try to utilize. New offensive coordinator Mike McDaniel loves speed, and there's no doubt in my mind that he played a role in selecting Thompson.

The Chargers aren't exactly loaded at wide receiver, either. Ladd McConkey is a beast, but Quentin Johnston still has plenty of question marks attached to him, and Tre Harris didn't get a lot done as a rookie. Thompson, at least, can play the role of burner in that offense, likely in heavier wide receiver packages as a rookie.

The odds of Thompson becoming a high-volume receiver are small – just being honest. We don't see this kind of profile hit very often. But the pairing with McDaniel makes him more intriguing than he would've been elsewhere.



Bryce Lance • WR



31.3

ZAP Score

NORTH DAKOTA STATE
BENCHWARMER

Low Risk Neutral High Risk

Draft Capital Δ
Height: 6'3 Weight: 204 NFL Team: Saints
Statistical Comps: Jehu Chesson ▪ Kenny Golladay ▪ Marquez Valdes-Scantling

Update: The Saints took Jordyn Tyson in Round 1, followed it up with tight end Oscar Delp in Round 3, and then added Bryce Lance late in Round 4.

From a fit standpoint, it makes sense. Lance is a big-bodied perimeter receiver who can stretch the field and complement their existing playmakers – if he develops.

That's a big "if."

Lance spent five years at North Dakota State, redshirting as a true freshman and mostly playing special teams over the next two seasons. Through 2023, he had just one career reception. At an FCS powerhouse, he didn't see meaningful production until his fourth year on campus – after turning 23.

To his credit, the final two seasons were productive. He posted a 2.70 prorated receiving yards per team pass attempt in 2024 and followed it with a massive 4.00 mark in 2025.

But once you adjust for competition, that 4.00 drops below 2.50. And it's the only meaningful adjusted season of his career. With such a late breakout, Lance doesn't register a Breakout Score.

That's not uncommon. What *is* uncommon is becoming fantasy relevant without one. Among more than 100 wide receivers in the ZAP Model without a Breakout Score, only Hunter Renfrow, Tyreek Hill, and Terry McLaurin have posted a double-digit PPR points-per-game season within their first three years. Hill is a unicorn. McLaurin had strong draft capital. Renfrow's peak didn't last long.

Lance has traits. He's 6'3", 204 pounds and ran a 4.34 40-yard dash at the Combine.

But this is a bet on tools over production. And those bets don't hit often, even if the upside is there.

I just like this fit more from a real football perspective than a fantasy one.



Barion Brown • WR

 **30.8**

ZAP Score

LOUISIANA STATE

BENCHWARMER

Low Risk Neutral High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height: 5'11 Weight: 177 NFL Team: Saints

Statistical Comps: Jalen Cropper ▪ Bo Melton ▪ Josh Stewart

Update: The Saints kept adding weapons in this draft, selecting Barion Brown in Round 6. He's getting a profile update because the ZAP Model...oddly doesn't mind him.

Brown is fast – legitimately fast. A former track athlete, he was heavily involved as a returner across four seasons – three at Kentucky and one at LSU – and he backed up the speed with a 4.40 forty at the Combine.

All things considered, the production profile isn't terrible.

At his size and with that speed, Brown likely projects as a gadget or space-oriented receiver at the next level. Historically, those players haven't been consistent fantasy contributors.

But there's at least something here. Brown posted a 1.97 adjusted receiving yards per team pass attempt mark as a freshman – the best of his career – which helped generate a 47.6 Breakout Score (66th percentile). That's a solid number.

His collegiate usage matches the archetype. Brown ranked top-10 among Combine wide receivers in both behind-the-line and deep target rates, and about 18% of his receiving yards came on screens – also a top-10 figure in the class.

In other words, most of his touches were manufactured or came on vertical shots. That doesn't point to a refined route runner – it suggests a player offenses tried to scheme into space or send deep to create big plays.

Again...speed.

There's intrigue because that kind of athleticism is rare. But this type of wide receiver usually needs overwhelming traits to truly hit in fantasy. New Orleans clearly leaned into that idea with their Day 3 receivers, adding both Bryce Lance and Brown as potential big-play specialists.

Brown is the type of player you can take at the end of rookie drafts and stash on a taxi squad. With the ZAP Model more optimistic than his draft slot suggests, there's at least a non-zero chance he does something at the next level.



Kevin Coleman • WR

 **29.8**

ZAP Score

MISSOURI

BENCHWARMER

Low Risk Neutral High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height: 5'10 Weight: 179 NFL Team: Dolphins

Statistical Comps: Joe Adams ▪ Richie James ▪ Diontae Johnson

Update: Given their depth chart, the Dolphins needed to add at wide receiver in this draft. They took two on Day 2 and then grabbed Kevin Coleman, a wideout who played for four different schools throughout his collegiate career, in Round 5.

Coleman is a true slot receiver. Over 91% of his career routes came from the slot – the highest rate in this class. And it wasn't scheme-driven. Across four different programs, he posted slot rates of at least 87% at every stop, per PFF.

His best season came at Mississippi State. As a junior, he posted a 2.53 receiving yards per team pass attempt mark, which jumped to 2.86 after adjusting for strength of schedule. That led to a 48.2 Breakout Score, seventh-best in the class.

The heavy slot usage is the concern. Since 2020, receivers entering the league with a slot rate of at least 90% include KJ Hamler, KJ Hill, Dazz Newsome, Jaelon Darden, Kyle Philips, Derius Davis, Tre Tucker, Malachi Corley, and Jimmy Horn. Like Coleman, that group generally lacked strong draft capital – and it shows in the results.

Coleman doesn't overlap much with Miami's earlier picks. Caleb Douglas and Chris Bell project more as perimeter options, while Coleman likely fills a dedicated slot role. That probably gives him the safest projection of the trio, even if Bell carries the higher ceiling.

It comes down to preference. In the later rounds of rookie drafts, are you chasing safety or upside? In deeper formats, Coleman makes more sense as a dart. In standard dynasty leagues, he's not a priority target.



Kaden Wetjen • WR

 **27.9**

ZAP Score

IOWA

WAIVER WIRE ADD

Low Risk Neutral High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height: 5'9 Weight: 193 NFL Team: Steelers

Statistical Comps: Kaelin Clay ▪ Marcus Green ▪ Johnnie Dixon

Update: According to NFL Mock Draft Database, the Steelers selected Kaden Wetjen about 100 picks earlier than expected. That's kind of been the theme of this draft.

They didn't take Wetjen for traditional wide receiver production – or at least, they shouldn't have. He caught just 23 passes across three seasons at Iowa, and more than 54% of his targets came behind the line of scrimmage. The goal was simple for his coaches in college: get Wetjen the ball in space and let him create.

The production metrics are rough. Wetjen owns the second-lowest best-season adjusted receiving yards per team pass attempt in the ZAP Model database. His best-season adjusted fantasy points per game also ranks in the bottom two – out of hundreds and hundreds of wide receivers.

Unsurprisingly, Wetjen left school without a Breakout Score.

This was almost certainly a special teams-driven pick. Wetjen returned 56 kicks and 54 punts at Iowa – after starting his career at Iowa Western Community College – and won the 2024 Jet Award as the nation's top return specialist.

To his credit, he reportedly impressed at the Shrine Bowl, and Iowa's offense hasn't exactly been a pass-heavy environment. But historically, when receiving production is this limited, the odds of translating to fantasy relevance are extremely low.



Colbie Young • WR

 **26.5**

ZAP Score

GEORGIA

WAIVER WIRE ADD

Low Risk Neutral High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height: 6'5 Weight: 218 NFL Team: Bengals

Statistical Comps: Marcell Ateman ▪ Jamal Custis ▪ Bryce Ford-Wheaton

Update: Only six wide receivers in the ZAP Model database have averaged at least 14 PPR points per game in one of their first three seasons after being drafted outside the top 100: Allen Hurns, Martavis Bryant, Tyreek Hill, Hunter Renfrow, Amon-Ra St. Brown, and Puka Nacua.

That's rare air.

And there's no consistent size archetype among them. So while Colbie Young checking in at 6'5", 218 pounds may have appealed to Cincinnati, it doesn't really move the needle for fantasy.

Young ends up as a Day 3 pick out of Georgia, where he spent two seasons after stops at Miami and Lackawanna College.

Across five years, the production never truly materialized. Even at Lackawanna, he posted just a 1.68 prorated receiving yards per team pass attempt mark as a freshman – a number that fades even further once adjusted for competition.

His best adjusted season came last year, also at 1.68, when he was nearly 23 years old. Because of the late production and modest efficiency, he never registered a Breakout Score.

There are a few intriguing traits. Young posted elevated deep-ball and behind-the-line target rates, suggesting teams were trying to manufacture touches. He also forced missed tackles at an above-average clip, hinting at some ability after the catch.

But zooming out, this is a long-shot profile. Day 3 receivers without meaningful production or a Breakout Score rarely become fantasy difference-makers. And with Ja'Marr Chase and Tee Higgins ahead of him, there's almost no path to short-term volume.



Kendrick Law • WR

 **26.3**

ZAP Score

KENTUCKY

WAIVER WIRE ADD

Low Risk Neutral High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height: 5'11 Weight: 203 NFL Team: Lions

Statistical Comps: Kaelin Clay ▪ Juwann Winfree ▪ Chris Moore

The ZAP Model isn't fond of Kendrick Law. He failed to register a Breakout Score, and he's not expected to go early in the draft.

But his profile is undeniably unique.

Law spent three seasons at Alabama doing very little as a receiver – just 33 total catches and no meaningful efficiency spike. He transferred to Kentucky in 2025 and had his most productive year, catching 53 passes for 540 yards. That translated to a 1.47 receiving yards per team pass attempt mark, the fourth-worst top season in this class.

So why is he even interesting?

Because stylistically, he's a bruiser. Law forced 0.35 missed tackles per reception – the best rate among Combine invites. Nearly half of his targets (49.5%) came behind the line of scrimmage, per PFF, the second-highest rate in the class. Roughly 44% of his career receiving yards came on screens, and his average depth of target was the lowest in this year's group.

This was a manufactured-touch profile through and through.

There's a world where an NFL team leans into that and deploys Law as a gadget weapon. And that kind of role can do something in real football.

Fantasy is another story.

Since 2020, the only ZAP Model receivers with 25% or more of their yards coming from screens are Lynn Bowden, Anthony Schwartz, Derius Davis, and Malachi Corley. Remember, Law was at nearly 50%. That's not exactly a list of league-winners.

Still, there are a few of these quirky, gadget-leaning profiles in this class, and Law could realistically become the best value of that bunch. If he lands in a creative offense and earns early manufactured touches, there's at least some theoretical upside at a cheap rookie draft cost.

Just understand what you're buying. This is a scheme-dependent bet.



Emmanuel Henderson • WR

 **23.6**

ZAP Score

KANSAS

WAIVER WIRE ADD

Low Risk Neutral High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height: 6'1 Weight: 185 NFL Team: Seahawks

Statistical Comps: Josh Harper ▪ James Quick ▪ Ja'Corey Brooks

Among the 46 wide receivers invited to this year's NFL Combine, Emmanuel Henderson ranked second with a 40.5% career deep-ball target rate. He was also fourth in collegiate average depth of target.

What's interesting is that Henderson wasn't strictly a boundary-only player. He ran about 36% of his routes from the slot, which is a fairly healthy rate for someone with that kind of downfield profile.

Henderson's college path took him to Alabama for three seasons before transferring to Kansas for his final year. At Alabama, there was essentially no meaningful receiving production – he caught just five passes across three seasons. His final year there resulted in an adjusted receiving yards per team pass attempt rate of 0.28.

Kansas is where things finally clicked. In 2025, he caught 45 passes for 766 yards and 5 touchdowns, posting a 2.39 adjusted receiving yards per team pass attempt. That was enough to get him on the board with a Breakout Score, but it was just 21.1.

So we've got one productive season, and it came late.

Henderson also contributed in the return game, bringing back 18 kicks for 455 yards and a touchdown in his final season. That special teams juice could play a role in NFL outlook.

But from a fantasy perspective, this is a historically fragile archetype. Since 2020, 17 wide receivers have entered the league with a deep-ball target rate of 35% or higher. Henderson was north of 40%. None of those 17 averaged 10 or more PPR points per game in one of their first three seasons.

When a player's offensive profile is heavily tilted toward vertical shots, it usually signals a limited route tree and volatile usage.

Henderson could carve out a role as a speed-based rotational receiver and special teams contributor. That can absolutely help an NFL team. Fantasy managers, though, shouldn't expect much beyond the occasional splash play.



Eric McAlister • WR

 **22.0**

ZAP Score

TEXAS CHRISTIAN

WAIVER WIRE ADD

Low Risk Neutral High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height: 6'4 Weight: 194 NFL Team: Undrafted

Statistical Comps: Tory Horton ▪ Cedrick Wilson ▪ Ricky White

Texas Christian wide receivers haven't exactly inspired confidence lately. Since 2020, we've seen Jalen Reagor, Derius Davis, Quentin Johnston, Savion Williams, and Jack Bech enter the league from there. There's a very real chance none of them ultimately outperform their draft-capital-based B2S expectation.

Eric McAlister could be next up in late April's draft. Interestingly, though, he owns the second-best Breakout Score of that group, trailing only Quentin Johnston. And just barely – Johnston posted a 76.6, McAlister sits at 75.0.

McAlister actually has the second-best Breakout Score in this entire class.

That's either exciting...or mildly terrifying.

Breakout Score is predictive, especially in the earlier portions of the draft. But once you move into the Day 3 range, chaos tends to take over. Draft capital itself barely matters after Pick 170 or 180.

McAlister's Breakout Score is impressive. It would just be more impressive if he were projected inside the top 100 picks instead of Round 5 or 6.

How did McAlister get there? Well, he spent two seasons at Boise State before transferring to TCU for his final two years. As a sophomore at Boise, he caught 47 passes for 873 yards and 5 touchdowns in just nine games. That prorated to a massive 3.56 adjusted receiving yards per team pass attempt (3.65 raw), which supercharged his Breakout Score.

McAlister never quite reached that level again, but his final-season adjusted receiving yards per team pass attempt of 2.78 was still strong – it would rank 10th in this class.

Historically, Day 3 receivers with strong Breakout Scores have at least offered mild optimism. Among 230-plus wideouts drafted after Pick 100 from 2011 through 2023 (that gives them three-year NFL samples), only 25 posted a Breakout Score above 60. That group outperformed its draft-capital-based B2S expectation by 1.8 PPR points per game. The rest, predictably, underperformed.

The odds of McAlister becoming a long-term fantasy staple are slim. Day 3 receivers always face steep odds. But if you're taking swings late in rookie drafts, betting on strong underlying production is rarely the wrong way to do it.



CJ Daniels • WR

 **20.8**

ZAP Score

MIAMI (FL)

WAIVER WIRE ADD

Low Risk Neutral High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height: 6'2 Weight: 202 NFL Team: Rams

Statistical Comps: Dez Fitzpatrick ▪ Jalen Tolbert ▪ Chimere Dike

My three-year-old son's favorite wide receiver in this class is CJ Daniels. And that's strictly because my son's name is CJ.

The ZAP Model does not share his enthusiasm.

Daniels' College Football Reference page reads like a 700-page novel. He spent four years at Liberty, where his only truly meaningful production came in Year 4. That season was legitimately impressive: a 3.14 adjusted receiving yards per team pass attempt mark – the fourth-best max-season number in this class – which helped fuel a strong 47.3 Breakout Score.

The issue? Every other season he played was below 1.70 in that metric.

After Liberty, Daniels transferred to LSU for a year, then finished at Miami. That's six collegiate seasons. He'll be 24 when the draft rolls around.

Late breakouts can work, but they usually need draft capital support. In the ZAP Model database, 32 wide receivers failed to go top-100 while posting a Breakout Score below 60 but a best-season adjusted receiving yards per team pass attempt above 3.0. In other words, they had one monster efficiency year, but age suppressed the overall breakout profile.

Of those 32 players, 30 never even reached 7 PPR points per game in any of their first three seasons.

Then there's the age bucket itself. Prior to this class, 35 wide receivers entered the league at age 24 or older. Only one – John Brown – produced a 10-plus PPR points-per-game season within his first three years. Brown also had top-100 draft capital, something Daniels isn't likely to receive.

Now, could the model be a little too mean towards older prospects given the NIL era, transfer portal freedom, and COVID eligibility ripple effects? That's fair to consider. College football has changed.

But it's also fair to acknowledge that Daniels really only gave us one high-end season across six years.

There's juice in that peak campaign. But the rest of the profile is just thin.



Malik Benson • WR

 **20.6**

ZAP Score

OREGON

WAIVER WIRE ADD

Low Risk Neutral High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height: 6'0 Weight: 189 NFL Team: Raiders

Statistical Comps: Michael Rector ▪ Braylon Sanders ▪ Jon'Vea Johnson

Malik Benson can absolutely run. The former track athlete clocked a 4.37 40 at the Combine, and when you watch him, the vertical juice is obvious. He's built to threaten defenses over the top.

The path to this point, though, has been anything but linear. Benson spent two seasons in JUCO before landing at Alabama in 2023, where he caught just 13 passes across 14 games. That led to a transfer to Florida State, where he managed only 25 receptions. He then finished his career at Oregon in 2025, his fourth college stop.

That final season was technically his most productive, but even then, his adjusted receiving yards per team pass attempt peaked at just 1.88. That's a bottom-10 mark in this class.

Deployment helps explain some of it. Over his final three non-JUCO seasons, Benson posted a 25.6% deep-ball target rate, 11th-highest in the class. He was used as a field-stretcher. The problem is that he was rarely featured. He never reached even a 15% prorated target share in any season, the third-worst rate among Combine invite wide receivers.

So what we're looking at is a 23-and-a-half-year-old prospect with plus speed, minimal target-earning ability, and no season that truly stands out from a production standpoint.

The athleticism gives him a puncher's chance. But analytically, this is a thin profile. It's tough to get overly optimistic without meaningful draft capital to force opportunity.



Josh Cameron • WR

 **20.3**

ZAP Score

BAYLOR

WAIVER WIRE ADD

Low Risk Neutral High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height: 6'2 Weight: 220 NFL Team: Jaguars

Statistical Comps: Travis Fulgham ▪ Amara Darboh ▪ Michael Wilson

Josh Cameron often looks like a running back playing wide receiver. He's got a thick, sturdy build, and Baylor leaned into that across his five seasons there. He wasn't used out of the backfield much, but he also wasn't asked to win deep – his career deep-ball target rate was the second-lowest in this class. His average depth of target sat a bit higher because he lived in that intermediate range.

Cameron is more of a traits bet than a production one. He'll be past his 23rd birthday at draft time, and he had five seasons to post a truly strong receiving yards per team pass attempt mark. It never happened. His best adjusted season came in at 1.90, and that translated to a 28.1 Breakout Score – just 30th percentile in the model.

The ZAP Model isn't overly enthusiastic. But one input does quietly like him: adjusted fantasy points per game. Among the 46 Combine invite wideouts, Cameron ranks 15th in that metric after age and schedule adjustments. That at least tells us he wasn't *totally* unproductive.

There are some interesting attributes here – size, play strength, and a profile that suggests he can handle physical work over the middle. Cameron just never showed high-end dominance.

Cameron is the type of player who could hang around as a depth receiver and surprise if things break right. But unless the draft really swings in his favor, he's not someone you need to aggressively prioritize in rookie drafts.



Dillon Bell • WR



17.2

ZAP Score

GEORGIA
DART THROW

Low Risk Neutral High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height: 6'1 Weight: 209 NFL Team: Undrafted

Statistical Comps: Deondre Douglas ▪ Keon Hatcher ▪ Zach Pascal

The ZAP Model database now has six wide receivers with the last name Bell. Three of them are in this 2026 class.

That's analytics.

Dillon Bell is generally viewed as the least exciting of the trio. He spent four seasons at Georgia – which is never a bad line on the résumé – but he never topped 466 receiving yards in a season. His best-year receiving yards per team pass attempt was under 1.0. Before this cycle, the ZAP Model had seen only nine wide receivers with a max-season mark that low. The only player even remotely relevant in fantasy was Russell Gage.

That's tough company.

Where Bell gets interesting is in the versatility bucket. Like several others in this class, he was used as a Swiss Army knife in college. Unlike many of them, he brings legitimate size to the table.

At Georgia, Bell logged 51 carries for 373 yards and 5 touchdowns. His usage lines up with that profile – he had one of the lower average depths of target in the class, and 18.4% of his collegiate receiving yards came on screens, sixth-highest among Combine-invited wide receivers.

You'll probably hear Deebo Samuel comparisons tossed around with Bell. Archetype-wise, it's understandable. But Samuel entered the league with far stronger receiving production, and he had premium draft capital. Bell would need both opportunity and development to align perfectly to approach that kind of NFL impact.

Bell's not devoid of intrigue. Big, versatile players with backfield utility always catch attention.

But analytically, this is a long runway bet.



Harrison Wallace • WR



14.4

ZAP Score

MISSISSIPPI

DART THROW

Low Risk Neutral High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height: 6'0	Weight: 192	NFL Team: Undrafted
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Statistical Comps: Tony Jones ▪ Malik Knowles ▪ Cam Phillips

It's tough to find an analytical hook in Harrison Wallace's profile that screams upside. His Breakout Score sits below 30, he'll already be 23 by draft day, his career yards per route run is just 1.86, and his best adjusted fantasy points per game season topped out at 12.7. He gained a first down on only 8.9% of his routes – an ordinary rate – and he doesn't bring overwhelming size to compensate.

Across the board, it's hard to build a strong fantasy case.

Wallace spent four years at Penn State before transferring to Ole Miss for his final season. He didn't clear 300 receiving yards in any of his first three seasons with the Nittany Lions, and while his final two years produced adjusted receiving yards per team pass attempt marks of 2.00 and 1.96, those are more "fine" than impactful. Just 14% of his routes came out of the slot, so he was mostly deployed as a perimeter guy.

But there's just not much separation in the data – literally or figuratively.

Wallace *might* hear his name called late in the draft, but even if he does, the profile suggests a depth receiver fighting for a roster spot rather than someone likely to matter in fantasy formats.



Vinny Anthony • WR



10.4

ZAP Score

WISCONSIN
DART THROW

Low Risk Neutral High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height: 6'0 Weight: 183 NFL Team: Undrafted

Statistical Comps: James Quick ▪ Jarrod West ▪ Tyron Johnson

Vinny Anthony spent four years at Wisconsin and topped 400 receiving yards in just one of them. That junior-season spike was enough to get him to a 33.5 Breakout Score, but that's about where the optimism peaks.

From there, the profile gets shaky.

Anthony's best single-season yards per route run mark was a respectable 2.29, but the consistency and drive-ending impact just weren't there. Anthony gained a first down on only 6.4% of his routes in college, the fourth-worst rate in this year's class.

Historically, that's a major red flag.

Since 2020, the ZAP Model has logged 32 wide receivers drafted outside the top 100 with first downs per route run rates below 7%. Not one of them reached 10 PPR points per game in one of their first three seasons. In fact, all but two failed to even hit 3.0 PPR points per game.

You can get that kind of production off the waiver wire. Even in dynasty leagues.

Anthony could carve out a depth role, but from a fantasy perspective, the odds of him becoming someone you're confidently starting on Sundays are extremely slim.



Aaron Anderson • WR



9.6

ZAP Score

LOUISIANA STATE

DART THROW

Low Risk Neutral High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height: 5'8 Weight: 191 NFL Team: Undrafted

Statistical Comps: Braxton Berrios ▪ Tommy Shuler ▪ Bralon Addison

There are four LSU wide receivers at the NFL Combine this year, but all of them are projected to go on Day 3 – including Aaron Anderson.

Anderson began his career at Alabama, redshirting as a freshman before transferring to LSU. He then spent three seasons in Baton Rouge, where his production profile settled in as below average. His best adjusted receiving yards per team pass attempt was 1.88, which translated to a 25.5 Breakout Score.

That's not moving the needle much analytically.

To his credit, Anderson posted the best yards per route run figures among the LSU wideouts in this class. His 2.07 career yards per route run is slightly above the class average among Combine invites. But that efficiency came almost entirely from the slot – he ran over 88% of his routes from there, the second-highest slot rate in the class.

That archetype hasn't treated us well recently.

Since 2020, there have been 12 wide receivers in the ZAP Model database with a Breakout Score below 40 and a career slot rate above 80%. None of them have reached 10 PPR points per game in one of their first three seasons. And two of those players were top-100 picks. Anderson likely won't get that kind of draft capital boost.

It's hard to see a clear path to fantasy relevance here. Anderson could carve out a depth role as a slot specialist, but from a rookie draft perspective, this isn't a profile you need to prioritize.



Jordan Hudson • WR



9.0

ZAP Score

SOUTHERN METHODIST
DART THROW

Low Risk Neutral High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height: 6'1 Weight: 191 NFL Team: Undrafted

Statistical Comps: Drew Morgan ▪ Levi Norwood ▪ James Quick

Jordan Hudson was a highly recruited prospect who chose Texas Christian out of high school. He spent the 2022 season at TCU alongside a group that included NFLers Quentin Johnston, Derius Davis, Savion Williams, Jared Wiley, and Kendre Miller before transferring to SMU, where he played three seasons.

The production at SMU was... fine. Nothing more.

Hudson's receiving yards per team pass attempt cleared 1.0 just once, and that came in 2025, his final year. He technically registered a Breakout Score, but it landed at just 27.8, well below where you'd want it for someone you're hoping can outkick Day 3 draft capital.

There aren't many standout traits in Hudson's profile. His first downs per route run were slightly above the class average, and his 1.93 career yards per route run is respectable enough for a likely late-round pick. But dig a little deeper and you see the imbalance: his perimeter yards per route run was just 1.77, while his slot yards per route run was a strong 2.94, sixth-best in the class.

Oddly, he barely played in the slot. Only about 14% of his collegiate routes came from that alignment. If an NFL team leans into that more heavily, maybe there's something to unlock. He was also slightly above average in missed tackles forced per reception, which at least hints at some after-the-catch juice.

As it stands, though, he projects more like a traditional boundary receiver without the boundary-dominant efficiency you'd want to see. And for late-round bets, you usually want at least one clear, bankable trait.

Hudson's profile just doesn't offer that hook.



Jalen Walthall • WR



8.9

ZAP Score

INCARNATE WORD
DART THROW

Low Risk Neutral High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height: 6'1 Weight: 191 NFL Team: Undrafted

Statistical Comps: Tyson Johnson ▪ Alex Wesley ▪ Jon'Vea Johnson

No player in the ZAP Model database had come from Incarnate Word. Until now with Jalen Walthall. That's where he spent two of his four collegiate seasons.

The other two? Hawaii.

What a wild, wild collegiate journey for a player looking to be drafted to the NFL.

At Hawaii, Walthall's production never got off the ground. As a freshman and sophomore, he posted sub-1.0 prorated receiving yards per team pass attempt rates. He appeared in just five games during his second year, but even on a full-season pace, the numbers weren't trending toward anything meaningful.

Walthall then transferred to Incarnate Word, where the level of competition dipped. Even there, though, his best receiving yards per team pass attempt rate topped out at 2.39. And once that was adjusted for strength of opponent, it wasn't enough to earn a Breakout Score.

That's a major hurdle.

In the ZAP Model database, 61 wide receivers have posted a sub-1.5 best-season adjusted receiving yards per team pass attempt rate. Walthall falls into that group. Of those 61, only Tyreek Hill and Hunter Renfrow managed to score more than 12 PPR points per game in one of their first three seasons.

Hill, as you've read in other blurbs, had elite speed and rushing production to buoy his profile. Renfrow's peak was modest and short-lived.

The odds are overwhelmingly against this turning into something meaningful for fantasy. Walthall's path has been unique, but analytically, it's a long shot bet.



Eric Rivers • WR



8.0

ZAP Score

GEORGIA TECH
DART THROW

Low Risk Neutral High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height: 5'10 Weight: 176 NFL Team: Undrafted

Statistical Comps: Daniel Braverman ▪ Jalen Nailor ▪ Terry Godwin

Eric Rivers owns the second-best single-season yards per route run mark in this class. Seriously. His career yards per route run sits at 2.40 – eighth-best among Combine invite wide receivers.

So... do we have something here?

Probably not.

Rivers will turn 24 in September, putting him on the older side of the prospect spectrum. He played two years at Memphis with minimal production, transferred to Florida International for two more, and then finished at Georgia Tech. That eye-popping 3.57 yards per route run season came in his second year at FIU. The seasons surrounding it? 1.32 and 2.07.

One of those years is not like the others.

That outlier campaign was strong enough to earn him a 32.8 Breakout Score, which isn't nothing for a projected Day 3 pick. But it's not particularly impressive either – especially for a 176-pound receiver.

We saw a ceiling season, sure. But it came at FIU, not exactly against elite competition. When you zoom out, this looks more like a one-year spike than a sustainably dominant profile.



Jeff Caldwell • WR



7.4

ZAP Score

CINCINNATI

DART THROW

Low Risk Neutral High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height: 6'5	Weight: 216	NFL Team: Undrafted
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Statistical Comps: Da'Quan Felton ▪ Marcell Ateman ▪ Tyre Brady

Jeff Caldwell might be the biggest size-speed outlier in this entire class. He's 6'5", 216 pounds, and ran a 4.31 at the Combine. On top of that, he posted the second-best broad jump and vertical among wide receiver invitees. That's absurd movement at that frame.

Those testing numbers probably shifted him from fringe-undrafted territory into "someone will take a shot" range.

But Caldwell's outlook is almost entirely traits-based.

Caldwell began his career at Lindenwood in 2022, and he stayed there for three seasons. On the surface, a 3.24 receiving yards per team pass attempt mark in 2024 looks impressive. Once adjusted for strength of competition, though, it falls below 2.0. We have to always remember that raw dominance at a lower level doesn't carry the same signal.

Caldwell transferred to Cincinnati for his final season and finished with 32 catches for 478 yards and 6 touchdowns. His 1.31 receiving yards per team pass attempt there didn't move the needle analytically.

The result is a 29th percentile Breakout Score and a best-season adjusted receiving yards per team pass attempt of 1.94. That's not the kind of production profile that typically overcomes mid-to-late-round draft capital.

However, there's no denying the athletic profile. Caldwell's one of the best athletes we've seen come out of the Combine. It's rare. But historically, betting on testing without meaningful, translatable production is tough.

Unless draft capital comes in far stronger than expected, Caldwell is more of a last-round rookie draft dart throw than someone you need to prioritize.



Chase Roberts • WR



6.6

ZAP Score

BRIGHAM YOUNG

DART THROW

Low Risk Neutral High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height: 6'3 Weight: 209 NFL Team: Undrafted

Statistical Comps: Andrei Iosivas ▪ J'Mon Moore ▪ Javon Wims

The last time a BYU wide receiver was drafted was 2023. You might've heard of him – Puka Nacua.

Those are pretty large shoes to fill for Chase Roberts.

Let's be clear, though: Roberts is almost certainly not the next Nacua.

For starters, he'll be 25 at draft time. In ZAP Model history, only four wide receivers have entered the league at 25 or older. The most notable recent example is Devaughn Vele – and even that's more “solid depth piece” than fantasy cornerstone.

Like Vele, Roberts is older largely because of a mission trip out of high school, which delayed his collegiate timeline. That context is important to know, but age still feeds directly into the model. Because of it, Roberts didn't register a Breakout Score. If we pretend he entered college immediately and was 23 instead of 25, his Breakout Score would've been 30.9, which isn't *amazing* anyway.

At BYU, Roberts improved each season, peaking at a 2.39 adjusted receiving yards per team pass attempt mark in 2025. He was a reliable presence in the offense, finishing with the sixth-highest first downs per route run rate in this class.

Roberts has solid size and played both inside and outside in college. Most impressively, his perimeter yards per route run was 2.61 – fifth-best in the class. That's not nothing.

The age is what drags this profile down more than anything else. Without it, Roberts would still be more “interesting Day 3 flier” than priority target, but there'd be less friction.



Donaven McCulley • WR



6.3

ZAP Score

MICHIGAN

DART THROW

Low Risk Neutral High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height: 6'5	Weight: 203	NFL Team: Undrafted
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Statistical Comps: Michael Jefferson ▪ Alonzo Russell ▪ Binjimen Victor

Donaven McCulley's path to wide receiver is one of the more unique ones in this class.

McCulley arrived at Indiana in 2021 as a quarterback. That experiment didn't last long – he completed just 35 of 82 pass attempts as a freshman before making the switch to wide receiver. Per a USA Today piece, McCulley noted that he'd grown taller and always had good hands, so he made the switch. The athleticism was obvious. The position just needed to change.

Year 2, his first as a receiver, was understandably quiet. But in Year 3, we saw real progress: 48 receptions for 644 yards and a 1.91 adjusted receiving yards per team pass attempt mark. For a converted quarterback, that's respectable.

After appearing in just four games for Indiana in 2024, McCulley transferred to Michigan to close out his career. He slightly edged his previous efficiency mark, improving his adjusted receiving yards per team pass attempt by 0.02.

According to Rich Hribar of Sharp Football Analysis, no wide receiver in this draft class had a higher uncatchable target rate than McCulley. That likely suppressed his counting stats and may have capped what could've been a slightly better Breakout Score (he finished at 34.8).

At 6'5" with legitimate athletic traits, there's clearly clay to mold here. The issue is that the underlying efficiency never truly popped. His career yards per route run sits at 1.56. And that wasn't meaningfully better on the perimeter, where he's almost certainly destined to line up in the NFL.

It's a fun story and an intriguing athletic bet. A team could absolutely take a late-round swing on the size and developmental upside.

But from a fantasy perspective, this is still a long-range projection rather than a profile built on proven production.



Chris Hilton • WR



5.6

ZAP Score

LOUISIANA STATE

DART THROW

Low Risk Neutral High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height: 6'0 Weight: 188 NFL Team: Undrafted

Statistical Comps: Braylon Sanders ▪ Damian Copeland ▪ Tyron Johnson

All four LSU wide receivers invited to this year's Combine checked in under 200 pounds – Aaron Anderson was the heaviest at just 191. Chris Hilton fits the mold, and with that lighter frame came good speed. He ran a 4.41 40-yard dash, which is a strong time.

That's about where the positives taper off.

Hilton spent five seasons at LSU – credit to him for staying put in the portal era – but he never topped 250 receiving yards in a single year. As you'd expect, that means he failed to register a Breakout Score.

Hilton's role was extremely narrow. Per PFF, over 42% of his targets came on deep-ball throws, the highest rate in this class. He was essentially a lid-lifter. The problem is that he was rarely a focal point. He never reached a double-digit prorated target share in any season, giving him the lowest best-season target share among Combine invite wide receivers.

When you combine the lack of volume, the one-dimensional usage, and the absence of any meaningful production, you're left with a very rough fantasy projection.

LSU's receiver room has been great in recent years, so that context is important to know. But projecting that profile forward – into a league where the competition only gets tougher – makes it difficult to see a path to consistent fantasy relevance.



Deion Burks • WR



4.9

ZAP Score

OKLAHOMA

DART THROW

Low Risk Neutral High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height: 5'10 Weight: 180 NFL Team: Colts

Statistical Comps: Hunter Renfrow ▪ Travis Benjamin ▪ TJ Graham

Projected draft capital is doing heavy lifting in Deion Burks' profile, because the production doesn't stand out.

Burks spent three seasons at Purdue before transferring to Oklahoma for two more. Across that five-year career, his adjusted receiving yards per team pass attempt never reached 2.0. He did manage a 34.6 Breakout Score, but that's more middling than encouraging.

The deeper efficiency numbers are even tougher. Burks posted a 1.35 career yards per route run rate, third-worst in this class. Since 2020, the ZAP Model has tracked 24 wide receivers entering the league with career yards per route run below 1.50. The only one to provide any meaningful fantasy production from that group is Josh Palmer. And are we even rostering him in dynasty at this point?

Burks' deployment adds another layer of uncertainty. In two of his seasons, he ran over 85% of his routes from the slot. In two others, he was below 25%. Given his smaller frame, the slot feels like the probable NFL home.

That's where things get even more concerning. His slot yards per route run sits at just 1.14 – bottom-six in this class.

There's not much analytical support here. If Burks sneaks into Day 2, that will be the primary argument in his favor. Otherwise, he profiles as a late-round rookie draft flier. And even then, there may be stronger bets on the board.



Caullin Lacy • WR



3.0

ZAP Score

LOUISVILLE

DART THROW

Low Risk Neutral High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height: 5'9	Weight: 183	NFL Team: Undrafted
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Statistical Comps: Isaiah Williams ▪ Tayvion Robinson ▪ Trent Taylor

Caullin Lacy measured in at 5'9", 183 pounds at the Combine and ran a 4.55 40. That translated to a 14th percentile Speed Score. In a wide receiver class loaded with high-end testers, that kind of number is going to hurt him on NFL boards.

The saving grace is that, for someone this low in the ZAP Model, the production profile isn't a total disaster.

It's just not especially inspiring, either.

Lacy will turn 25 in December, making him one of the older prospects in the class. That's the byproduct of six collegiate seasons – four at South Alabama and two at Louisville. Not ideal.

To Lacy's credit, he did post a legitimate ceiling season. In 2023, he recorded a 3.33 receiving yards per team pass attempt rate. Even after strength-of-schedule adjustments, that number remained strong – his adjusted mark ranks sixth-best in the class.

The issue is the broader context. At his size, Lacy operated primarily from the slot, with over 74% of his routes coming from that alignment. And despite the volume and role, his career slot yards per route run stayed under 2.0. That's not the type of efficiency you'd like to see from a smaller, slot-heavy receiver who isn't bringing plus speed to the table.

When you combine the age, average athleticism, and middling efficiency, you're left with a fairly low-ceiling projection for fantasy. He could stick as depth or as a role player if things break right.

But from a rookie draft perspective, Lacy's not someone you need to prioritize.



J. Michael Sturdivant • WR



1.6

ZAP Score

FLORIDA

DART THROW

Low Risk Neutral High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height: 6'3	Weight: 207	NFL Team: Undrafted
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Statistical Comps: Cayleb Jones ▪ Michael Bennett ▪ Traeshon Holden

We actually did see a flicker of early-career promise from J. Michael Sturdivant, the least user-friendly database name in the class (if you know, you know).

Sturdivant began at Cal, and in his second season there, he posted an adjusted receiving yards per team pass attempt mark that barely missed the (low) Breakout Score threshold. Unfortunately, that ended up being the high point of his collegiate journey in that metric, so he never officially recorded a Breakout Score.

After Cal, Sturdivant transferred to UCLA for two seasons and then finished at Florida. The cumulative profile is rough: a career 1.40 yards per route run, fourth-worst in this class. Over the last five years, no wide receiver in the ZAP Model database with a sub-1.50 career yards per route run and no Breakout Score has produced more than 6.0 PPR points per game in a season.

There are legitimate physical tools. At 6'3", 207 pounds, Sturdivant ran a 4.40 40-yard dash. His Speed Score is excellent, and his broad and vertical jumps were strong as well. On paper, that's a really appealing athletic foundation.

If those measurables belonged to a 21-year-old prospect, you could talk yourself into a developmental upside case. But Sturdivant will be over 23-and-a-half at draft time. At that age, with that age-adjusted production, it's a difficult sell.

The physical tools are there. The track record isn't. And historically, that combination – especially for an older prospect – hasn't led to fantasy relevance.

Running Back



Legendary Performer

Jeremiyah Love..... 83



Weekly Starter

Jadarian Price..... 84



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Jeremiyah Love • RB

 **97.6**

ZAP Score

NOTRE DAME

LEGENDARY PERFORMER

Low Risk Neutral High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height: 6'0 Weight: 212 NFL Team: Cardinals

Statistical Comps: Bijan Robinson ▪ Ezekiel Elliott ▪ Melvin Gordon

Update: We won't get into the real-life ramifications of Arizona taking Jeremiyah Love third overall – this is a fantasy football guide. (But, man, that's not what I would've done with that roster.)

Love, as a player, is the truth. There aren't really any red flags in his profile. His top-season prorated reception share of 12.4% could be better, but it still lands in the 65th percentile among ZAP Model running backs. His adjusted total yards per team play ranks in the 94th percentile, while his adjusted receiving yards per team pass attempt sits in the 83rd.

Non-ZAP metrics like him, too. Love posted an 88th percentile career avoided tackles per attempt rate, and his yards after contact per rush, per PFF, ranked in the 96th percentile.

Given his draft capital, Love's ZAP score is beyond elite. Nearly every player to hit 97 or higher in the model's history has averaged at least 17 PPR points per game in one of their first three seasons – the lone exception is Ashton Jeanty, who's only played one NFL season.

The situation in Arizona won't make you jump for joy, but it's workable. The Cardinals are now coached by Mike LaFleur, a Shanahan-tree play-caller – he's no stranger to an efficient run game. The offense may struggle until they find their quarterback, but even in what looked like a crowded backfield entering the draft, Love should see volume right away – especially as a receiver.

There's just no doubt: Love is the 1.01 in any normal rookie draft format. Don't overthink it.



Jadarian Price • RB

 **69.3**

ZAP Score

NOTRE DAME

WEEKLY STARTER

Low Risk Neutral High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height: 5'11 Weight: 203 NFL Team: Seahawks

Statistical Comps: Ronald Jones ▪ Jordan Scarlett ▪ Darrynton Evans

Update: Jadarian Price isn't going to look great in any analytical prospect model. He played behind Jeremiyah Love in college, so his production profile is heavily suppressed – like, really suppressed.

Price finished with a best-season reception share of just 2.8%. In ZAP Model history, 18 backs have fallen below the 3% threshold, and none became fantasy-relevant. Even if you expand that to backs below 5%, there are 46 of them, and only Derrick Henry produced a double-digit PPR points-per-game season within his first three years.

Unsurprisingly, Price also posted low marks in adjusted yards per team play (10th percentile) and adjusted receiving yards per team pass attempt (12th percentile).

In most cases, this is a profile you'd fade. But 32nd overall draft capital keeps him on the radar. Since 2011, 20 running backs have been selected between Picks 20 and 40. Nine of them – nearly half – produced at least 14 PPR points per game in one of their first three seasons. Three of those backs were drafted just last year: TreVeyon Henderson and Quinshon Judkins didn't get there, while Omarion Hampton did.

The landing spot in Seattle also creates early opportunity. Zach Charbonnet is expected to miss time after a late-season ACL tear, which could open the door for Price right away. And with running backs, talent isn't always everything – if a coaching staff wants to feed a player, they'll feed him.

It's probably still worthwhile to temper expectations. Seattle ran hot last year and still ranked just 12th in running back PPR scoring, and they frustratingly split the backfield. In 16 games with Kenneth Walker and Charbonnet active together, Walker led with a 43.2% rushing share to Charbonnet's 38.8% – 12.8 to 11.5 carries per game. Meanwhile, Charbonnet handled about 73% of the team's goal-line work, leading to 11.8 expected touchdowns versus 4.7 for Walker.

There are also legitimate concerns from film evaluators – Price has question marks in pass protection and the receiving game. If he can't carve out a role as a pass-catcher, it's fair to ask whether his ceiling is much different from what Walker gave fantasy managers for stretches of 2025.

If you're in an active league, Price becomes more interesting. An immediate workload could boost his short-term value and give you a window to capitalize in the dynasty market. Just don't get carried away – this profile comes with clear red flags. Or, at least, it comes with a ton of volatility. Draft capital and teammate score are doing a lot of the heavy lifting. You could argue they're doing almost all of it.



Jonah Coleman • RB

 **48.7**

ZAP Score

WASHINGTON

FLEX PLAY

Low Risk **Neutral** High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height: 5'8 Weight: 220 NFL Team: Broncos

Statistical Comps: Doug Martin ▪ Zac Stacy ▪ Zack Moss

Update: Jonah Coleman is a true do-it-all back.

He began his collegiate career at Arizona, logging over 200 combined carries across his freshman and sophomore seasons. After transferring to Washington for his final two years, he elevated his profile further.

Coleman's peak in total yards per team play came as a junior, though that season included a reception share below 8%. As a senior, he put it all together, posting a similar yards-per-team-play mark while nearly doubling his prorated reception share to 13.2%.

Stylistically, he looks like a powerful workhorse. According to PFF, no running back in this class forced missed tackles at a higher rate per attempt. He also ranked top-five in yards after contact per attempt and earned one of the strongest pass-blocking grades among Combine invitees.

There are some questions about long speed – and he didn't test athletically – but his career explosive run rate is still above the class average. He may not be a burner, but he's not lacking big-play ability.

The landing spot in Denver is especially interesting. The Broncos drafted RJ Harvey in Round 2 last year, but his rookie season was underwhelming. Per Next Gen Stats, Harvey ranked 46th in rushing yards over expected per attempt among 48 qualified running backs, and his success rate ranked 32nd – well behind J.K. Dobbins, who was 12th in the same offense. And Dobbins himself could be gone after the 2026 season.

There's a real scenario where Coleman ends up being the best running back in this backfield. That doesn't mean it happens right away – or that it's a certainty – but the combination of his profile and the uncertainty around him makes it possible.

If the market discounts that in rookie drafts, it's worth taking advantage.



Kaelon Black • RB

 **46.5**

ZAP Score

INDIANA

FLEX PLAY

Low Risk Neutral High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height: 5'9 Weight: 211 NFL Team: 49ers

Statistical Comps: Dameon Pierce ▪ Damien Harris ▪ Terrance West

Update: For the first time in Late-Round Prospect Guide history, a profile page is being added post-draft. What a time to be alive.

It's not common for non-Combine invites to get drafted, let alone inside the top 100. But that's what happened with Indiana running back Kaelon Black. San Francisco did the most Kyle Shanahan thing imaginable and took him with the 90th overall pick.

Keep in mind, the running back ZAP Model bakes in some pre-draft projected capital, and Black was expected to go closer to Pick 180. So within the model, his draft capital looks more like 106 than 90.

Still, the landing spot is intriguing. San Francisco needs a backup after Brian Robinson left for Atlanta, and Christian McCaffrey is about to be a 30-year-old back coming off a 413-touch season.

Unfortunately, the team's history at the position – combined with Black's profile – makes this far from a slam dunk.

Black followed a familiar path for Indiana players, starting at James Madison before following Curt Cignetti. His career began in 2020, when he redshirted. He then started his second season strong before a knee injury ended it after three games.

From there, he played two more seasons at James Madison and two at Indiana. He's not young – already 24 and a half – and while we've seen a few older backs find mild success of late [largely due to transfer rules and NIL], age is still a clear negative.

The production profile doesn't help. Black posted a modest 10.3% best-season reception share – a number you'd expect to be higher given his experience. His best-season adjusted total yards per team play sits at just 1.12, the same as Jadarian Price's. And, as we know, Price was playing behind an elite teammate. Black was not.

Since Kyle Shanahan arrived in 2017, here are the running backs San Francisco has drafted (excluding Black): Jordan James, Isaac Guerendo, Tyrion Davis-Price, Trey Sermon, Elijah Mitchell, and Joe Williams. Most of those players were reaches when comparing projected draft capital to actual. In fact, Davis-Price, Williams, and now Black are three of the top-six biggest reaches in ZAP Model database history.

So yes, the landing spot is appealing. And running back is a position where talent isn't everything – if a coaching staff wants a player on the field, that player can produce.

But history says to be careful.



Mike Washington • RB



41.4

ZAP Score

ARKANSAS
FLEX PLAY

Low Risk Neutral High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height: 6'1 Weight: 223 NFL Team: Raiders

Statistical Comps: Latavius Murray ▪ Brian Robinson ▪ DJ Giddens

Update: Mike Washington was the biggest faller at running back in this class. According to NFL Mock Draft Database, he was expected to go around Pick 63. Instead, he landed in Las Vegas at 122.

Using Chase Stuart's draft value chart, that drop equates to a 4.2-point gain for the Raiders. Since 2016, the only players with a similar gap between projected and actual capital are Kenneth Dixon, Dalvin Cook, Paul Perkins, Derrius Guice, and Damien Martinez.

The fall isn't all that surprising. Washington is a freak athlete – at 223 pounds, he ran a 4.33 40-yard dash, good for the second-best Speed Score in ZAP Model history. But the production profile is far more ordinary.

Washington played five seasons across three programs and never exceeded a 41% rush attempt share. And despite his size, he ranked bottom-five in this class in missed tackles forced per attempt, per PFF. His rate of runs gaining 15 or more yards was also below the class average, even with that elite speed.

In other words, the production doesn't really match the measurables.

There's also the situation. Washington lands behind Ashton Jeanty, one of the top running back prospects of the last decade. Realistically, that caps him as a handcuff.

And there's some value in that role. If Jeanty were to go down, Washington is capable enough to carry the load. It's just easier to buy into a player like this when the profile is stronger. With Washington, it's more of a "fine, I guess" than anything else.

If this wasn't within such a mediocre draft class, we'd probably want to be even less bullish.



Emmett Johnson • RB

 **34.7**

ZAP Score

NEBRASKA

BENCHWARMER

Low Risk Neutral High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height: 5'10 Weight: 202 NFL Team: Chiefs

Statistical Comps: Michael Carter ▪ Kenneth Gainwell ▪ James White

Update: Emmett Johnson is one of my favorite prospects in this class, but he didn't find the cleanest landing spot with the Chiefs. The long-term offense is appealing, sure, but Kenneth Walker's arrival this offseason creates an immediate obstacle.

The good news is that they're very different backs. Walker wins with speed and explosive runs, while Johnson profiles more as a grinder – even at his size – with a strong receiving skill set.

From a production standpoint, Johnson checks just about every box in the ZAP Model. His best-season prorated reception share ranks in the 94th percentile, his top adjusted yards per team play sits in the 95th, and his adjusted receiving yards per team pass attempt lands in the 89th percentile. It's no surprise he earned a low-risk designation.

It's not all butterflies and rainbows, though. Among Combine-invited running backs, Johnson ranked third-worst in career yards after contact per attempt, per PFF.

There's some context worth noting. According to Rich Hribar of Sharp Football Analysis, Johnson was hit at or behind the line on just 33.9% of his runs – the lowest rate in the class. And when he was hit there, he still gained yardage on a class-high 75.3% of those attempts. That points to some efficiency that traditional metrics may miss.

Johnson's also unlikely to be a big-play threat. His career explosive run rate sits in the 19th percentile, and his 4.56 40-yard dash at 202 pounds resulted in a below-average Speed Score.

But that doesn't automatically disqualify him.

Since 2011, 10 running backs under 210 pounds have posted a season above 12 PPR points per game after being drafted outside Round 2. Only four of them had a Speed Score above 94. In other words, elite straight-line speed hasn't been a requirement for this archetype.

We've seen receiving-driven backs with modest athletic profiles hit – Kyren Williams, Bucky Irving, Aaron Jones. We've also seen plenty miss. The range of outcomes is wide.

Johnson is an intriguing dart throw in rookie drafts. The path to immediate production isn't clear, but there's not much in his way behind Walker on the Chiefs depth chart. And Walker hasn't exactly stayed healthy throughout his time in the NFL.



Nick Singleton • RB

 **33.2**

ZAP Score

PENN STATE

BENCHWARMER

Low Risk Neutral High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height: 6'0 Weight: 219 NFL Team: Titans

Statistical Comps: Jay Ajayi ▪ Javorius Allen ▪ CJ Prosise

Update: The Senior Bowl is invaluable for evaluating prospects up close. Unfortunately, injuries are part of the deal.

That's what happened to Penn State's Nick Singleton, who broke his foot during practice in January. It may have contributed to his slide to Pick 165, where Tennessee scooped him up.

According to the ZAP Model, that could be a value.

Among Combine-invited running backs, Singleton ranks sixth in best-season prorated reception share, fifth in adjusted receiving yards per team pass attempt, and sixth in adjusted total yards per team play – out of 20 players.

That's even more impressive given that he shared a backfield with Kaytron Allen for all four seasons at Penn State. Singleton was clearly the better pass-catcher, highlighted by a 41-catch season in 2024 compared to Allen's 18.

There are some concerns outside the model. Per PFF, Singleton forced missed tackles at a below-average rate, and despite strong athletic traits, his rate of runs gaining 10 or more yards was below average among Combine invitees. The tools are there – the consistency wasn't always.

Still, this is a rare profile for a Day 3 pick. In ZAP Model history, just 13 running backs drafted after Pick 100 have entered the league with a prorated reception share above 12%, a best-season total yards per team play above 1.6, and an adjusted receiving yards per team pass attempt above 1.0. Singleton cleared all three with room to spare.

Of those 13 backs, 9 exceeded their draft-capital-based expectation, and on average, the group outperformed expectation by 3.5 PPR points per game.

When Day 3 running backs hit, it's often because they land in ambiguous backfields. You can see that reflected in seasonal average draft position – when a team's top running back isn't a high-investment player, it signals opportunity.

That's exactly the situation in Tennessee. Tyjae Spears and Tony Pollard are both set to hit free agency next year, and there's no clear long-term answer in place. There may not even be a short-term one in place.

Singleton is absolutely worth a look in rookie drafts.



Adam Randall • RB

 **29.9**

ZAP Score

CLEMSON

WAIVER WIRE ADD

Low Risk Neutral High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height: 6'3 Weight: 232 NFL Team: Ravens

Statistical Comps: Karlos Williams ▪ Kalen Ballage ▪ Qadree Ollison

Update: We seem to get a wide receiver-to-running back convert in every draft class. This year, it's Adam Randall.

The key difference between Randall and recent converts like Brashard Smith and Tyrone Tracy is size. Randall checks in north of 230 pounds. In ZAP Model history, he's just one of 11 backs at that weight to post a best-season reception share above 10%.

Most of the players in that bucket – Saquon Barkley, Leonard Fournette, Eddie Lacy, Jeremy Hill, James Conner, Najee Harris – came with strong draft capital. The ones who didn't haven't given us much at the NFL level.

That's where things get tricky.

Randall's profile is easy to like on the surface: big-bodied former receiver, positional versatility, untapped upside. But the underlying data is underwhelming. His reception share clears 10%, but his best adjusted receiving yards per team pass attempt is just 0.59 – seventh-worst in the class. His adjusted total yards per team play ranks fifth-worst.

He only spent one of his four collegiate seasons at Clemson playing running back, logging 168 carries in 2025. With that kind of limited experience, you wouldn't expect a polished profile.

And you don't get one.

Despite the size, Randall ranked below average in both missed tackles forced per attempt and yards after contact per attempt. For a player built like a power back, the power metrics don't stand out.

Interestingly, the landing spot might actually help, even if it doesn't look that way at face value. Most wouldn't be excited about a back sitting behind Derrick Henry, but for Randall, it's probably ideal. He needs time to learn the position, and there's no better way to do so than behind a future Hall of Famer. Randall's still under 22 and very raw as a running back.

In a class lacking obvious upside swings, Randall is at least worth keeping on your radar in the later rounds of rookie drafts.

Eli Heidenreich • RB



27.3

ZAP Score

NAVY		WAIVER WIRE ADD	Low Risk Neutral High Risk
Height: 6'0	Weight: 198	NFL Team: Steelers	

Draft Capital Δ

Statistical Comps: LeQuint Allen ▪ Akrum Wadley ▪ Dylan Laube

Update: Chances are, as a seventh-round pick in a pretty throwaway landing spot, Eli Heidenreich won't become anything meaningful for fantasy football.

But, man, what a cool story and profile.

Heidenreich went to Mt. Lebanon High School, right outside Pittsburgh. (I went to North Allegheny, also right outside Pittsburgh, but we won't get into which high school is better. Now isn't the time.) He then spent his college career at Navy.

And, well, service academies don't throw the ball. Since 2011, Army, Navy, and Air Force have combined to reach 300 team pass attempts in a season just twice.

So when you're evaluating a player in that kind of environment, the numbers can get... weird.

That's exactly what happened with Heidenreich in 2025.

Heidenreich was a productive piece of Navy's offense for three seasons, but 2025 was the breakout: 51 receptions and a staggering 48.1% prorated reception share. That's the highest mark in ZAP Model history. By roughly 23 percentage points.

He's not a traditional running back. He's more of a Swiss Army knife – a movable chess piece who can align in the backfield, in the slot, or out wide. He carried the ball 77 times last season but was deployed all over the formation as a receiver. Any team drafting him is doing so with that versatility in mind.

And the receiving metrics? They're absurd. His adjusted receiving yards per team pass attempt sits at 4.96 – the best mark in the model's database. Second place? Christian McCaffrey at 2.36.

Yeah. For real.

Like I said at the top, the odds aren't great that Heidenreich becomes anything meaningful for fantasy purposes. These tweener profiles usually need a very specific situation to hit.

But this class isn't very good. At all. So I'm going to say something I don't say often as a process-oriented analyst:

Why not have a little fun and shoot for the outlier?



Demond Claiborne • RB

 **25.3**

ZAP Score

WAKE FOREST

WAIVER WIRE ADD

Low Risk **Neutral** High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height: 5'10 Weight: 188 NFL Team: Vikings

Statistical Comps: Brashard Smith ▪ Jason Huntley ▪ Akeem Hunt

Update: You've seen it in other profiles, but for Day 3 running backs to hit, they often need to land in semi-ambiguous backfields. If their teammates aren't being drafted highly in season-long formats, it's a signal that there's no clear starter.

And where there's uncertainty, there's opportunity.

Demond Claiborne lands in one of those situations in Minnesota.

Size could be a limiting factor. At 5'10", 188 pounds, the Wake Forest product handled a solid – but not dominant – workload across four seasons. His peak came as a junior with 228 carries, the only time he cleared 200 attempts.

There's some pass-game involvement, with a 13.1% best-season reception share. But the impact was modest. He never exceeded a 0.63 adjusted receiving yards per team pass attempt mark, and once you factor in age and strength of schedule, that falls below the class average.

The straight-line speed is real – he ran a 4.37 40-yard dash at the Combine.

The issue is that the big-play profile doesn't fully align with that speed. Per PFF, Claiborne posted a 12.3% explosive run rate, below the class average of 13.8%. Over the last five years, the only back under 200 pounds with an explosive run rate below 15% to even reach 4 PPR points per game in a season is Kyren Williams – and Williams had a much stronger overall production profile.

Claiborne also didn't stand out in missed tackles forced or yards after contact per attempt. For a lighter back, you'd ideally want at least one of those traits to pop.

This looks more like a complementary back than a true bell-cow – and that's fine. This class isn't loaded with high-end running back talent, and Claiborne's skill set pairs well with Minnesota's current early-down option, Jordan Mason.

There's also a longer-term angle. Both Mason and Aaron Jones are set to hit free agency next year, so if Claiborne flashes at all, there's a path to more volume in 2027.



Kaytron Allen • RB

 **23.3**

ZAP Score

PENN STATE

WAIVER WIRE ADD

Low Risk Neutral High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height: 5'11 Weight: 216 NFL Team: Commanders

Statistical Comps: Kendre Miller ▪ Wayne Gallman ▪ Mike Gillislee

Update: When you first look at Kaytron Allen's production profile, the lack of receiving output stands out immediately. His best-season prorated reception share was just 8.6%, sixth-worst in the class, and his adjusted receiving yards per team pass attempt was 0.50 – also sixth-worst.

Allen spent all four seasons at Penn State alongside Nick Singleton, who was drafted just before him. Singleton handled more of the passing-game work, which naturally suppresses Allen's receiving résumé in the model.

Stylistically, Allen was the thunder to Singleton's lightning – a downhill, physical runner who forced missed tackles at a slightly higher rate. That said, his tackle-breaking and yards-after-contact numbers were more average than standout relative to this class.

When you combine that type of rushing profile with limited receiving involvement, it can be concerning. Historically, it often is.

The ZAP Model database includes more than 170 running backs who entered the league with a best-season prorated reception share below 10% and a peak adjusted receiving yards per team pass attempt under 0.60 – Allen fits both thresholds. Of that group, just seven produced a season of at least 14 PPR points per game within their first three years: Alfred Morris, Andre Ellington, CJ Anderson, Carlos Hyde, Jordan Howard, Chris Carson, and Isiah Pacheco.

This is where Allen's overall production matters. He was highly productive on the ground – he's Penn State's all-time leading rusher – and posted a 1.96 adjusted total yards per team play mark. Among those seven hits, only Jordan Howard and Carlos Hyde reached that level.

Add in the fact that Allen shared a backfield with legitimate competition throughout his career, and the profile looks a bit better than the receiving numbers alone suggest.

The landing spot in Washington helps, too. There's no entrenched backfield leader, and we know ambiguous situations can create early opportunity for Day 3 picks.

Allen is the type of player who could see a short-term spike in dynasty value. If that happens, he may be more of a sell candidate than a long-term hold after Year 1, given the lack of receiving upside – similar to what we've seen with players like Dameon Pierce or even Jordan Howard. But you can still take him in rookie drafts and hope his early-down work wins out in 2026.



Seth McGowan • RB

 **20.0**

ZAP Score

KENTUCKY

WAIVER WIRE ADD

Low Risk **Neutral** High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height: 6'0 Weight: 223 NFL Team: Colts

Statistical Comps: Dwayne Washington ▪ David Johnson ▪ Keaontay Ingram

Prior to this draft class, only one ZAP Model running back – Martez Carter – entered the NFL at age 25 or older.

This year, we have two. One of them is Seth McGowan.

Does age matter? Yes. The model accounts for it, and historically, older prospects have produced weaker outcomes. But context is needed. College football has shifted dramatically in recent years. Transfer rules changed. The pandemic extended eligibility. NIL deals altered incentives. As a result, we're seeing older backs more frequently.

Over the last two draft classes (excluding this one), 10 running backs either attended the NFL Combine or were drafted at age 24 or older. From 2011 through 2023, there were 11 total. Last year alone, RJ Harvey, Woody Marks, and Jacory Croskey-Merritt were all 24 or older at selection.

Adjusted for draft capital, the hit rates for these older prospects haven't been disastrous of late.

As long as the production profiles were strong.

McGowan's profile isn't bad – it's just uneven. He began at Oklahoma in 2020 before being dismissed following legal issues, though the charges were ultimately dropped. After time away from the game, he resurfaced at Butler Community College in 2023, then transferred to New Mexico State in 2024. There, he logged 152 carries in a backfield that also featured 2026 draft hopeful Mike Washington. More importantly for his analytical outlook, McGowan posted a career-best 16.3% reception share that year.

That season did a lot of the heavy lifting for his pass-catching profile, showing at least some ability to function on passing downs. The question is sustainability. When a receiving spike comes after multiple stops and years in the wilderness, it's fair to wonder how sticky it really is.

In 2025, McGowan transferred again – this time to Kentucky. There, he carried the ball 165 times, recorded a 9.1% reception share, and posted a career-best 1.22 adjusted total yards per team play.

McGowan is a big, physical back who plays through contact. Among this year's Combine invitees, he ranks top-five in career missed tackles forced per attempt, per PFF. His explosive run rate is average at best, but when you pair the tackle-breaking ability with an acceptable receiving profile, you can at least envision a path where he sticks as a quality backup with contingent upside.



Jam Miller • RB



17.1

ZAP Score

ALABAMA
DART THROW

Low Risk Neutral High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height: 5'10 Weight: 209 NFL Team: Patriots

Statistical Comps: Rico Dowdle ▪ Montrell Johnson ▪ Ty Davis-Price

Jam Miller flashed some juice at the NFL Combine. At 209 pounds, he ran a 4.42 40, giving him a Speed Score just shy of 110.

That might be the best part of the profile, if we're being honest.

Miller spent four seasons at Alabama and never reached 150 carries in a year. His best rush attempt share season topped out at 29.7%. Through the air, he never hit an 8% reception share in any campaign.

That combination – modest workload and minimal receiving – is historically tough to overcome.

There are 34 running backs in the ZAP Model database who failed to clear a 30% best-season attempt share and an 8% reception share. Just four of them reached 10 or more PPR points per game in one of their first three seasons: CJ Anderson, Chris Carson, Dameon Pierce, and Damien Harris.

All four weighed at least 215 pounds entering the league.

Miller doesn't.

Even if we loosen the thresholds – backs under 215 pounds with a best-season attempt share below 40% and a best-season reception share below 10% – there are 43 players in that bucket. Only Devonta Freeman, Elijah Mitchell, and Darrell Henderson produced meaningful fantasy seasons.

And that's before diving into the advanced rushing metrics.

Despite the strong 40 time, Miller ranked dead last in this year's class in collegiate explosive run rate, per PFF. It's one of the lowest marks we've seen in the last five draft cycles. His yards after contact per attempt also ranked dead last.

Alabama's depth chart is never easy to crack, and they obviously play some tough defenses. But the overall résumé doesn't suggest we should be pounding the table for Miller this offseason.

The Speed Score is intriguing. The production profile is not.



Desmond Reid • RB



15.2

ZAP Score

PITTSBURGH
DART THROW

Low Risk Neutral High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height: 5'6 Weight: 174 NFL Team: Undrafted

Statistical Comps: Tarik Cohen ▪ Deuce Vaughn ▪ Khalfani Muhammad

Desmond Reid out of Pittsburgh (Hail 2 Pitt) isn't just the smallest back in this year's class – at 174 pounds, he's the lightest running back in the ZAP Model database since 2017.

That size is going to be the headline. And it should be.

But if you zoom in on the production, it's legitimately strong. Reid posted the second-best top-season reception share in the class at 20.4%. His adjusted receiving yards per team play also ranked second. And his best-season adjusted total yards per team play – which includes rushing – came in at 2.10, a mark only two running backs in the class topped.

From a pure production standpoint, Reid is near the top of this group.

The problem is the body type. In the ZAP Model database, there are 23 running backs under 190 pounds. Only De'Von Achane – who added weight once he reached the NFL – and Tarik Cohen have delivered truly fantasy-relevant seasons. You could maybe toss Keaton Mitchell into the conversation, but that's not exactly a deep bench of hits.

So the bet with Reid is pretty clear: you're hoping for a creative offensive coordinator who leans into his receiving ability and builds a role around him. In the right system, he could be a PPR weapon.

The challenge is that the NFL has shifted. Running back target spikes aren't quite what they were in the Tarik Cohen era. It's harder now for a sub-180-pound back to live purely off receiving volume without a lot of rushing work.

Pitt allegiance aside – that's my alma mater, for those of you who don't know – Reid is fun. He's quick, he's productive as a receiver, and he's electric in space.

But fun doesn't automatically translate to fantasy difference-maker – especially at 174 pounds.

Roman Hemby • RB



12.4

ZAP Score

Low Risk Neutral High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

INDIANA		DART THROW
Height: 6'0	Weight: 207	NFL Team: Undrafted

Statistical Comps: Will Shipley ▪ Ty Chandler ▪ Rasheen Ali

The advanced numbers don't paint Roman Hemby as a dynamic runner. His career avoided tackles per rush rate is tied for the third-worst in this class. He gained 15 or more yards at the second-lowest rate. His yards after contact per attempt also sits in the bottom half among Combine invites.

Those are rushing indicators. And they're not flattering.

The ZAP Model is a bit more forgiving because it leans heavily on receiving inputs. At Maryland, Hemby posted an 11% reception share or better in three of his four seasons – the three in which he played more than two games. His adjusted total yards per team play and adjusted receiving yards per team pass attempt were below average, but not alarmingly so.

Hemby then transferred to Indiana for his final season, where he set a career high with 230 carries. Once you account for offensive environment, though, his attempt share wasn't meaningfully different from what it had been at Maryland. He never exceeded a 40% rush attempt share in college.

Put it all together and the profile becomes fairly clear. Hemby projects as a committee back, likely with some pass-catching utility. That's exactly what his statistical comparables suggest: a complementary piece who can contribute, but probably not anchor a backfield on his own.



Robert Henry • RB



11.1

ZAP Score

TEXAS-EL PASO
DART THROW

Low Risk Neutral High Risk

Draft Capital Δ
Height: 5'9 Weight: 196 NFL Team: Undrafted
Statistical Comps: LeVante Bellamy ▪ Travis Homer ▪ Cody Schrader

Robert Henry's best-season reception share was 12.3%, which is respectable on the surface. The problem is that it came with major inefficiency, largely due to adjustments. In that same season, his age- and schedule-adjusted receiving yards per team pass attempt was just 0.40, the fourth-worst mark in this class.

Context doesn't really save it, either. Henry played at Jones College and UTEP, and he reached higher than a 7% reception share in just that one campaign. He wasn't facing elite weekly competition – the production simply wasn't there in an impactful way.

Athletically, there's not much of a boost. At 196 pounds, Henry ran a 4.52 40 at the Combine, resulting in a below average 93.9 Speed Score.

Historically, that's a tough combo. In the ZAP Model database, 111 running backs have posted both a sub-100 Speed Score and a sub-0.5 adjusted receiving yards per team pass attempt rate. Only nine of them reached 10 or more PPR points per game in one of their first three seasons: Alfred Morris, Stevan Ridley, Andre Ellington, Alex Collins, Thomas Rawls, Jordan Howard, Chris Carson, Ronald Jones, and James Robinson.

Every single one of those backs weighed more than Henry at the Combine.

Add in the age – he'll be 24 after five collegiate seasons – and the odds shrink even further. Older running back prospects haven't produced much sustained fantasy success historically.

Even in a favorable landing spot, Henry doesn't project cleanly into a three-down role. He's not built like a classic early-down bruiser, and the receiving profile doesn't suggest a natural passing-down specialist, either.

That's an awkward middle ground to live in. And it's not where you want your Day 3 dart throw to sit.



CJ Donaldson • RB



10.9

ZAP Score

OHIO STATE

DART THROW

Low Risk Neutral High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height: 6'2	Weight: 230	NFL Team: Undrafted
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Statistical Comps: Ja'Quinden Jackson ▪ Bo Scarbrough ▪ David Williams

When you weigh 230 pounds and rank dead last in your draft class in career missed tackles forced per attempt, that's a red flag.

That's the starting point with CJ Donaldson. Among 220-plus-pound running backs since 2020, the only ones with missed tackles forced rates in his range are Gerrid Doaks and Stevie Scott.

Not great!

Donaldson spent three seasons at West Virginia before transferring to Ohio State for his final year. He was originally recruited as a tight end, which makes sense when you see the 6'2", 230-pound frame.

Across four collegiate seasons, Donaldson never truly controlled his team's rushing workload. His best attempt share was around 31%. Efficiency didn't pick up the slack, either. He posted the third-lowest explosive run rate in this year's class and the second-worst career yards after contact per attempt.

The receiving profile offers little relief. His best-season reception share was just 6.2%, better than only Jadarian Price among running backs invited to the NFL Combine.

So what's the bet? That an NFL team sees the size and thinks it can mold him into something more physical and efficient than he showed in college.

Maybe that happens. But historically, backs with this combination of low tackle-breaking ability, modest workload share, and minimal receiving production don't turn into fantasy staples.

If Donaldson carves out a role, it's likely as more of a situational back. That's not the kind of archetype you're drafting with confidence in any fantasy format.



J'Mari Taylor • RB



10.2

ZAP Score

VIRGINIA
DART THROW

Low Risk Neutral High Risk

Draft Capital Δ
Height: 5'10 Weight: 199 NFL Team: Undrafted
Statistical Comps: Trevor Etienne ▪ Ito Smith ▪ James Williams

Back in 2020, J'Mari Taylor was a walk-on at North Carolina Central. He stayed there through 2024, steadily earning more work each season and eventually topping out with a 53% rush attempt share and an impressive 18.6% reception share in his final year.

Taylor then transferred to Virginia for the 2025 season and continued to show pass-game ability, posting a 14.7% reception share against stronger competition. That's an encouraging signal – the skill set translated upward in level.

On the ground, there are some positives, too. Per PFF, Taylor ranks sixth in this class in career rushing yards after contact per attempt. Despite weighing just 199 pounds, he forced missed tackles at an above-average rate. He wasn't facing SEC defenses every week at North Carolina Central, but the data still reflects functional strength and balance.

One big concern for Taylor is age. He'll be 24 at draft time after five collegiate seasons. Historically, backs entering the league at that age haven't found sustained fantasy success in the ZAP Model database.

There's also the frame. At 199 pounds, he's unlikely to project as a true three-down option in the NFL.

But that shouldn't be the expectation anyway.

Taylor's statistical comparables lean toward satellite backs – players who entered the league as passing-down complements with a path to expanded roles if things break right. As a likely Day 3 pick, landing spot will matter immensely. If he joins a backfield with an established early-down grinder who needs a receiving complement, Taylor could carve out that niche.

The ceiling probably isn't feature-back dominance. But there's a plausible path to situational relevance in the right ecosystem.



Noah Whittington • RB



7.3

ZAP Score

OREGON

DART THROW

Low Risk Neutral High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height: 5'8 Weight: 205 NFL Team: Undrafted

Statistical Comps: Boston Scott ▪ Mike Ball ▪ Michael Smith

Noah Whittington played six seasons of college football and never reached 1,000 total yards in a single year.

Whittington's most encouraging stretch likely came in Year 3, his first season at Oregon after two years at Western Kentucky. That year, he posted his best adjusted receiving yards per team pass attempt rate and his second-best adjusted total yards per team play mark. He also tied his career-high reception share at 7.1%.

And he did that in the same offense as Bucky Irving.

You'd hope the arrow would continue pointing up from there, but it didn't. Whittington tore his ACL in 2023, the following season, and the profile never really recovered. His best-season reception share ranked bottom-five in the class. His adjusted receiving yards per team pass attempt was also bottom-five. His top adjusted total yards per team play mark – 1.20 – ranked third-worst among Combine-invited running backs.

Even if we soften the thresholds by 20% – pushing them to roughly an 8.5% reception share, 1.45 total yards per team play, and 0.50 receiving yards per team pass attempt – Whittington still falls well short.

In the ZAP Model database, 66 running backs have failed to meet those boosted baselines. Just two – Andre Ellington and Chris Carson – produced even one fantasy-relevant season in their first three years.

That's not encouraging.

The profile is iffy, and the lack of any true ceiling season makes it difficult to sell Whittington as anything more than a depth guy.

As always with running backs, landing spot can manufacture short-term opportunity. But analytically, this is not a profile you'd want to aggressively bet on.



Le'Veon Moss • RB



4.7

ZAP Score

TEXAS A&M
DART THROW

Low Risk Neutral High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height: 5'11 Weight: 203 NFL Team: Undrafted

Statistical Comps: Kennedy Brooks ▪ Nick Wilson ▪ Abram Smith

The issue with Le'Veon Moss isn't the name – it absolutely sounds like an NFL running back's name.

It's the production.

Moss spent four years at Texas A&M and never once handled more than 25% of his team's rush attempts in a season. His best-season attempt share was only higher than Eli Heidenreich's in this class, and Heidenreich is basically a slot receiver playing running back.

The receiving profile doesn't bail Moss out. He posted just a 6.7% best-season reception share, the third-lowest mark among Combine invite running backs. His adjusted receiving yards per team pass attempt came in at 0.63, well below the class average.

So we've got a limited rushing share and limited receiving involvement.

At the Combine, Moss weighed 203 pounds. That's not tiny, but it's also not the kind of frame that screams "early-down hammer" – especially when the production doesn't support that label.

Historically, that combination is rough. In the ZAP Model database, only four running backs have reached 10 or more PPR points per game in one of their first three seasons with both a sub-8% best-season reception share and a sub-30% best-season attempt share: Chris Carson, Dameon Pierce, Damien Harris, and CJ Anderson.

Pierce and Harris had decent draft capital. All four of them were over 215 pounds entering the league. Moss doesn't check either of those boxes.

Which brings us to the key question: where does Moss fit?

He doesn't project as a clear passing-down option. He doesn't profile as a high-volume early-down grinder. He didn't dominate touches in college. And as a likely Day 3 pick, he won't have investment to force opportunity.

That's an uncomfortable place to live for fantasy purposes. Without a standout trait or a defined role to lean on, Moss feels more like depth than a back you'll be excited to roster.



Rahsul Faison • RB



0.0

ZAP Score

SOUTH CAROLINA
DART THROW

Low Risk Neutral High Risk

Draft Capital Δ
Height: 5'11 Weight: 208 NFL Team: Undrafted
Statistical Comps: Brittain Brown ▪ SaRodorick Thompson ▪ Wes Hills

Some prospects in this class took winding paths through college. Rahsul Faison went on a full-blown odyssey.

First, the headline: Faison is 26 years old.

He began his college career in 2019 at Marshall, transferred to Lackawanna College in 2020, then moved to Snow College, where he finally started seeing real playing time. After a couple of seasons there, he transferred to Utah State and spent two years with the Aggies. His best season came there, when he posted a 1.37 total yards per team play rate – easily the top mark of his career.

In 2025, Faison transferred again, this time to South Carolina, where he finished with 96 carries and 19 receptions. It was a quiet final chapter.

Faison is the oldest player in the ZAP Model database, so we're operating in pretty unusual territory. And age at running back isn't something you can just hand-wave away – he's already brushing up against the typical fantasy age apex before taking an NFL snap.

Even beyond the age, the production doesn't do much work. Despite spending six-plus years in college football, Faison never reached a double-digit target share in a season. His best-season adjusted total yards per team play was 1.18, second-worst in this class.

There is one encouraging note: at 208 pounds, he forced missed tackles at one of the best rates in the group. Only two backs in this class posted a better career missed tackles forced rate.

But let's be real: Faison was a 25-year-old at one point playing against teenagers. That edge doesn't translate cleanly forward.

This is the type of profile that's easy to fade in rookie drafts. The age, the lack of a true spike season, and the limited receiving production create a very mid prospect.

Tight End



Legendary Performer

Kenyon Sadiq..... 105



Elite Producer

Eli Stowers..... 106



Weekly Starter

Max Klare..... 107

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Flex Play

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Kenyon Sadiq • TE

 **98.5**

ZAP Score

OREGON

LEGENDARY PERFORMER

Low Risk Neutral High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height: 6'3 Weight: 241 NFL Team: Jets

Statistical Comps: Noah Fant ▪ OJ Howard ▪ Evan Engram

Update: Kenyon Sadiq became just the seventh tight end drafted 16th or earlier in the NFL Draft since 2011, placing him in rarefied air. The others: Eric Ebron, TJ Hockenson, Kyle Pitts, Brock Bowers, Tyler Warren, and Colston Loveland. Each logged at least one season with 9.3 PPR points per game or more within their first three NFL seasons – a 90th-percentile max early-career season in the database at a minimum. Warren and Loveland have played just one season, too. This group also owns a 54% rate of top-12 seasons in that early-career window while averaging an 18.9% target share.

Sadiq's comps look underwhelming, though, so it's worth revisiting how productive Fant, Howard, and Engram actually were early in their careers – B2S scores of 10.2, 9.6, and 12.6, respectively, all 94th-percentile or better. Even Kyle Pitts, perhaps the most obvious “legendary” recent prospect, logged a 93rd-percentile B2S of 9.6 despite a slow start.

You can cherry-pick nominal legends like George Kittle (15.6), Mark Andrews (13.2), and Travis Kelce (11.6), but none were even top-60 NFL Draft picks – they simply hit bigger than most tight ends do. Sadiq is a better prospect than any of them. The truth is that there are only a handful of difference-making tight ends every decade, and Sadiq has the building blocks to be one.

Sadiq played three seasons at Oregon, running behind significant NFL-caliber talent before breaking out in Year 3 with 51 receptions, a school record at the position. He then broke the tight end record in the 40-yard dash (4.39 seconds) at the Combine – and was drafted just after turning 21. Among first-round tight ends drafted before age 22 in the ZAP Model, even the weakest max early-career season (David Njoku, 29th overall pick) ranked in the 87th percentile.

The landing spot with the Jets isn't ideal for reaching a huge offensive ceiling, and for anyone concerned about the production profile for Sadiq, it's a justifiable out. Frank Reich, the team's new coordinator, has historically been friendly to the position, and across 10 seasons where he was a team's coordinator or head coach, his squads have just once ranked outside the top 20 in tight end target share, while ranking in the top five four times.

The draft capital, combined with his age-adjusted profile and athleticism, gives Sadiq one of the best ZAP scores the position has ever seen. The model isn't projecting peak Kittle performance in Year 1. It's telling us that Sadiq certainly belongs in the high-end tier of tight end prospects in recent years.



Eli Stowers • TE

 **75.4**

ZAP Score

VANDERBILT

ELITE PRODUCER

Low Risk **Neutral** High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height: 6'4 Weight: 239 NFL Team: Eagles

Statistical Comps: Sam LaPorta ▪ Mike Gesicki ▪ Luke Musgrave

Update: Eli Stowers was getting steam entering the NFL Draft, and his consensus big board rank was nearing the first round by late April. He ended up going 54th overall, a little later than expected, which led to a larger draft capital differential between Stowers and Kenyon Sadiq than we may have anticipated. That's relevant because, throughout the pre-draft process, Stowers and Sadiq became linked, as the former's profile really started to shine.

The buzz for Stowers really ramped up after the NFL Combine. Stowers' 4.51-second 40-yard dash was tied for the second-best at the combine at the position, trailing Sadiq's 4.39. Additionally, Stowers broke the all-time vertical leap record and the tight end broad jump record, too. So, while Sadiq had the best straight-line speed we'd ever seen at tight end, Stowers stole the show overall.

Stowers also had a better Breakout Score (66.5, 91st percentile) than Sadiq (62.3, 86th percentile).

All things considered, they're both elite athletes with high-end age-adjusted production. The draft capital difference between the two is relevant and hard to brush off completely. Of course, Stowers is still in the Elite Producer category, and it's also a little easier to like his landing spot in terms of his long-term outlook.

Incumbent tight end Dallas Goedert is set to be a free agent next season, and Stowers should be able to play alongside him anyway because he projects as a "big receiver" more than he does an inline tight end.

Stowers is a playmaker. He recorded a first down on 12.4% of his routes, via PFF, in his college career. That puts him third on a list of Harold Fannin, (coincidentally) Goedert, Mark Andrews, and Tucker Kraft among Day 2 picks since 2014.

Last year, the Eagles were a top-12 team in 12 personnel usage, and Stowers brings a different profile to the position than Goedert. The more notable pairing might actually be with the team's first-round wide receiver draft pick, Makai Lemon. Lemon played a lot in the slot at USC, and Jalen Hurts has historically thrown more to the sidelines than to the middle of the field.

Still, only three other tight ends in the ZAP Model database had top-64 draft capital, a Breakout Score over 65, and a height-adjusted Speed Score over 115: Kyle Pitts, Noah Fant, and Evan Engram. All were first-round NFL Draft picks.



Max Klare • TE

 **63.4**

ZAP Score

OHIO STATE

WEEKLY STARTER

Low Risk **Neutral** High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height: 6'4 Weight: 246 NFL Team: Rams

Statistical Comps: Greg Dulcich ▪ Jonnu Smith ▪ Pat Freiermuth

Update: Despite being considered the TE3 on plenty of big boards entering the draft, Max Klare actually wound up as the TE5, going 61st overall to the Rams, who drafted a fun prospect in Terrance Ferguson (46th overall) just last year.

Klare, though, is a fantasy football manager's tight end. That is to say: he should be able to handle a lot of receiving volume – if it comes his way.

Klare leads this year's tight end class in Breakout Score, thanks to some big production at Purdue (specifically a 51-catch, 685-yard, 4-touchdown stat line as a redshirt sophomore) before tailing off a bit in his lone year at Ohio State.

That's understandable when you're playing alongside Jeremiah Smith, Carnell Tate, and Will Kacmarek (a fellow tight end who was drafted 87th overall this year).

So, he carved out great market shares in an easier situation and remained relevant with competition upgrades at Ohio State (he was third on the team in catches behind Smith and Tate this past season). That's good stuff.

Playing alongside target-earners like that will also prove to be good practice, as Klare is joining a team with Puka Nacua, Davante Adams, and a crowded tight end room (for now).

Klare has some versatility. He was also used out wide fairly often (13.4% wide rate, per PFF, in 2025 – highest among tight ends in the class).

While he's unlikely to be the highest-ceiling option we've seen in recent years (especially within this offense, where elite target shares are spoken for already), he should be able to answer the call when the ball is thrown his way.

Also, Colby Parkinson and Davis Allen are free agents after this year, so wheels should be up for Klare soon enough, even if he shares the field with Ferguson a lot in the future. Remember, the Rams shifted quite a bit to heavier tight end sets in 2025. Klare almost drew a Mark Andrews comp – just for a little more context.



Sam Roush • TE



61.2

ZAP Score

STANFORD
WEEKLY STARTER

Low Risk Neutral High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height: 6'6 Weight: 267 NFL Team: Bears

Statistical Comps: Darnell Washington ▪ Daniel Bellinger ▪ George Kittle

Update: Despite being the 69th overall pick in the 2026 NFL Draft, Sam Roush was the sixth tight end off the board in what became a deep tight end draft class much quicker than we expected. The fit with the Bears, though, isn't exactly ideal for Roush's immediate fantasy football impact.

Of course, Colston Loveland is looking like a stud after his rookie season, and Cole Kmet is under contract for two more years.

Roush is huge, though, at 6'6" and 267 pounds, and the 4.70-second 40-yard dash at that size is good for a height-adjusted Speed Score north of 112. He also tested well outside of straight-line speed.

His 3-cone time was 7.08 seconds. I have only 44 players in my Combine database (since 2000) with a weight of 267 and a 3-cone of 7.08 or faster, and most are defensive ends.

Again, going back to 2000, Roush is fifth among all tight ends in weight-adjusted vertical, coincidentally ranking third in this class alone. The leaders in this metric are Eli Stowers, Vernon Davis, Virgil Green, and Kenyon Sadiq. He's also second since 2000 among tight ends in weight-adjusted broad jump. He's big and athletic.

What about the production?

It wasn't bad by any means. His max yards per team attempt and Breakout Scores were just above the 60th percentile within the database, and the blocking grades were pretty good overall.

With draft capital in the 60s, Roush actually has a lot of overlap with Travis Kelce's profile (61st-percentile max yards per team attempt for Roush and 62nd-percentile for Kelce – with a better Breakout Score for Roush). It's always bold to compare any tight ends to the ones who went on to be true outliers, but there are many similarities between Roush and some difference-makers. There are also many similarities between Roush and some unproductive, big-bodied blockers.

It just may be difficult for him to find early-career production with how that current tight end room is situated.



Marlin Klein • TE

 **59.7**

ZAP Score

MICHIGAN

FLEX PLAY

Low Risk Neutral High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height: 6'6 Weight: 248 NFL Team: Texans

Statistical Comps: Tanner McLachlan ▪ Jack Stoll ▪ Stephen Sullivan

Update: This is an unfathomable post-draft ZAP score swing for Marlin Klein, who was 164th on the consensus big board when the prospect guide was first published – fantasy afterthought territory as a projected late fifth-round pick. The Texans drafted him 59th overall. That's a signal they're willing to buy in on Klein as a developmental prospect, and it's also basically earlier capital for a profile like his than we've almost ever seen (though we saw multiple reaches in the 2026 draft alone).

The new tight end model reacts to different information in different ways, and Klein is a good athlete, so the model will account for production differently as a result. That matters because he has question marks there.

On the athleticism front, Klein ran a 4.61-second 40-yard dash at the Combine, seventh-fastest among 18 tight ends who tested this year. His height-adjusted Speed Score clocked in at 112.7, sixth-best among official combine testers and an 89th-percentile mark in the ZAP Model database.

The production was lacking, though. Klein played behind Colston Loveland for three years at Michigan before seeing his role expand in 2025, posting career-bests in receptions (24), yards (248), and touchdowns (1) – resulting in a max yards-per-team-attempt mark in just the 21st percentile.

What the model is picking up on is a combination of strong athleticism with elite draft capital, which has helped uncover NFL opportunity in the past. He pairs that with strong blocking grades and film, and we've seen good blockers with great athleticism overcome weak production before. For Klein, the limited output can at least be partially explained by spending three years behind a generational prospect.

Still, this is rare draft capital for a profile like Klein's. Accounting for the drastic swing, his comparison list includes Luke Schoonmaker, Drew Sample, Tucker Kraft, Jelani Woods, Dawson Knox, and Jordan Cameron – a wide array that reflects the range of outcomes here.

Klein could take a few years to hit his stride – if he ever does – but with only Dalton Schultz (signed for two more years) ahead of him on the Texans' depth chart, there's a real path. He's a bet on traits, which is more than you can say for some other Day 2 tight ends from this class.



Oscar Delp • TE

 **55.5**

ZAP Score

GEORGIA

FLEX PLAY

Low Risk Neutral High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height: 6'5 Weight: 245 NFL Team: Saints

Statistical Comps: Jared Wiley ▪ Chig Okonkwo ▪ Julius Thomas

Update: Oscar Delp was selected 73rd overall by the New Orleans Saints, so he'll be joining an older tight end room and have a chance to flash his athleticism in a dome for half of his games. That's fun.

Delp ran a 4.48-second 40-yard dash at his Georgia pro day, and even adjusting that for some potential pro day bias, he grades out with the second-best height-adjusted Speed Score in the class behind only Kenyon Sadiq.

Delp's production data is pretty weak, though. His max yards per team attempt and his Breakout Score hover around the 25th percentile within the tight end database.

But he also had a lot of competition at Georgia. Brock Bowers and Ladd McConkey were there for his first two seasons, and Darnell Washington was fifth on the team in receptions in Delp's freshman season.

So, did he surge after they were gone? No, not quite. In Delp's final season alongside Bowers and McConkey, he reeled in 24 catches for 284 yards and 3 touchdowns. After they left, he put up lines of 21-248-4 and 20-261-1.

Overall, though, the tight end model likes Delp a bit, given that it forgives some of the production concerns because of the combination of elite athleticism and strong draft capital.

There's more to Delp than a pure bet on traits (he had some production in college, just not a ton).

The Saints' tight end room has just one player younger than 25 (Moliki Matavao, a seventh-rounder from last year) in it. They bought into the offense with Jordyn Tyson in Round 1, and while Juwan Johnson and Noah Fant are each under contract for two more years, they're 30 and 29 already, respectively. Delp likely isn't projecting for a huge rookie season, but in a few years, he could be a cornerstone for the Saints' offense.



Eli Raridon • TE



51.5

ZAP Score

NOTRE DAME
FLEX PLAY

Low Risk Neutral High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height: 6'6 Weight: 245 NFL Team: Patriots

Statistical Comps: Dalton Keene ▪ Cole Turner ▪ Colby Parkinson

Update: Eli Raridon was the ninth tight end drafted within the first 95 picks of the 2026 NFL Draft, which really put things into context. With 27 tight ends invited to the NFL Combine and most of them grading out well athletically, some of them were going to be drafted earlier than expected, and Raridon was another such case, vaulting up from a fifth-round projected pick in mid-March to being a third-round pick on draft day.

Raridon played four seasons at Notre Dame, yet despite his size, he scored just 3 times on 48 catches over 40 games, and there are some blocking concerns. That didn't seem to affect his draft stock too much, though.

The Patriots seem good with the upside.

Raridon is 70th-percentile or better in max yards per team attempt and Breakout Score among the tight end database, and there's still a bit of that big-bodied, basketball-background archetype in Raridon's profile that we've seen lead to some really nice fantasy football production in the past.

We shouldn't ignore him (the NFL clearly didn't), and there's a lot of room for him in New England's tight end room.

Hunter Henry is 32 years old and has just one more year on his contract. Julian Hill was an undrafted free agent from the 2023 class. Other than that, Raridon should get chances.

He's a good athlete (110 height-adjusted Speed Score), he's big, and he is going to be playing alongside an MVP-caliber quarterback in Drake Maye. It's a promising landing spot for a prospect with fantasy football potential in a class with some questionable team fits and some reaches on primary blocking tight ends.



Will Kacmarek • TE

 **43.7**

ZAP Score

OHIO STATE

FLEX PLAY

Low Risk Neutral High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height: 6'6 Weight: 261 NFL Team: Dolphins

Statistical Comps: Noah Gindorff ▪ David Wells ▪ Dax Raymond

Update: Will Kacmarek was projected to go undrafted when the prospect guide was first published. The Dolphins made him a third-round pick, 87th overall.

This tight end class is something else, man.

The class is highlighted primarily by two smaller, pass-catching tight ends in Kenyon Sadiq and Eli Stowers.

Kacmarek is certainly not that. He weighed in at 261 pounds at the NFL Combine, making him the second-heaviest tight end in the class (of the 27 players invited).

Kacmarek also ran a 4.74-second 40-yard dash at a nice size for a 106.1 height-adjusted Speed Score. So, there's size and athleticism to go along with draft capital. Was there production?

Not really, no.

Kacmarek played three seasons at Ohio before transferring to Ohio State for two more years. Even at Ohio, he didn't average more than 19.0 yards per game in either season, and he caught just 23 passes in 26 games at Ohio State.

In college, Kacmarek was primarily a blocking tight end with some good per-route receiving data (the Dolphins' Instagram post welcoming Kacmarek to the team actually starts by calling him "a run-blocking specialist").

As far as Miami's tight end room is concerned, there's not much in the sense of consistent receiving production, but Kacmarek may not be the answer there.

Top-90 draft capital on a big-bodied, plus athlete isn't totally irrelevant. But the high-risk flag here suggests that Kacmarek was a reach in the NFL Draft when viewed from a fantasy football lens.



Matthew Hibner • TE



36.1

ZAP Score

SOUTHERN METHODIST

BENCHWARMER

Low Risk Neutral High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height: 6'4 Weight: 251 NFL Team: Ravens

Statistical Comps: Jake Stoneburner ▪ Schuyler Oordt ▪ Matt Furstenberg

Update: After a big run on tight ends on Day 2, it took a while for the position to be called upon on Day 3. Matthew Hibner was the first tight end taken in Round 4 when he went 133rd overall to the Baltimore Ravens, joining a tight end room that is pretty barren after the team parted ways with Isaiah Likely in the offseason.

Mark Andrews is locked up through the 2028 season, so we can't gloss over that, but Durham Smythe's contract is up after 2026. And that's really it. So, there is a pretty immediate opportunity for Hibner to be the TE2 in Baltimore.

What makes Hibner the TE10 in the class, though? It's a good question because he was projected to be a seventh-round pick (or undrafted) for most of the lead-in to the draft.

Hibner spent six years in college (four at Michigan, including 2020 when he saw no action as a freshman, and two at Southern Methodist). Despite half a dozen collegiate seasons, Hibner failed to exceed 1.0 yards per team attempt in any season after adjusting for age and schedule, and he ultimately lands in the 20th percentile by best-season max yards per team attempt in the tight end database.

However, Hibner did have competition at tight end in his career. Kind of a lot of it. The past two seasons at SMU, he shared the field with RJ Maryland, who was also invited to the NFL Combine this year. Before that, he was at Michigan, overlapping with Colston Loveland, AJ Barner, and Marlin Klein (who went 59th this year in the draft).

So, no, the production isn't amazing, but the draft capital is solid – and so is the landing spot. Now, add in the athleticism, and we have a better picture of the potential here. Hibner ran a 4.57-second 40-yard dash at the NFL Combine. That was fifth-best among tight ends who ran and equates to a height-adjusted Speed Score over 115.

He's yet another athletic tight end without a complete production profile that an NFL team bought in on during the 2026 NFL Draft, perhaps signaling a sea change for how franchises value tight end prospects in the modern NFL. Athleticism and traits may be winning out over raw receiving production.

Hibner is already 24, though, and that's the biggest knock of all. Recalibrated comps for Hibner at better draft capital than expected would paint a picture more like a Luke Willson or perhaps a Chig Okonwko on the optimistic end of things.



Justin Joly • TE



31.7

ZAP Score

NORTH CAROLINA STATE
BENCHWARMER

Low Risk Neutral High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height: 6'3 Weight: 241 NFL Team: Broncos

Statistical Comps: Ja'Tavion Sanders ▪ Harrison Bryant ▪ Austin Hooper

Update: Justin Joly is a converted wide receiver with really strong age-adjusted production numbers (including an 88th-percentile Breakout Score among the tight end database). He was a borderline top-100 pick at various points in the pre-draft process but was finally taken off the board 152nd overall by the Denver Broncos.

While the draft capital was lower than we'd like, it's actually a solid landing spot in a tight end room led by Evan Engram and featuring just one name younger than 27 years old (Caleb Lohner is 25, and he was a seventh-round pick last year). Joly hasn't turned 22 yet.

Joly didn't test athletically, and he doesn't look like a game-changer on film due to pure speed and burst. Also, he wound up weighing 241 pounds at the NFL Combine despite being listed over 260 in his final year at North Carolina State. It just wasn't the best pre-draft process for Joly, and his stock dropped.

However, if you want age-adjusted production, he has that. I mentioned the 88th-percentile Breakout Score already, and that pairs with 84th-percentile max yards per team attempt data. And the trajectory itself is intriguing. A high school wide receiver, Joly began his college career slowly with 18 catches as a freshman at Connecticut. As a sophomore, he led the team with 56 receptions for 578 yards and 2 touchdowns.

He then transferred to North Carolina State, continuing his rise with a team-high 661 yards and 4 touchdowns on 43 catches while playing alongside KC Concepcion, a first-round pick in 2026, during the 2024 season. As a senior, Joly led the Wolfpack in receptions (49) and touchdown catches (7).

His NFL career path just might come down to the draft capital. In the tight end ZAP Model, around 10% of prospects went on to log a best season (within their first three NFL years) of at least 10.0 PPR points per game. For players drafted between 100 and 200, that drops to around 6.4%. Of the ones who actually did put up good NFL seasons, they share stellar marks in max yards per team attempt. Excluding Jordan Cameron and Julius Thomas (who were basketball players in college), the hits from this draft tier averaged an 85th-percentile max yards per team attempt. Joly (84th) has that in his favor.

The age-adjusted production and the landing spot in particular keep me reasonably optimistic about Joly's outlook in Denver.



Tanner Koziol • TE

 **28.3**

ZAP Score

HOUSTON

WAIVER WIRE ADD

Low Risk **Neutral** High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height: 6'7 Weight: 247 NFL Team: Jaguars

Statistical Comps: Wes Saxton ▪ James Mitchell ▪ Charles Clay

Update: Tanner Koziol was the 12th tight end off the board in the 2026 NFL Draft and actually the second for the Jaguars, who selected blocking specialist Nate Boerkircher 56th overall.

Koziol projects to be much more of a pass-catcher between the two, which is why the fantasy-focused ZAP Model likes him more than Boerkircher despite a massive difference in their draft capital.

Koziol actually led two different offenses in receptions in his final two years of college, Ball State and Houston, respectively. He also pops in terms of an interesting stat: first downs per route run. Koziol might be a ball player.

In total, he owns a Breakout Score and a max yards per team attempt mark at or above the 85th percentile in the model. That's good stuff.

It's not just production, either. He crosses the threshold for viable athleticism.

Koziol clocked a 4.70-second 40-yard dash at the NFL Combine at 6'7" and 247 pounds, good for a 105 height-adjusted Speed Score.

He also graded out with a really good weight-adjusted burst score (vertical and broad jump). Although those aren't direct inputs in the model, it's nice to see there's more than just straight-line speed, especially given the lighter frame.

It's also looking like there just isn't much competition for Koziol after this season in Jacksonville, either. Brenton Strange, Quintin Morris, and Hunter Long have contracts that run out after 2026.

It's still late draft capital and not a ton of investment in Koziol. With that said, the names that do hit when drafted this late have possessed elite results in max yards per team attempt, and Koziol checks that box.



Joe Royer • TE

 **25.6**

ZAP Score

CINCINNATI

WAIVER WIRE ADD

Low Risk Neutral High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height: 6'5 Weight: 247 NFL Team: Browns

Statistical Comps: Cade Stover ▪ Jeremy Sprinkle ▪ Tyler Higbee

Joe Royer was ranked as high as the TE2 by some analysts before the draft, and after a strong 2024 season, you'd see his name flirting with the first round in some early mock drafts.

But after a step back in 2025, he was still on the board at pick 170 for the Cleveland Browns in a very unpredictable tight end class.

Royer played five seasons in college, logging 38 total games. He appeared in 14 games over three seasons at Ohio State (including missing time due to the passing of his mother) before transferring to Cincinnati and playing in 25 games in his final two seasons.

So, while he was far from an early declare (and while he's a bit older than we'd like at 24 years old at draft time), he didn't have a traditional five-year career.

Given the missed time, it's understandable that his Breakout Score is below average, but it's still 40th-percentile. His max yards per team attempt number is about average for the sample, and it accounts for age. That helps to balance out the profile a bit.

Royer's career arc included a 50-catch season in 2024 at Cincinnati. He broke Travis Kelce's school record of 45 catches for a tight end. Royer followed it up with 29 catches in 2025 but improved his yards per catch numbers from 10.4 to 14.3 and scored four times, one more than in 2024.

What does it all boil down to? He joins a Browns depth chart headed up by a presumable stud in Harold Fannin, and while there are a lot of other names in the room, none are locked up beyond this season, and none are younger than 26 years old.

Royer can block, move, and catch, and he's joining a Browns team that led the league in 12 personnel usage in 2025. Even with the coaching change, they could feature tight ends quite a bit under Todd Monken. Royer and Fannin could share the field plenty. It's still weak draft capital, and he's destined to be stuck behind Fannin, but he could easily evolve into one of the better TE2s in the league if the Browns commit to him over the other names on the depth chart.



Nate Boerkircher • TE

 **25.6**

ZAP Score

TEXAS A&M

WAIVER WIRE ADD

Low Risk Neutral High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height: 6'6 Weight: 245 NFL Team: Jaguars

Statistical Comps: Jackson Hawes ▪ Charlie Woerner ▪ Blake Bell

Update: There were going to be some surprises at tight end this year in the draft. It was just bound to happen. Nate Boerkircher being selected as the third tight end off the board qualifies as one. Not only that, but it's not like the position as a whole slid down the board. No, the Jaguars drafted him 56th overall.

And, to be honest, the ZAP Model hasn't handled many profiles like his before.

Boerkircher is already 24 years old and will be 25 by the time the 2026 season starts. Only two other tight ends in the ZAP Model were older than 24 and also a top-64 pick: Luke Schoonmaker and Hayden Hurst (more on them in a second).

Boerkircher is now just one of six tight ends in the model with top-64 draft capital despite a Breakout Score under 30 (his is way below that at 13.2). The other five are Dwayne Allen, Hurst, Drew Sample, Schoonmaker, and Brenton Strange (coincidentally, now his Jaguars teammate).

There's been sporadic fantasy relevance from those guys, but it's been short-lived and capped early in their careers.

However, Boerkircher didn't even test as well athletically as most of those guys did, and that matters. The model allows prospects some leeway with poor production if it's combined with plus athleticism. Boerkircher, though, logged a 4.78-second 40-yard dash – not even at the NFL Combine officially but at his pro day – so we're looking at a 93.2 height-adjusted Speed Score for Boerkircher.

Only Dwayne Allen from the aforementioned list also had a height-adjusted Speed Score below 103.

Boerkircher is a very specific case in an outlier sense. Yes, he's a second-round pick, but he lacks the athleticism and age-adjusted production that we need to see to buy in.

And, yes, Boerkircher will likely be earning snaps with investment this high. Additionally, the Jaguars' tight end room will be wide open starting in 2027 (Brenton Strange, Quintin Morris, and Hunter Long are all free agents next year). Being on the field is step one to fantasy football production, so he has that angle going for him.

With that being said, though, his profile is not the type that has turned into consistent fantasy football production in the past.



Bauer Sharp • TE



21.1

ZAP Score

LOUISIANA STATE

WAIVER WIRE ADD

Low Risk Neutral High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height: 6'5 Weight: 249 NFL Team: Buccaneers

Statistical Comps: Stephen Sullivan ▪ Jack Stoll ▪ Jake Stoneburner

Update: A better-than-projected 40-yard dash time of 4.63 at the NFL Combine raised Bauer Sharp's stock in the pre-draft model, but he was still a long shot and was projected to go undrafted at the time despite a 110 height-adjusted Speed Score.

He still is a long shot, of course, but he was a sixth-round pick, 185th overall, by the Buccaneers, who were rumored to be interested in a tight end as early as the first round.

That's because their tight end room is pretty barren behind Cade Otton, who is under contract through the 2028 season. Then there are some low-volume names in Ko Kieft and Payne Durham signed through 2026, plus Devin Culp, who is signed through 2027. There's a chance Sharp can break through here.

In college, Sharp spent three seasons at Southeastern Louisiana and was a wildcat quarterback for a time before making the move to Oklahoma and then to LSU.

To say he just moved to Oklahoma would be a little bit of an understatement: he led the team in receptions and yards in his first year as a Sooner. To get too excited about that would be a bit of an overstatement, though: he had 42 catches for 324 yards (7.7 per reception) with 2 touchdowns.

At LSU in 2025, he finished sixth on the team in catches (24) and yards (252) in his fifth and final college season.

That's still a strong overall progress curve, and it's a great story. The max yards per team attempt rate is good enough for the 38th percentile; the Breakout Score (24th percentile) is less enticing.

Additionally, while he has just two years of charted PFF data, Sharp enters with the lowest average depth of target of the class: under 5.0 yards. It's still poor when you adjust for how his tight end teammates were used.

Good athleticism with weak draft capital and production is telling us plenty about how Sharp is able to use that athleticism. It's a core philosophy of the tight end model.

As a result, Sharp isn't expected to make much of an impact on Sundays, but it's also not like he's blocked out by tough competition in Tampa Bay, leaving the door open for him to outperform expectations if the tenacity as a blocker carries over and earns him snaps and if the athleticism earns him some schemed targets.



Riley Nowakowski • TE

 **21.0**

ZAP Score

INDIANA

DART THROW

Low Risk Neutral High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height: 6'2 Weight: 250 NFL Team: Steelers

Statistical Comps: Tyler Davis ▪ Ryan Taylor ▪ Eric Saubert

Update: Riley Nowakowski feels like a Pittsburgh Steeler, and he became one with the 169th pick in the 2026 NFL Draft. But he doesn't feel like a future fantasy football star.

Nowakowski played six years in college: five of them at Wisconsin, and then his final year at Indiana.

It took a long while for him to find his footing as a tight end, and he didn't log more than 11 catches or 74 yards until his final season, when he caught 32 balls in 16 games for 387 yards (24.2 yards per game).

Adjusting all of that for age and schedule, Nowakowski just finds himself near the bottom of the tight end database in meaningful receiving metrics and Breakout Score.

Despite being a short tight end (6'2", 250), Nowakowski actually profiles more of a blocking tight end than an undersized pure receiver and spent most of his career as an inline tight end. Among this year's class, he has the lowest career route rate, via PFF.

Leading into the draft, his traits were getting him top-15 tight end draft capital projections as a top-200 pick. He got that as the TE13 at pick 169.

Now, the Steelers' tight end depth chart isn't ironclad. Pat Freiermuth is under contract through 2028, but nobody else is signed through 2027.

It's just more likely that Nowakowski is helping Pittsburgh's offense without the ball in his hands than he is helping our fantasy football teams win championships.



Josh Cuevas • TE

 **20.6**

ZAP Score

ALABAMA

WAIVER WIRE ADD

Low Risk Neutral High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height: 6'3 Weight: 245 NFL Team: Ravens

Statistical Comps: Gavin Bartholomew ▪ Grant Calcaterra ▪ Temarrick Hemingway

Update: Josh Cuevas was the second tight end that the Baltimore Ravens drafted during the 2026 NFL Draft. They first took Southern Methodist's Matthew Hibner (older, bigger, and more athletic than Cuevas) with pick 133 and then circled back to the position, grabbing Cuevas 40 picks later, 173rd overall.

But it kind of makes sense for Cuevas to have an indirect path to an NFL team: he played for three different schools – Cal Poly, Washington, and Alabama – in five years.

As you may expect, with a trajectory like that, the Breakout Score for Cuevas isn't anything to get excited about (31st percentile).

Obviously, there was increased competition with each of his landing spots, but we're tying a lot of the receiving belief in Cuevas' profile to his fifth college season at Alabama, where he was able to post a 50th-percentile max yards per team attempt rate after adjusting for schedule and age. When seeking fantasy football potential, a level of production like that is enticing for a late-round pick.

And after a deeper look at that receiving data, there are some red flags, like that Cuevas' average depth of target in 2025 wasn't great (it was better than for other Alabama tight ends – but not by a lot).

There are also some green flags, like that Cuevas' career yards after the catch per reception was better than average for incoming tight end prospects, and you see that potential on tape. He split out wide at the highest career rate (in his three years from Washington and Alabama, via PFF) among this year's class.

Given his size and skillset, Cuevas is very much in the fullback/H-tight end category and might wind up being more of a safety valve-type tight end than a primary pass-catcher in the NFL. This puts him into a bit of a high-floor, low-ceiling tier.

Not only will there be competition behind Mark Andrews, but there will also be competition with Hibner, who is more athletic (but older) than Cuevas (still just 22 years old). This again suggests more of a hybrid (i.e., low-fantasy ceiling) role for Cuevas, who just barely sneaks into the Waiver Wire Add category and who just narrowly avoids a "high risk" profile.



Jack Endries • TE



14.3

ZAP Score

TEXAS

DART THROW

Low Risk Neutral High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height: 6'5 Weight: 245 NFL Team: Bengals

Statistical Comps: Brycen Hopkins ▪ Kylen Granson ▪ Dalton Schultz

Update: Jack Endries has a strong tie to the 2025 Heisman Trophy winner, Fernando Mendoza.

They played two seasons together in 2023 and 2024 at Cal before transferring to different schools. Endries, as a redshirt sophomore, led the Golden Bears in receptions (56) and yards (623).

But their draft capital couldn't have been much different. Mendoza, of course, went first overall to the Raiders. Endries was selected 221st overall, in the seventh round, by the Bengals.

He does possess solid age-adjusted production and an athletic baseline, however.

Endries, in total, rates out with strong max yards per team attempt data (67th percentile) and good Breakout Score (73rd percentile).

He also ran a 4.62-second 40-yard dash at the NFL Combine, giving him a height-adjusted Speed Score of 109 at 6'5", 245.

On the flip side, despite a smaller frame and good athletic testing, Endries doesn't pop from a yards-after-the-catch standpoint. That's also tied to some average-to-below-average blocking scores from PFF and SportsInfoSolutions (and it's worth noting that he graded out with around 15th-percentile arm length).

Endries had a pretty wide range of pre-draft valuations, spanning from the middle of the second round to one of the first names being called on Day 3. He wound up being one of the last names called on Day 3.

The Bengals, though, have just two tight ends signed through 2027 (the 31-year-old Mike Gesicki and the 26-year-old Erick All). Endries had everything but draft capital in his profile, and at a certain point in the draft, athleticism isn't usually what wins out. It's a history of producing. That's at least some hope.

The odds he hits big are incredibly low, but if he begins to find footing in a high-octane offense like Cincinnati's, well, maybe he plays more like a Day 2 pick that some thought he could be before the draft.



Jaren Kanak • TE



13.6

ZAP Score

OKLAHOMA

DART THROW

Low Risk Neutral High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height: 6'2 Weight: 234 NFL Team: Titans

Statistical Comps: Jaheim Bell ▪ Colt Lyster ▪ Stephen Anderson

Update: Jaren Kanak has a really noteworthy profile. It wasn't leading to much in the way of projected draft capital, but he did get selected. The Titans snagged Kanak in the seventh round, 225th overall.

Kanak, a high school track athlete and dual-threat quarterback, was a four-star recruit as an athlete with interest from a lot of big programs. He ran a 4.52-second 40-yard dash at the NFL Combine, equating to a height-adjusted Speed Score of 109.2. While that's not bad by any means, virtually every tight end who ran this year graded out well by that metric. Still, the athleticism alone is noteworthy.

However, he measured in at the NFL Combine at 6'2", 234 pounds, making him both the shortest and lightest of all 27 invited tight ends. Noteworthy, though.

But get this: Kanak didn't have a catch at Oklahoma until his final season...because he was a linebacker before converting to tight end ahead of the 2025 season. Noteworthy.

So, if he got a Combine invite, he must have been relevant this year, right? Yep. He went out and caught 44 passes for 533 yards, both third-best on the Sooners, while playing alongside Combine-invited wide receiver Deion Burks.

He wound up being significantly productive when actually playing offense, so his age- and schedule-adjusted max yards per team attempt and Breakout Score are actually above average because he's still relatively young (just 22.2 years old at the time of the draft).

Transparently, Kanak has an uphill battle to fantasy football production given his size and the seventh-round status, but we've seen plenty of fantasy-relevant tight ends enter the league with minimal reps at the position – guys who came over from basketball, for example. It's the type of profile that, with more buy-in, we could get more excited about.

And, look, tight end isn't a strength for the Titans. Gunnar Helm, a fourth-rounder last year, is set to be the TE1 for them after a promising rookie campaign, and Daniel Bellinger is inked through 2028 after signing with the team this offseason. Kanak could get some schemed touches. He's just unlikely to morph into a high-snap, high-touch player at his size.



John Michael Gyllenborg • TE



10.5

ZAP Score

WYOMING

DART THROW

Low Risk Neutral High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height: 6'6 Weight: 249 NFL Team: Undrafted

Statistical Comps: Virgil Green ▪ Chris Gragg ▪ Zack Kuntz

John Michael Gyllenborg had some top-tier athletic testing, but we'll circle back to that – because his profile probably needs some context first.

After redshirting in 2021 (he didn't even play football until his senior year in high school), Gyllenborg was at Wyoming for four more years, maxing out with a 30-catch, 425-yard, 3-touchdown season in 2024, all career highs (or matching a career high, in the case of touchdowns) in a low-volume passing offense.

Adjusting his best season for age and schedule, Gyllenborg's max yards per team attempt does grade out well (69th percentile in the tight end database), yet his Breakout Score is about average despite that.

Gyllenborg logged just nine games in each of his final two seasons at Wyoming, missing time with various injuries, including a hamstring issue in 2025. That could easily have held back his true upside; the receiving production could've been better if he were healthier. Along those lines, his average depth of target was basically cut in half (12.4 to 6.6, via PFF) from 2024 to 2025. So, yes, it was a production decline – but at least it had some explanation.

The Combine-tested broad jump and vertical were great, as was the shuttle time. He ran a 4.60-second 40-yard dash at 6'6", 249 pounds (a 114.2 height-adjusted Speed Score), but size and scores like that are getting more and more common, particularly in this class.

While that doesn't necessarily mean that he's just another guy, it does mean that his draft capital will tell us whether NFL teams are buying into that size, athleticism, and production from a smaller school while also being tied to some iffy blocking tape.

It's a pretty decent profile that won't mean anything without a franchise buying in, but it's also not displaying many traits of elite fantasy football production, either.



Dallen Bentley • TE



10.1

ZAP Score

UTAH

DART THROW

Low Risk Neutral High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height: 6'4	Weight: 253	NFL Team: Broncos
-------------	-------------	-------------------

Statistical Comps: Jerell Adams ▪ Luke Willson ▪ AJ Derby

Update: Dallen Bentley's pre-draft big board rankings were all over the place, and he just barely got drafted, 256th overall, to the Denver Broncos. He was the second tight end the team drafted, after Justin Joly in the fifth round.

Speaking of wide-ranging, let's talk about Bentley's college profile. Bentley didn't draw much attention coming out of high school and did mission work before he played his first college ball at Snow College, where he didn't do much (just eight catches in eight games).

He then transferred to Utah in 2023, playing special teams and some tight end initially. He finished the year with one catch over seven games. In 2024, he played 12 games, yet caught 2 passes for 15 yards.

Clearly, his 2025 season is what garnered him a Combine invite. This past season, Bentley hauled in 48 passes for 620 yards (both second-best on the team) for a team-high 6 scores. As we'd expect, the Breakout Score and age-adjusted max yards per team attempt data are subpar with a trajectory like that, and he's already 25 years old.

Bentley played in a high-average depth of target offense at Utah, yet he still saw a higher average depth of target than his fellow Ute tight ends in 2025. As a result, he's third among this year's class in career average depth of target, via PFF data.

Bentley's athletic testing is also noteworthy. He ran a 4.62-second 40-yard dash after clocking in at 6'4", 253 pounds, good for a height-adjusted Speed Score of 111.1. We can't get overly excited about the athleticism, given that it wasn't tied to relevant draft capital.

There really isn't a long-term solution on the Broncos' roster at tight end. Evan Engram is a free agent in 2027, and while Joly projects as a good pass-catcher, he was only a fifth-rounder. Bentley probably can find some snaps but is unlikely to garner big receiving volume.



RJ Maryland • TE



7.1

ZAP Score

SOUTHERN METHODIST
DART THROW

Low Risk Neutral High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height: 6'4 Weight: 236 NFL Team: Undrafted

Statistical Comps: Caleb Wilson ▪ Colt Lyster ▪ Bucky Hodges

Based on age- and schedule-adjusted data, RJ Maryland is one of the better receiving tight ends in this year's class – and, frankly, in the entire tight end database.

But you wouldn't know it based on the pre-draft hype, which is why the ZAP Score and the comps are uninspiring. Maryland, the son of Russell Maryland (the first overall pick in the 1991 NFL Draft), is projected to go undrafted most places you look.

Maryland tore his ACL during the 2024 season, ending with just seven games played. But he bounced back with a solid senior year and ran a 4.51-second 40-yard dash, tied for second-fastest among runners in this year's class.

We have to point out that Maryland weighed in as the second-lightest tight end at the Combine at just 236 pounds. His weight-adjusted vertical was also poor, yet we've seen plenty of other pass-catching tight ends play well despite that being the case (Zach Ertz, OJ Howard, Dalton Schultz types) though those players were all bigger and heavier.

Let's look at some of that production I've mentioned. Maryland spent all four college seasons at Southern Methodist, churning out 113 catches, 1,495 yards, and 19 touchdowns in 46 games, finishing with a career 13.2 yards per catch rate. He also maintained at least 1.60 yards per route run, per PFF, for each of the last three seasons: really solid for a tight end.

And for additional context here, Maryland put up these good numbers sharing time with Jordan Hudson (a Combine-invited receiver), Romello Brinson (a draft-eligible receiver), and Matthew Hibner (a Combine-invited tight end). Maryland was still pretty productive as a freshman with Rashee Rice logging 96 catches for 1,355 yards in 2022.

But if none of this age-adjusted data and a still-young draft age (he won't turn 22 until July) is getting NFL teams excited, then there's not much we can do. Maryland is small, even compared to a light tight end class. He may not transition to a plus blocker in the NFL, which he wasn't able to do in college. That might keep NFL teams from investing in his skillset.



Michael Trigg • TE



7.0

ZAP Score

BAYLOR
FLEX PLAY

Low Risk Neutral High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height: 6'4 Weight: 240 NFL Team: Undrafted

Statistical Comps: Cade Stover ▪ Evan Rodriguez ▪ Tyler Higbee

Michael Trigg's profile is that of a well-rounded athlete. He played defensive end and basketball in high school and earned four-star recruiting status before heading to Southern California, the first of three NCAA schools for which he suited up.

Trigg played only six games as a Trojan in 2021 and then seven and three games at Ole Miss in 2022 and 2023, respectively. Across those 16 games, he totaled just 28 catches for 330 yards and 5 touchdowns.

But then at Baylor in 2024, Trigg notched 30 catches for 395 yards and 3 touchdowns and built on it in 2025: 50 grabs for 694 yards and 6 touchdowns, ranking top-three on the team in each of those categories in his final NCAA season.

Even with that slow start, his best season by age- and schedule-adjusted max yards per team attempt is about average among the tight end database, as was his Breakout Score.

We do have to note, though, that Trigg missed time not only for injuries but also for off-field incidents, and while it's possible that the production profile could've been markedly better, film and scouting grades put his blocking into question. It could all be interconnected. I'm focused on the data, but this is part of the equation with Trigg, whose draft stock has been declining in the months leading up to the NFL Draft.

For us as fantasy football managers, we care a lot about the receiving production, but we also know that poor blocking and commitment can mean reduced snaps. It can also translate into a new-age tight end who is tasked more with receiving than blocking. Trigg's yards per route run data was good at all his stops, including a 2.18 mark in his last season, and he led this year's Combine-invited class in slot rate, per PFF. That's what makes him appealing as a fantasy football prospect. He could be a good-to-great NFL receiver.

Trigg's long arms and big hands, as measured at the Combine, help make for a highlight-level catch radius, which he certainly flashed on tape. The big board rank has been falling, but if an NFL team sees it differently and applies some capital in the late-Round-2 or middle-of-Round 3 range where he peaked, he draws some Tucker Kraft and Brenton Strange comps. Trigg could be legit if an NFL team uses him to his best abilities.



Dae'Quan Wright • TE



6.9

ZAP Score

MISSISSIPPI

DART THROW

Low Risk Neutral High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height: 6'4	Weight: 246	NFL Team: Undrafted
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Statistical Comps: Zach Davidson ▪ Noah Gray ▪ Virgil Green

Dae'Quan Wright began his college career at Virginia Tech, making a bit of an impact (19 catches for 208 yards) as a true freshman in 2022. He then saw his role expand as a Hokie in 2023 but wound up transferring to Ole Miss and finding paydirt nine times in 28 games while being more involved as a receiver.

Overall, Wright's max yards per team attempt is a slight tick above the sample average, and his Breakout Score is about average. That's not bad, especially if he's as fast as his game tape makes him look.

While he didn't run the 40 at the NFL Combine, his yards-after-catch ability and downfield attention are what separate his profile from many in this year's class. Wright easily leads this year's tight end class in career yards after the catch per reception, per PFF, and he's 11th (out of 27 combine-invited tight ends) in average depth of target – fractions of a yard away from a top-eight number.

This all makes more sense when you learn that he had actually made some starts for Ole Miss as a wide receiver. That's a very important wrinkle to his profile, as we're obviously seeking receiving production at the NFL level.

Given the time at wide receiver and enough positives in his profile, Wright has the potential to become a relevant tight end in the NFL for fantasy purposes, but it's hard to make him a true priority in rookie drafts. His blocking seems like enough of a concern that he could find it hard to earn reliable snaps, and it seems to be reducing his draft capital.

From a fantasy football standpoint, he could be one of the bigger overperformers among this year's tight end class in the right situation. That situation being that his draft capital stays low (Round 6), but a team uses him as a big-bodied receiver and doesn't care that his blocking is below average. There's legitimate fantasy football potential here for Wright, but it's a profile that requires an NFL team buying into what he does best.



DJ Rogers • TE



6.9

ZAP Score

TEXAS CHRISTIAN
DART THROW

Low Risk Neutral High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height: 6'4 Weight: 258 NFL Team: Undrafted

Statistical Comps: Beau Reliford ▪ Mason Schreck ▪ Ben Koyack

DJ Rogers isn't really registering on the tight end model much at all.

He played five years at TCU but didn't catch more than 12 passes until his fifth and final year, when he caught 34 balls for 319 yards (9.4 yards per reception) and 2 touchdowns.

In total, Rogers averaged under 1.4 yards per route run over his final three seasons, per PFF, and he was an underneath receiver by average depth of target, even after adjusting for team context.

Despite that profile – which includes some size and athleticism – film and scouting grades aren't in agreement with his baseline blocking ability, generally skewing toward the pessimistic end of the spectrum.

His lack of a good Breakout Score or peak receiving season hurts his potential for future fantasy football success. Profiles similar to Rogers' occasionally hit with some tangential fantasy relevance but rarely are tied to consistent fantasy production.

Rogers weighed in at 258 pounds at the Combine, third-heaviest in the class (out of 27 Combine-invited tight ends), and a long arm measurement could get a team interested solely based on his size.

Unfortunately, he didn't run the 40 at the Combine, so maybe a great pro day 40 vaults him up the draft board a bit, but as it is, Rogers is likely a fantasy afterthought who would spend more time blocking than running routes for an NFL team.



Lake McRee • TE



6.8

ZAP Score

SOUTHERN CALIFORNIA

DART THROW

Low Risk Neutral High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height: 6'4 Weight: 243 NFL Team: Undrafted

Statistical Comps: Quintin Morris ▪ Rory Anderson ▪ Drake Dunsmore

Lake McRee hits the NFL Draft process after five seasons at Southern California, ultimately finishing his career with 97 catches, 1,154 yards, and 7 touchdowns.

He had a production jump in 2025, turning 30 catches into 450 yards and 4 touchdowns: all career-high outputs. Whether with low volume or high (again, a max of 30 catches), McRee did average at least 10.1 yards per catch in all five seasons, ending his college career with an 11.9-yard career yards per catch rate – and a 15.0-yard mark as a fifth-year senior.

McRee's pretty light at 243 pounds, and he didn't test at the Combine (he only benched, resulting in 22 reps). Bench reps actually correlate pretty well with NFL receiving production for tight ends, and McRee is near that inflection point (around 24 reps when receiving correlations really start to swing as a whole).

In total, the max yards per team attempt and Breakout Score for McRee puts him around the 35th percentile for tight ends in the database. It's enough to keep us interested but only if draft capital follows.

Unlikely to evolve into a dominant run blocker at his size (including small hands and short arms), McRee profiles mostly as an average-to-below-average athlete after two ACL tears (one in high school and one in college).

There's unlikely to be much spike potential from McRee at the next level.



Miles Kitselman • TE



6.2

ZAP Score

TENNESSEE

DART THROW

Low Risk Neutral High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height: 6'5 Weight: 251 NFL Team: Undrafted

Statistical Comps: Payne Durham ▪ Jackson Hawes ▪ James O'Shaughnessy

Poor athletic testing was rare for tight ends at the Combine this year.

Of course, only 20 of 27 Combine-invited tight ends ran the 40, but of those who did, only one ran slower than a 4.74: Miles Kitselman (4.90). That equates to an 88.2 height-adjusted Speed Score. That's 12th-percentile in the tight end model.

That doesn't automatically mean there's nothing in the profile to get excited about. Because even with that athleticism, Kitselman is drawing late-round draft projections, which makes him more interesting than most slow tight ends. It can mean there's something here with the production. Was there?

Eh.

Kitselman started off his college career at Hutchinson Community College and then spent two years at Alabama before transferring elsewhere in the SEC to Tennessee.

In 2024, Kitselman was fifth in receiving (301 yards) for the Volunteers in a crowded offense with Dont'e Thornton, Bru McCoy, and Chris Brazzell. He was fifth again in receiving (253 yards) in 2025 and struggled with drops.

There's a lack of explosiveness in the data (his career-long catch is 31 yards), and his vertical and broad jumps were weak, as well.

Even if drafted, Kitselman rates out more as a helpful piece to the offense as a strong blocker than as a fantasy football stud.



Khalil Dinkins • TE



5.2

ZAP Score

PENN STATE
DART THROW

Low Risk Neutral High Risk

Draft Capital Δ

Height: 6'4 Weight: 251 NFL Team: Undrafted

Statistical Comps: Bruno Labelle ▪ Shaun Beyer ▪ Keenen Brown

Khalil Dinkins is expected to go undrafted despite a 6'4", 251-pound frame.

Dinkins capped out at 14 catches and 167 yards in a single season at Penn State, and no matter how you slice the numbers, he's toward the bottom of the tight end database in terms of adjusted production.

He did post some good size-adjusted agility data at the Combine, but the explosiveness results were below-average, and the height-adjusted Speed Score (based on his 4.72-second 40-yard dash) is just about average.

Dinkins also repped 225 on the bench 25 times, which is over the threshold where we tend to see a signal that the given tight end is more of a blocking tight end than a receiving tight end.

He could find a spot on an NFL roster as a big-bodied, blocking tight end with some situational pass-catching opportunities, but at the end of the day, the receiving profile is too pedestrian to ignore for Dinkins when we're seeking pure fantasy football upside.

The Year 2 Model

Overview

There's a video game called *Rocket League* that's been around for a minute, and it's still wildly popular. At its core, it's simple: car soccer. You control a car and try to smash a ball into your opponent's goal.

I've played it on and off for years. It's one of those games you can jump into for 20 or 30 minutes, knock out a few five-minute matches, and move on.

When you queue up for an online game, *Rocket League* pairs you with teammates and opponents who have similar skill ratings. In theory, everyone on the field should be roughly equal.

In practice? Not always.

You can play with friends, but if you queue solo for a two-on-two or three-on-three match, you're paired with random teammates.

And those players can be total wildcards.

Within the first minute or two, you usually figure it out. Maybe your teammate is clearly outmatched. Maybe they're excellent, but their rating is suppressed by bad luck or poor teammates in previous games.

Your expectations adjust quickly once you see real information.

The same thing happens in fantasy football.

Prospects enter the league with a set of expectations based on what we knew about them coming out of college. Then they play actual NFL games. Suddenly, we have new data that either reinforces or challenges those original assumptions.

The question is: how much should those expectations change?



That's where the Year 2 Model comes in.

The goal of the Year 2 Model is to do a better job predicting a player's future performance — specifically his Year 2 through Year 4 B2S — than simply leaning on his rookie-season points per game.

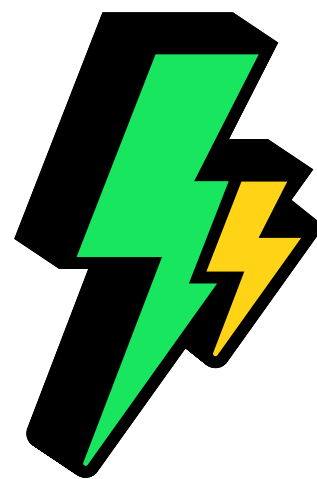
At both running back and wide receiver, the Year 2 Model combines a player's prospect score, certain rookie-season production inputs, and his rookie-year fantasy points per game to generate a Year 2 score. That score is designed to recalibrate expectations using both pre-draft information and what we actually saw on the field.

In previous iterations, the model focused on a player's best season in either Year 2 or Year 3. This year, that window has been expanded through Year 4.

Why? Because it gives us a larger, more stable sample to work with. Expanding the window allows the model to better capture delayed breakouts, injury interruptions, and uneven early-career development — all things that can distort shorter evaluations.

As you'd expect, the Year 2 Model does a much better job predicting a player's next three seasons than rookie-year points per game alone.

Just like the ZAP Model, the Year 2 Model can be summarized through probability tables. Players are grouped into the same categories you've already seen — Legendary Performer, Elite Producer, and so on — allowing us to clearly see how often different tiers of players go on to hit specific B2S thresholds.



Wide Receiver (Best Two-Year Average; Years 2-4)

	>10	>12	>14	>16	>18	>20
Legendary Performer	100.0%	100.0%	90.0%	60.0%	30.0%	30.0%
Elite Producer	88.9%	81.5%	74.1%	59.3%	22.2%	7.4%
Weekly Starter	61.8%	38.2%	21.8%	18.2%	1.8%	0.0%
Flex Play	15.3%	7.3%	2.4%	1.6%	0.0%	0.0%
Benchwarmer	1.6%	0.8%	0.0%	0.0%	0.0%	0.0%
Waiver Wire Add	1.1%	1.1%	0.0%	0.0%	0.0%	0.0%
Dart Throw	0.0%	0.0%	0.0%	0.0%	0.0%	0.0%

Running Back (Best Two-Year Average; Years 2-4)

	>10	>12	>14	>16	>18	>20
Legendary Performer	100.0%	100.0%	100.0%	75.0%	75.0%	75.0%
Elite Producer	73.9%	65.2%	56.5%	34.8%	21.7%	17.4%
Weekly Starter	60.5%	37.2%	18.6%	14.0%	7.0%	4.7%
Flex Play	27.3%	14.8%	6.8%	2.3%	2.3%	0.0%
Benchwarmer	7.4%	3.7%	1.9%	1.9%	1.9%	0.0%
Waiver Wire Add	2.5%	1.7%	1.7%	0.0%	0.0%	0.0%
Dart Throw	0.0%	0.0%	0.0%	0.0%	0.0%	0.0%

The Year 2 Model is more predictive than the ZAP Model. Period. That's not because the ZAP Model is flawed. It's because we simply have more information. Once a player has completed his rookie season, we're no longer projecting how he might handle NFL competition — we've seen it.

We're deeper into the Rocket League match now. We've watched our teammate play. The skill rating makes more sense.

One thing you may notice when looking at the tables above is that the Year 2 Model behaves a little differently at running back than it does at wide receiver. Every elite Year 2–4 wide receiver lands in the Weekly Starter tier or above. At running back, though, a few productive players slip through the cracks.

There are real football reasons for that.

Running back production is often dictated by coaching decisions. If a staff wants a split backfield, it gets one. And for fantasy

purposes, split backfields are a problem — they lower ceilings and introduce volatility.

A running back can have a strong rookie season, but if his team decides to change roles, add competition, or rethink usage, that production doesn't always carry forward.

Wide receivers are different. There are more of them on the field. More routes. More chances to earn targets. When opportunity expands, talent tends to win out. That's ultimately what these models are trying to capture — talent — and it's why wide receiver outcomes are generally more predictable.

Running back is also a more replaceable position. That doesn't mean backs aren't valuable; it means teams know they can find usable production later in the draft or in free agency. When supply is high, demand drops — and that creates instability.

That instability shows up clearly in the data.

From 2011 through 2023, there were six running backs selected after Pick 100 who averaged at least 12 PPR points per game as rookies (minimum seven games played, relevant fantasy weeks only). When looking at those players' performances from Year 2 through Year 4, every single one of them peaked as a rookie. None improved their fantasy production after Year 1.

Ask yourself why that might be.

From a general manager's perspective, a Day 3 rookie having a big season doesn't automatically mean he's a long-term solution. Was it real talent? Or was it circumstance? Scheme? Injuries elsewhere?

Front offices will likely second guess themselves, wondering why that running back fell to the third day of the draft in the first place, regardless of his rookie-season production.

Because running backs are relatively easy to replace — and relatively inexpensive — teams often introduce competition quickly. That competition suppresses long-term fantasy ceilings, especially for later-round players.

In other words, rookie-year running back production is incredibly volatile.



That volatility is exactly why the Year 2 Model matters. It properly weighs rookie production within the broader context of prospect quality, role stability, and historical outcomes. It's not taking Year 1 numbers at face value.

Journey Comparables

At some point, every fantasy analyst ends up asking the same question:

Have we seen this before?

When something weird happens in the league, we ask it. When a player posts an absurd stat line, we ask it. When a team wins nine straight games by a field goal or less, we ask it.

The Year 2 Model helps answer that question through Journey Comparables.

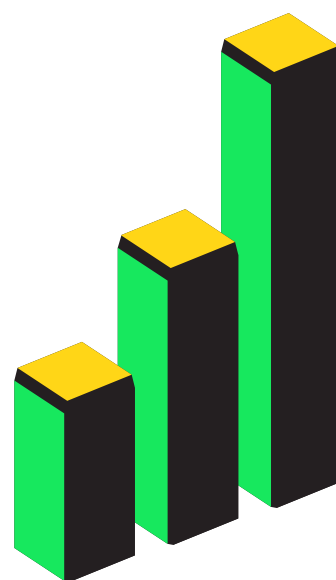
You've already seen statistical comparables tied to the ZAP Model. Journey Comparables are different. Instead of comparing player attributes as they enter the league, they compare players based on how their evaluation changes.

Specifically, Journey Comparables look at a player's ZAP score alongside his Year 2 Model score and identify historical players who followed a similar path — from pre-draft expectations to post-rookie-season reality.

They ignore play style, size, athletic testing, and role. The only thing that matters is the journey: how a player was viewed entering the league, and how that view changed after Year 1.

History doesn't repeat itself perfectly.

But in fantasy football, it rhymes often enough to matter.



2026 Year 2 Profiles

Overview

Drafting Kaleb Johnson was one of the most painful experiences a dynasty manager could've had last year. Drafting Luther Burden? It took a minute, but his managers are probably feeling pretty good right now.

But what happens next?

That's where the Year 2 Model profiles step in.

Over this final section of the guide, you'll get analysis on every wide receiver and running back from last year's draft class who ranks as at least a Flex Play in the Year 2 Model.

You'll see how the Year 2 Model scores them, and you'll get insight on how to manage each player moving forward.

It's time to fix those dynasty rosters.

Key Terms

ZAP Score: The score given to an incoming rookie in the ZAP Model. It's based on the factors outlined in the ZAP Model Overview section of this guide. All scores range from 0 to 100.

Y2 Score: The score given to a running back or wide receiver in the Year 2 Model. This is based on rookie-season numbers along with a player's ZAP score. All scores range from 0 to 100.

Y2 Score Category: Every player's Year 2 score coincides with one of seven categories, which were talked about earlier. Those categories will be listed on every player's Year 2 profile page.

Journey Comparables: Players in history who have had similar ZAP and Year 2 Model scores.

Year 2 Wide Receiver



Elite Producer

Tetairoa McMillan..... 138

Emeka Egbuka..... 139

Luther Burden..... 140



Weekly Starter

Jayden Higgins..... 141

Travis Hunter..... 142



Flex Play

Elic Ayomanor..... 143

Matthew Golden..... 144

Pat Bryant..... 145

Tre Harris..... 146

Chimere Dike..... 147

Jaylin Noel..... 148

Jack Bech..... 149

Isaac TeSlaa..... 150

Isaiah Bond..... 151

Kyle Williams..... 152

Tory Horton..... 153

Tez Johnson..... 154



Tetairoa McMillan • WR

88.3

Y2 Score

CAROLINA PANTHERS
ELITE PRODUCER


82.7

ZAP Score

Journey Comps: Brian Thomas ▪ AJ Brown ▪ Justin Jefferson

Tetairoa McMillan wants to be called T-Mac. Just before interviewing him on Radio Row back in early February, his reps approached us and stressed that point. T-Mac. Nothing but T-Mac.

And honestly, I'll call him whatever he wants after his fantastic rookie season. The man balled out.

McMillan – sorry, T-Mac – finished his rookie campaign with a 25.4% target share and a 1.84 yards-per-route-run rate. Since 2011, the only rookie wide receivers to clear both a 25% target share and a 1.80 yards-per-route-run mark are Odell Beckham, Mike Evans, Puka Nacua, Justin Jefferson, Brian Thomas, Malik Nabers, Drake London, Chris Olave, and... Kelvin Benjamin.

That's a lot of insane wide receiver talent. And Kelvin Benjamin.

Looking at first-down share, T-Mac clears again. His per-game first-down share sat at 32.4% last season, the fourth-highest mark among all wide receivers in the Year 2 Model database. The three players ahead of him? Malik Nabers, Odell Beckham Jr., and Puka Nacua.

Pretty great company!

T-Mac averaged just 12.4 PPR points per game thanks to a below-average catchable target rate and an offense that ranked in the bottom five in pass rate over expected. Those two factors could limit his ceiling a bit moving forward – Bryce Young isn't the most complete quarterback, and Dave Canales leans toward a run-centric offense. Over his two years in Carolina, the Panthers have had below-average pass rate over expected numbers.

That's the thing that might stop T-Mac. Because from a talent perspective, McMillan has the tools to be a true difference-maker at the next level. His Journey Comparables of A.J. Brown and Justin Jefferson underscore that point.

If you've got McMillan on your dynasty squad, you should feel great about it. The ceiling is high if the circumstances surrounding him improve. Even if they don't, he should still be very usable.



Emeka Egbuka • WR

77.7

Y2 Score

TAMPA BAY BUCCANEERS
ELITE PRODUCER


81.5

ZAP Score

Journey Comps: Kendall Wright ▪ Allen Robinson ▪ Rome Odunze

Emeka Egbuka's rookie season is difficult to summarize without sounding dramatic. Because the production split is genuinely extreme.

Over the first five weeks of the season, Egbuka averaged more than 20 PPR points per game. From that point forward, his average fell to just 8.3. That's not a gradual decline – that's a cliff.

When researching his profile, the first thing I wanted to know was whether this kind of early-season surge followed by a prolonged drop-off actually shows up in historical data. Have we seen rookie wide receivers start this strong and then fade this dramatically?

The answer? Not really.

Among Year 2 Model wide receivers, a drop like this simply hasn't happened. Puka Nacua averaged over 20 PPR points per game through Week 6 as a rookie, but finished the season closer to 16. Calvin Ridley is a better comparison – he averaged 19.7 PPR points per game through Week 4 of his rookie year before falling to 10.7 the rest of the way. Even then, that decline wasn't nearly as severe as what we saw from Egbuka.

That's why it's important to zoom out and look at the full sample. Egbuka entered the league with a strong ZAP score, and his full-season rookie numbers were impressive: a 1.75 yards per route run rate, a target share just shy of 24%, and the second-most first downs among wideouts in his draft class.

Egbuka also lands in excellent company with his Year 2 Model score of 77.7. Within the Year 2 Model database – prior to this most recent draft class – we've seen eight wide receivers with Year 2 scores within three points of Egbuka's who also posted a yards-per-route-run rate north of 1.60. Those players? Allen Robinson, DJ Moore, DK Metcalf, Terry McLaurin, Chase Claypool, Amon-Ra St. Brown, Rashee Rice, and Zay Flowers.

Not bad.

We shouldn't call Egbuka bust-proof – just take a look at that first Journey Comparable – but landing in the Elite Producer category gives him strong odds to be at least a WR2 in fantasy football moving forward. Especially now that Mike Evans is gone. And especially when his 58% catchable targets rate – a 4th percentile number – regresses favorably.



Luther Burden • WR

77.4

Y2 Score

CHICAGO BEARS

ELITE PRODUCER



87.7

ZAP Score

Journey Comps: Brandin Cooks ▪ Xavier Worthy ▪ DJ Moore

The ZAP Model has an almost irrational love for Luther Burden. You saw it in last year's guide, but the latest iteration of the model may like him even more.

That might not be a bad thing.

Burden didn't see the route share we were hoping for in 2025 – he failed to reach a 70% route share in a single game – and that limited him to just 8.6 PPR points per game in relevant contests.

That low points-per-game output is a little concerning. The Year 2 Model dates back to 2011, and only 20 wide receivers in the database who averaged fewer than 10 PPR points per game as rookies went on to post a 14-plus PPR points-per-game season in Years 2, 3, or 4. That's out of hundreds of wide receivers.

Burden, however, wasn't quite like those other players. When he did get on the field, he was excellent.

Burden finished the season with a 2.69 yards per route run rate – the third-best rookie-season mark since 2011, trailing only Martavis Bryant and Odell Beckham (minimum 100 routes). He was also targeted on nearly 25% of his routes run.

That combination is rare, even among lower-volume wide receivers. Burden ran just 242 regular-season routes in 2025. Among Year 2 Model wideouts with between 150 and 350 routes run, only nine managed to post a yards-per-route-run rate above 2.0 and earn targets on at least 20% of their routes. Four of those nine went on to produce a season of 15 or more PPR points per game between Years 2 and 4.

There's no doubt that projecting Burden to his ceiling requires some optimism. The volume wasn't there in Year 1, and with a 45% slot rate (per PFF), we still haven't seen him consistently win on the outside.

The good news is that the ZAP Model already loved him, and when Burden actually received opportunities in 2025, almost everything pointed in the right direction. Xavier Worthy is a difficult Journey Comparable to fully buy into, but a Brandin Cooks or DJ Moore outcome is well within reason. And those paths are even more realistic now that DJ Moore is out of Chicago.

If you want a high-ceiling, higher-volatility wide receiver target in dynasty this offseason, Burden's definitely your guy. Just be aware that the market has become far more bullish post-DJ Moore trade.



Jayden Higgins • WR

63.9

Y2 Score

HOUSTON TEXANS

WEEKLY STARTER



65.5

ZAP Score

Journey Comps: Michael Pittman ▪ Dante Pettis ▪ Davante Adams

The Texans were pretty infuriating with their wide receiver usage in 2025, rotating players frequently and often giving Xavier Hutchinson more snaps than rookie Jayden Higgins. As a result, Higgins finished the regular season with just a 56% route share – a figure that ranked below players like Van Jefferson and David Sills.

When you include the playoffs, though, things look a little different. Higgins reached an 80% route share three times last year, and in those games, he scored 11.9, 10.3, and 13.4 PPR points. In his next-highest route share game (68%), he posted 13.8 PPR points.

Maybe let him run more routes?

From an efficiency standpoint, Higgins' rookie-year metrics were perfectly respectable. His 1.45 yards per route run was fairly ordinary for a first-year wide receiver, and he was targeted on fewer than 20% of his routes. His catch rate over expected was exactly average – literally 0%.

That said, Higgins was still better than both Christian Kirk and Xavier Hutchinson in Houston last season, the two wide receivers he was competing with most for snaps. He outpaced them in yards per route run, EPA per target, and catch rate over expected, while also posting an average depth of target north of 12 yards.

“Solid” is probably the best word to describe Higgins' rookie season. He was used primarily as an intermediate option, and he mostly got the job done. With Hutchinson as beatable competition and Kirk no longer on the team, there's a legitimate path for Higgins to step into a larger role in Year 2.

And that's exciting, because Higgins' Journey Comps are pretty interesting. They do paint a very high-variance picture, though.



Travis Hunter • WR

62.6

Y2 Score

JACKSONVILLE JAGUARS

WEEKLY STARTER



82.4

ZAP Score

Journey Comps: Quentin Johnston ▪ Henry Ruggs ▪ Alshon Jeffery

Travis Hunter will go down as one of the most difficult prospect evaluations I've ever had. The ZAP Model was never particularly fond of him, and the updated version likes him even less. That's largely because his collegiate analytical profile simply wasn't anything to write home about.

You can excuse some of that given Hunter's two-way role at Colorado, but that versatility only added more uncertainty to his projection. Still, thanks to his draft capital, he was slotted into the top tier of last year's rookie drafts.

At one point, it looked like Hunter might justify that investment. He appeared to be on the verge of becoming Jacksonville's top target earner before an LCL injury cut his rookie season short. That injury forced the Jaguars' front office to act, and they responded by acquiring veteran wide receiver Jakobi Meyers at the deadline.

Hunter's LCL may end up having longer-term fantasy implications. Jacksonville ultimately gave Meyers a new deal, locking him in through at least the 2027 season. While Hunter was sidelined, Parker Washington emerged as a viable slot option. And Brian Thomas remains entrenched on the outside with multiple years left on his rookie contract. (We'll see if that changes or not.)

So where does that leave Hunter in this offense?

The Jaguars don't have to force the issue with him. And analytically speaking, it's fair to ask whether they should. Nothing from Hunter's 2025 season meaningfully challenges his ZAP score. A 1.32 yards-per-route-run rate is underwhelming, and Jacksonville didn't target him at a particularly high rate when he was on the field – just 20% of his routes run saw a target. The breakout felt like it might be coming, but we can't say with confidence that it ever truly arrived.

Add in reporting from ESPN suggesting that Jacksonville views Hunter primarily as a cornerback with situational offensive packages, and the outlook becomes even murkier. As a dynasty manager, that's a tough pill to swallow.

In the short term – especially looking ahead to 2026 – the Jaguars have legitimate offensive options at wide receiver, and all signs point toward Hunter settling into something less than a lead role.

Hunter was more of a sell earlier in the offseason when the reporting wasn't as obvious about his role – his value on Keep Trade Cut has fallen by a decent bit since January. Now, you may have to wait for positive news to make any sort of sell move.



Elic Ayomanor • WR

59.3

Y2 Score

TENNESSEE TITANS

FLEX PLAY



36.0

ZAP Score

Journey Comps: Kenny Stills ▪ Tyjae Sharpe ▪ Darnell Mooney

It wasn't easy playing in the Titans' offense in 2025. Cam Ward finished the year with PFF's third-worst passing grade among quarterbacks with 200-plus drop backs, ahead of only Cleveland's Dillon Gabriel and Shedeur Sanders. His completion percentage over expected checked in at -3.0%, the fourth-lowest mark in the league.

That inefficiency bled directly into the pass-catching group. Elic Ayomanor, in particular, had it rough, finishing 71st among 76 qualified wide receivers in catchable target rate. Despite posting a respectable 18% target share as a rookie, Ayomanor averaged just 7.2 PPR points per game in relevant contests. That production was driven by inefficiency – his yards per route run rate sat at just 1.02.

Profiles like this don't hit at a high rate. In the Year 2 Model database, there are nine wide receivers – 10 if you include Ayomanor – who recorded a Year 1 target share between 15% and 20% while posting a yards-per-route-run rate below 1.20. That group includes Ace Sanders, Demarcus Ayers, Sterling Shepard, Tajae Sharpe, Corey Davis, Zay Jones, Jonathan Mingo, Rome Odunze, and Xavier Legette.

The only truly intriguing name there is Odunze, but he stands apart from the rest after posting by far the best yards per team pass attempt in the group. That's a metric that tends to be highly predictive. From that perspective, he's more the exception than the rule.

Ayomanor's Journey Comparables help clarify what his role could look like with an improved Cam Ward. During his two relevant seasons at Stanford, Ayomanor posted average depth of target rates north of 14 yards. That trend mostly carried over to the NFL, where his aDOT ranked well above average among wide receivers with 50-plus targets. His top pre-draft comp was Torrey Smith, and additional Journey Comparables like Kenny Stills and Darnell Mooney fit the same downfield mold.

Those comps aren't archetype matches, but they help frame Ayomanor properly. He's a player capable of spiked weeks and splash plays.

Given his talent profile, sustained fantasy consistency is unlikely. That's why the Flex Play tag fits him well. With that being said, the market is completely off of Ayomanor right now – you could easily argue that the Year 2 Model likes him more. So, from that perspective, it may not be a bad idea to get him as a trade throw-in.



Matthew Golden • WR

58.6

Y2 Score

GREEN BAY PACKERS

FLEX PLAY



68.5

ZAP Score

Journey Comps: Justin Hunter ▪ KJ Hamler ▪ Adonai Mitchell

There were plenty of red flags in Matthew Golden's prospect profile. For a first-round pick, his Breakout Score wasn't particularly strong, and his best single-season yards per route run mark was just 2.10 – a bottom-10 figure in last year's draft class.

Coming out of his rookie season, things didn't improve.

Golden's ZAP score was buoyed by strong draft capital, but it still wasn't anything to write home about. During the regular season, he totaled just 361 receiving yards on 267 routes run and averaged only 5.3 PPR points per game. We're still not writing home.

You could argue that Golden would've looked better had Green Bay simply used him more. His 1.35 yards per route run average isn't impressive, but we've seen worse – including from players who eventually turned into useful fantasy assets.

It's the combination of all of these factors that makes Golden such a scary investment.

Among all Year 2 Model wide receivers who failed to reach 7 PPR points per game as rookies, only seven went on to average at least 14 PPR points per game in either Year 2, 3, or 4. Two of those wideouts were Randall Cobb and Chris Godwin, and both posted yards per route run rates north of 2.0 as rookies. The peripherals were there to support future production.

That leaves five names: Davante Adams, Corey Davis, DJ Chark, Nico Collins, and Jameson Williams. Davis and Chark were never consistent WR2 assets in fantasy football, and Jameson Williams only missed that mark as a rookie because of injury.

So realistically, we're talking about Davante Adams and Nico Collins.

Sure, a bounce-back outcome exists for Golden. It's just not a likely one. And in a game of probability, that's obviously important.

Golden's Journey Comparables reinforce the concern. The published comps – Justin Hunter, KJ Hamler, and Adonai Mitchell – aren't exactly confidence-inducing. And if you zoom out beyond those names, the picture gets even bleaker: Zay Jones, Cordarrelle Patterson, Anthony Miller, Marvin Mims, Dante Pettis, Skyy Moore, Paul Richardson.

Davante Adams does appear in the behind-the-scenes comp list, but as we've already established, that's not the outcome you should be betting on.

The market still has *some* interest in Golden, but it's understandable if you'd rather just wait this thing out at this point. The Packers' wide receiver room could look different in 2026 as well, which only adds to the intrigue.

Just understand this: the odds aren't in his favor.



Pat Bryant • WR

56.0

Y2 Score

DENVER BRONCOS

FLEX PLAY



50.5

ZAP Score

Journey Comps: Donte Moncrief ▪ Nico Collins ▪ Tre'Quan Smith

For what looked like an overdrafted Day 2 selection by the Broncos, Pat Bryant's rookie season could've been worse. But make no mistake – it wasn't fantastic.

Beyond the raw numbers, Bryant posted just 1.22 yards per route run and recorded a first down on a little over 7% of his routes. He also failed to reach 5.0 PPR points per game, settling in at 4.8.

Those results aren't shocking for a Round 3 pick, but there wasn't much to get excited about with Bryant during most of the 2025 season.

If there's one positive to point to, it's how his role – and efficiency – changed as the year went on. From Weeks 1 through 8, Bryant saw just a 36% route share and averaged 3.6 PPR points per game. According to PFF data, his yards per route run during that stretch was an abysmal 0.48.

Then things shifted.

As the Broncos began to scale back Troy Franklin's usage, Bryant's route share jumped from 36% to 69% for the remainder of the regular season. His PPR points per game increased by four, and more importantly, his yards per route run climbed from 0.48 to a very respectable 1.58.

Courtland Sutton will turn 31 in October, and while Troy Franklin has proven to be a solid contributor, he hasn't shown himself to be an elite one. There's a path for Bryant to continue carving out a larger role in Denver's offense given his second-half surge.

And because the dynasty market largely views Bryant as an afterthought, he's the type of player worth throwing a dart at. The floor is low, but at this cost, seeing what he's got in 2026 makes plenty of sense.



Tre Harris • WR

53.5

Y2 Score

LOS ANGELES CHARGERS
FLEX PLAY


59.5

ZAP Score

Journey Comps: Ryan Broyles ▪ Jonathan Mingo ▪ Tyquan Thornton

The Chargers' decision to add Keenan Allen to their wide receiver mix last summer had a clear impact on Tre Harris' playing time. Harris finished the regular season with just a 43% route share, topping a 53% route participation rate in just three games. Unfortunately, in those contests, he scored only 4.8, 6.7, and 7.9 PPR points.

Harris exited his rookie season with a 1.10 yards per route run rate and a target on just 15% of his routes. Looking back at the ZAP Model, from 2011 to 2022, among wide receivers who posted scores between 55 and 75, there were 36 players who failed to reach both 1.20 yards per route run and a 17% targets-per-route threshold. Of those 36 wideouts, only three – Davante Adams, Michael Gallup, and DJ Chark – went on to average 10 or more PPR points per game in any of the next three seasons of their careers.

Now, those metrics aren't the end-all. Context always matters. Harris played in an offense with three legitimate wide receivers, which naturally capped his opportunity and ceiling within these efficiency numbers. Even so, it's hard to look at his rookie season – even after adjusting for team competition – and come away feeling particularly encouraged.

That said, Harris currently sits in WR6 territory in dynasty startups. At that cost, there's little incentive to sell. Not only can some of the inefficiency be explained away by usage and situation, but 2026 could be a much friendlier environment for this Chargers offense. Mike McDaniel is now the offensive coordinator, and the team's offensive line should be considerably healthier.

There's a path to a decent rebound for Harris. Just don't mistake that path for a guaranteed breakout.

Chimere Dike • WR

TENNESSEE TITANS

FLEX PLAY

52.2

Y2 Score



36.1

ZAP Score

Journey Comps: Greg Salas ▪ Quintez Cephus ▪ Tre Tucker

Chimere Dike was a pleasant surprise from the 2025 wide receiver class. His peripherals weren't eye-popping – he averaged just 1.02 yards per route run – but relative to expectations, Dike clearly outperformed them. After all, he finished the season leading the NFL in all-purpose yards.

That return-game production doesn't move the needle much for fantasy football, but it does speak to Dike's athleticism and ability with the ball in his hands – traits that should help him stick around the league.

The biggest problem for Dike right now is the Titans' signing of Wan'Dale Robinson. Brian Daboll brought in his former weapon from New York, and Robinson has been a career slot player, even if that slot usage dipped a bit in 2025.

Dike lived in the slot as a rookie, running 68% of his routes from that area of the field. The Titans also gave him a shallower role – 33% of his targets came behind the line of scrimmage, per PFF data. That usage likely signals some limitations in his overall route profile, and those cheaper looks could now find their way to Robinson.

Not ideal.

Pure slot receivers are becoming less fantasy relevant as offenses lean more into heavier personnel groupings, and Dike didn't enter the league as a standout route runner. Now he has Wan'Dale Robinson to deal with. You should keep him on your roster, but the odds of him becoming a significant fantasy contributor took a hit during free agency.



Jaylin Noel • WR

50.6

Y2 Score

HOUSTON TEXANS

FLEX PLAY



50.1

ZAP Score

Journey Comps: Austin Pettis ▪ Josh Palmer ▪ Marquise Goodwin

My subjective take is that the Year 2 Model is probably a little too low on Jaylin Noel. Objectively, though, his score makes sense.

The Texans barely deployed Noel in 2025 – he didn't have a single game as a rookie with a 50% route share. It's difficult for any player to project well in a forecasting model when the volume is that limited.

As expected, Noel was used primarily out of the slot as a rookie, just as he was at Iowa State. Houston deployed him in a very similar fashion, too. His average depth of target sat at just 9.1 yards, but nearly a quarter of his targets came on throws of 20 or more air yards. That aDOT was suppressed largely because 24% of his targets also came behind the line of scrimmage, one of the higher rates in the league.

And Noel does have downfield ability. He showed it in college, and as a rookie, he caught six of his eight deep targets, per PFF data. In fact, Noel finished second on the Texans in receptions on throws of 20-plus air yards, trailing only Nico Collins.

Where Noel may struggle – at least from a fantasy perspective – is in the intermediate area of the field. And that's often a valuable place for fantasy production. Targets in the 10-to-19 air-yard window are likely to funnel toward Collins and Jayden Higgins, which could leave Noel with fewer of those high-leverage opportunities.

Still, Noel finished the season with a respectable 1.45 yards per route run and managed three double-digit PPR performances despite his limited role. If free agent Christian Kirk is out of Houston in 2026, Noel could carve out a slightly larger piece of the offense.

That role just isn't likely to be as robust as we'd ideally want for fantasy purposes. Still, he's a good player in my eyes.



Jack Bech • WR

49.8

Y2 Score

LAS VEGAS RAIDERS
FLEX PLAY


55.9

ZAP Score

Journey Comps: Taywan Taylor ▪ Mohamed Sanu ▪ Van Jefferson

We can maybe excuse Jack Bech's lack of production from Week 1 through Week 9 last season, when Jakobi Meyers was still on the roster in Las Vegas.

What's harder to excuse is what happened from Week 10 through the end of the year.

Yes, the Raiders' offense wasn't good. But Bech was competing for targets with Tre Tucker and 33-year-old Tyler Lockett during the second half of the season, and he still couldn't get much going.

Bech finished the year with just one game above 6.3 PPR points. From Week 10 onward, he posted a 42% route share. He wasn't fully healthy all season, but it's still difficult to sell a profile built on 1.15 yards per route run while drawing a target on only 15% of those routes.

Bech wasn't a ZAP Model darling coming out of college, though a score of 55.9 wasn't terrible. Here's the problem: in the Year 2 Model database, there are 18 wide receivers from 2011 to 2022 who entered the league with a ZAP score between 45 and 65 and then saw their Year 2 score end up 10 or more points below that. In other words, players who were fine prospects – whether due to draft capital or production – but had poor rookie seasons.

Of those 18 wideouts, only DJ Chark ever averaged more than 12 PPR points per game in any of his first four seasons. And even then, he was never a long-term fantasy staple.

The odds simply aren't in Jack Bech's favor.

But hey – maybe Klint Kubiak can save him.

Isaac TeSlaa • WR

DETROIT LIONS

FLEX PLAY

49.4

Y2 Score



54.4

ZAP Score

Journey Comps: Mohamed Sanu ▪ Taywan Taylor ▪ Cedric Tillman

Among all rookie wide receivers since 2011 who scored six or more touchdowns, Isaac TeSlaa did it on the fewest targets (27). He barely edged out... Mecole Hardman.

The whole “all he does is score touchdowns” narrative with TeSlaa is cute, but it’s not especially predictive. In fact, if you look at the rookie wideouts over the past 15 or so years who rank best in touchdowns per target (minimum six scores), the list is... not great: TeSlaa, Martavis Bryant, Hardman, Jalen McMillan, Anthony Miller, Jahan Dotson, Gabe Davis. Christian Watson, Ja’Marr Chase, and Mike Evans converted efficiently, too, but touchdown scoring alone isn’t a particularly meaningful piece of the puzzle.

Volume is. And efficiency on that volume is.

TeSlaa had neither in 2025.

Yes, TeSlaa faced serious competition in Detroit with Amon-Ra St. Brown and Jameson Williams, but he still finished the year with a 0.81 yards per route run rate. In the Year 2 Model database, there are 21 wide receivers who ran at least 200 routes as rookies and posted a sub-0.90 yards per route run figure. Only one of them – Nelson Agholor – ever averaged more than 10 PPR points per game in Year 2, 3, or 4. And even then, Agholor was more waiver-wire filler than fantasy cornerstone.

TeSlaa is a fun story, and he’s a fun player to watch – he throws his body around like Puka Nacua does. But it would be beyond shocking if he followed in Puka Nacua’s footsteps. Even 50% of Nacua’s production would be a win.



Isaiah Bond • WR

47.2

Y2 Score

CLEVELAND BROWNS
FLEX PLAY


23.1

ZAP Score

Journey Comps: AT Perry ▪ Jordan Whittington ▪ Albert Wilson

Out of the 200-plus undrafted wide receivers in the ZAP Model, Isaiah Bond's 23.1 score ranks sixth-best. Undrafted wideouts rarely go on to succeed at the NFL level, but Bond's situation was a little different. He slipped out of the draft due to off-the-field issues and eventually signed with Cleveland in mid-August.

And all things considered, his rookie season wasn't, like, horrific.

No one truly got it done for the Browns last year outside of Harold Fannin, but Bond finished second on the team in wide receiver targets. He trailed Jerry Jeudy in yards per route run by just 0.04, and while Cleveland's offense struggled to sustain drives, Bond still accounted for roughly 9.5% of the team's first-down receptions when active – a top-12 first-down share among last year's rookie class.

Still, peripherals like these rarely translate into long-term fantasy production. Bond finished just below the 1.0 yards per route run mark, and in the Year 2 Model database, only DJ Chark and Davante Adams have gone on to post WR2 seasons or better in any of the following three years after failing to reach that threshold as rookies.

And even if Bond beats those odds – do we really feel great about Cleveland's offensive environment in the short term?



Kyle Williams • WR

46.7

Y2 Score

NEW ENGLAND PATRIOTS

FLEX PLAY



51.6

ZAP Score

Journey Comps: David Bell ▪ Anthony Schwartz ▪ Tyler Johnson

The hype train was real for Kyle Williams last summer – and I’ll admit it, I bought in, too.

Unfortunately, that train came to a screeching halt midway through the season when it became clear this just wasn’t going to happen in 2025.

Williams finished the year with 10 catches. He played all 17 games, but topped a 50% route share only three times – and that came on a team that frequently rotated its wide receivers.

To his credit, Williams flashed some speed. He caught three touchdowns of 30 or more yards, including a 72-yard bomb against Tampa Bay in November. That was fun. But beyond his role as a deep-ball specialist, there isn’t much in the underlying profile to get excited about. Among wide receivers with at least 150 routes, Williams ranked 11th in 20-plus air-yard target rate last season.

His Journey Comparables don’t inspire much confidence, either. David Bell was a college production monster who never found footing in the NFL. Anthony Schwartz, another speed-based prospect, caught 10 passes as a rookie before totaling just four the rest of his career. And Tyler Johnson was well-liked by the ZAP Model as a Day 3 pick, but has since settled in as a journeyman wide receiver.

Hopefully, Williams beats those outcomes. But the most likely path here is that he becomes a high-variance bench asset in dynasty formats.



Tory Horton • WR

45.9

Y2 Score

SEATTLE SEAHAWKS

FLEX PLAY



31.5

ZAP Score

Journey Comps: Mack Hollins ▪ Marvin Jones ▪ Justin Hardy

Tory Horton put together a 4-catch, 48-yard, 2-touchdown performance in Week 9 against Washington. And then we didn't see him on a football field again.

Groin and shin injuries cut Horton's rookie season short, and that absence likely played a role in Seattle trading for Rashid Shaheed at the deadline.

Before the injury, Horton was doing his best Isaac TeSlaa impression, scoring five touchdowns on just 22 targets. As we've already established, those touchdown totals aren't particularly predictive. And unfortunately, the underlying metrics for Horton don't offer much reassurance, either.

Horton finished Year 1 with modest efficiency marks, posting 1.16 yards per route run and a 16% targets-per-route rate. His 10.6% target share wasn't notable, either.

Still, there's a reasonable case to give Horton the benefit of the doubt. We're working entirely with early-season data, and we know rookie wide receivers often take a step forward during the second half of their first campaigns. Horton also graded out reasonably well as a prospect – his 31.5 ZAP score as the 166th overall pick resulted in a strong Draft Capital Delta.

Looking ahead, there's at least some reason to like Horton as a talent, but the Seahawks re-signing Shaheed definitely hurts his short-term outlook. We shouldn't view Horton as anything more than a deep bench stash at this point.



Tez Johnson • WR

44.9

Y2 Score

TAMPA BAY BUCCANEERS
FLEX PLAY


11.0

ZAP Score

Journey Comps: Jake Bobo ▪ Darius Johnson ▪ Jakobi Meyers

Tez Johnson has already handed the ZAP Model an L. Seriously. The model viewed Johnson as a weak prospect, and he's already outperformed those expectations at the NFL level.

You win some, you lose some.

Johnson's rookie season was a bit funky. His per-route metrics were well below average, but from roughly Week 5 through Week 12, he was at least usable in fantasy football. That window closed once Chris Godwin, Jalen McMillan, and Mike Evans all returned to the lineup. There was never going to be sustained opportunity for Johnson in an offense that deep at wide receiver.

Because of Tampa Bay's depth, Johnson didn't spend as much time in his natural slot role as expected. According to PFF, he lined up in the slot on fewer than 40% of his snaps. That said, the Buccaneers have largely ignored strict receiver alignments in recent years, so if there's a team that won't immediately pigeonhole Johnson into one role, it's probably them.

Still, the slot is almost certainly where Johnson fits best long term. Per PFF data, he averaged 1.19 yards per route run from the slot last season, compared to roughly 1.01 when aligned out wide. That gap isn't massive, but it lines up with what we saw in college, where Johnson lived – and thrived – inside.

The problem is opportunity. A consistent slot role isn't likely to open up as long as Chris Godwin is healthy in Tampa Bay, and Godwin is expected to stick around for at least another year. Mike Evans is now gone, which should give Johnson a chance to settle in as a top-four option in the offense, but it's still a tough environment for a young, fringe wide receiver.

At the very least, we know Johnson can function as a flex fill-in if injuries hit that receiver room again. And having Jakobi Meyers as a top comp can't be a bad thing for a player this low on the list.

Year 2 Running Back



Legendary Performer

Ashton Jeanty..... 156



Elite Producer

Omarion Hampton..... 157

TreVeyon Henderson..... 158



Weekly Starter

Cam Skattebo..... 159

Quinshon Judkins..... 160

RJ Harvey..... 161



Flex Play

Bhayshul Tuten..... 162

Woody Marks..... 163

Dylan Sampson..... 164

Jacory Croskey-Merritt..... 165

Kaleb Johnson..... 166

Kyle Monangai..... 167

Devin Neal..... 168



Ashton Jeanty • RB

99.6

Y2 Score

LAS VEGAS RAIDERS

LEGENDARY PERFORMER



100.0

ZAP Score

Journey Comps: Todd Gurley ▪ Jahmyr Gibbs ▪ Christian McCaffrey

Ashton Jeanty scored a perfect 100 in the updated ZAP Model, something only Christian McCaffrey, Saquon Barkley, and Jahmyr Gibbs have also done. And yet, you could argue – fairly convincingly – that Jeanty had the worst rookie season of the four.

Among 48 qualified running backs last year, Jeanty ranked dead last in both success rate and EPA per rush, per Next Gen Stats. He was 43rd in yards per carry.

That's scary. But let me calm your fears: it doesn't *really* matter.

Running back production is driven heavily by situation in a given year, and Jeanty's situation was brutal. Among backs with at least 100 carries, Quinshon Judkins was the only one, per PFF, to see fewer yards before contact per attempt than Jeanty. Unsurprisingly, Las Vegas' offensive line ranked 30th in PFF's run-blocking grades.

With Year 2 backs, volume is the signal we care about most – it tells us the team wanted to feature the player. Jeanty had that signal. The Year 2 Model uses a weighted opportunity formula to capture workload, and Jeanty's volume score ranks 10th-best in the database. He saw meaningful work both as a rusher and receiver, which carries strong predictive value for future seasons.

Especially when paired with a perfect prospect score.

Running back ZAP scores are actually more predictive of future success than Year 1 PPR points per game. Jeanty's 14.5 PPR points per game wasn't disastrous – it simply fell short of lofty expectations. The underlying profile still does the heavy lifting.

If there's one area worth monitoring, it's his big-play rate. Jeanty recorded a 20-plus-yard run on just 1.1% of his carries last season. Among the six other running backs to reach Legendary Performer status in the Year 2 Model, only Christian McCaffrey failed to clear a 3% big-play rate. That's at least mildly concerning.

Still, Jeanty's comparables couldn't be any stronger. And yes, it's a little uncomfortable seeing his name alongside those guys after a relatively underwhelming rookie campaign. I understand that hesitation.

But this is where trusting the process matters.

You don't have to rank him as the RB1 in dynasty. You don't even need to push him aggressively above his current market price. But you should feel confident about Jeanty's three-year outlook – especially with the change to the coaching staff and, ideally, the quarterback position.



Omarion Hampton • RB

87.2

Y2 Score

LOS ANGELES CHARGERS
ELITE PRODUCER


89.5

ZAP Score

Journey Comps: Leonard Fournette ▪ Ezekiel Elliott ▪ Trent Richardson

Does the ZAP Model like Omarion Hampton a little too much? Maybe. But aside from injury, it's not as if he flopped as a rookie.

Out of 48 qualified running backs, Hampton ranked 15th in rushing yards over expected per attempt last season, per Next Gen Stats. He was 22nd in success rate – and that came behind an offensive line that graded out as the worst run-blocking unit in the league, according to PFF.

It was also encouraging to see him involved as a pass-catcher. The ZAP Model viewed Hampton as a capable receiver entering the league, and in an offense (Greg Roman was offensive coordinator) that doesn't typically feature running backs heavily through the air, he posted a target share north of 12%.

From 2011 through 2022, there have been 10 running backs in the Year 2 Model database who entered the league as Legendary Performers or Elite Producers and then earned at least a 12% target share as rookies. Among those backs, only Trent Richardson and Giovani Bernard failed to provide an RB1 season within their next three campaigns.

The situation in LA also appears to be trending in the right direction. The Chargers added Mike McDaniel to coordinate the offense, and both Rashawn Slater and Joe Alt are expected to be healthy in 2026. Even if Kimani Vidal's emergence trims Hampton's workload slightly – or even the addition of Keaton Mitchell – there's little reason to believe Hampton can't ascend into high-end fantasy territory as soon as this season.

Yes, seeing Trent Richardson pop up as a Journey Comparable is uncomfortable. But Hampton-type profiles historically perform far better. That comp exists to keep us grounded, not to define the projection.



TreVeyon Henderson • RB

76.2

Y2 Score

NEW ENGLAND PATRIOTS
ELITE PRODUCER


67.0

ZAP Score

Journey Comps: Josh Jacobs ▪ Javonte Williams ▪ Kenneth Walker

TreVeyon Henderson had a strange rookie season.

We didn't see a true breakout until Week 10, when Rhamondre Stevenson was sidelined. But when it happened, it was loud. Henderson rushed for 147 yards on 14 carries against Tampa Bay and then posted at least 80 total yards in each of the next four games.

A concussion in Week 16 stalled that momentum. And even once he returned during New England's playoff run, Stevenson handled the majority of the backfield work – Henderson logged a sub-40% snap share from the Divisional Round onward.

One clear takeaway from Year 1 was Henderson's explosiveness. He gained 20 or more yards on over 3% of his rushes, the highest rate in this rookie class. Only 33 other running backs in the Year 2 Model database have reached that threshold on 100-plus carries as rookies. Of those backs who've played four years in the league, they averaged a best PPR points-per-game season of 14.5 between Years 2 and 4. That's a very solid high-end RB2 campaign.

The less encouraging takeaway was in pass protection. Henderson entered the league with a reputation as an elite blocker, but that didn't translate immediately. Among backs with 100-plus attempts in 2025, he ranked 41st out of 49 in PFF pass-blocking grade. Stevenson ranked third. That discrepancy likely played a role in Stevenson maintaining his role, especially early in the year.

And to be fair, Stevenson earned it late in the season. After a rocky start, he finished strong. That allowed him to post the highest rushing yards over expected per attempt among qualified backs, per Next Gen Stats.

Henderson's receiving profile also didn't fully materialize. An 8.7% target share isn't poor, but for a player whose collegiate résumé suggested more pass-game involvement, that number needs to grow for him to hit his ceiling.

Stevenson's late-season surge – combined with the fact that he remains under contract in 2026 – makes Henderson's short-term outlook a bit murky. We should expect more volume in Year 2, and his long-term upside remains substantial. But given his current market price, the direction you go with Henderson likely depends on where your team stands – a win-now roster may want to capitalize and sell, while a rebuilding one may prefer to hold.

The good news? Henderson's Journey Comparables are pretty strong.



Cam Skattebo • RB

69.1

Y2 Score

NEW YORK GIANTS

WEEKLY STARTER



60.0

ZAP Score

Journey Comps: Miles Sanders ▪ James Cook ▪ Zack Moss

Anyone selling modeling as perfect and flawless is lying. We're trying to project something that's inherently difficult to forecast. And with these Year 2 Models, we're working off just one season of NFL data. Weird outcomes can, and will, happen.

Injuries are one of the biggest challenges for any model. And Cam Skattebo is a perfect example.

Before suffering a gruesome ankle injury last season, Skattebo looked like a legitimate league-winning player. His bruising college play style carried over to the NFL – something that doesn't always happen. Among running backs with 100-plus attempts last year, he ranked inside the top 10 in missed tackles forced per rush, per PFF.

The volume signal was there, too. Skattebo's weighted opportunity per game trailed only Ashton Jeanty and Omarion Hampton in the 2025 draft class. And perhaps most importantly, he earned a 13% target share when active – second-best in the class behind Jeanty.

The primary concern – beyond recovery – is Skattebo's lack of big-play production. Fewer than 1% of his rushes went for 20 or more yards last season. That does carry signal for future production, and a new coaching staff may want more of that from the run game.

It's worth remembering that some big-name players like Christian McCaffrey and Derrick Henry also failed to post strong big-play rates as rookies, so this isn't automatically disqualifying. Big plays can be somewhat situational, and they often improve with better blocking or more stable offensive environments.

But Skattebo *did* enter the league with legitimate long-speed questions. He was never projected as a home-run hitter, and the rookie data didn't exactly silence those concerns. So while the sub-1% rate isn't a red flag on its own, it does reinforce the idea that his fantasy ceiling is more likely to come through volume, tackle-breaking ability, and receiving usage than through explosive chunk gains. That's not a horrendous archetype – it just narrows the margin for error a bit.

The wildcard here is the new coaching staff in New York. Rumors are swirling that the Giants could take Jeremiyah Love at the top of this year's draft, and that would completely crater Skattebo's fantasy value without some sort of trade. The dynasty market seems to be baking that possibility in to some degree, but in situations like this, you have to ask yourself how much higher Skattebo's value could realistically go if that move *doesn't* happen. In my opinion, it's not much higher than his current RB20 price tag on KeepTradeCut. After all, Skattebo's already 24 years old.



Quinshon Judkins • RB

68.2

Y2 Score

CLEVELAND BROWNS

WEEKLY STARTER



66.0

ZAP Score

Journey Comps: Cam Akers ▪ Le'Veon Bell ▪ Eddie Lacy

Quinshon Judkins' 2025 season was a win for fantasy football. Back in August, we weren't even sure he'd suit up for the Browns. Instead, he delivered an impressive – albeit potentially slightly overrated – rookie campaign.

“Overrated” might sound harsh, so let me provide some context. Judkins came out firing, with his three best rushing yards over expected per attempt games occurring within his first four contests. Fantasy managers were understandably excited. From there, the efficiency tapered off.

That doesn't mean he was bad. Far from it. Judkins averaged over 12 PPR points per game – a mark only four other running backs in the class reached. And he did so in brutal conditions. Among higher-volume backs, he ranked dead last in yards before contact per attempt, a clear reflection of Cleveland's offensive line issues. Pro Football Focus graded the Browns' run blocking as bottom-five in the league.

Where there is reason for mild concern is in the passing game.

Judkins' ZAP score wasn't super elite coming out because he was never deployed as a full-time receiving back in college. That theme carried over to the NFL. As a rookie, he ran a route on just 30% of Cleveland's dropbacks, a lower participation rate than Derrick Henry.

That kind of usage can cap a running back's fantasy ceiling. It's not necessarily a talent deficiency – Judkins isn't incapable as a receiver – but Cleveland preferred to use fellow rookie Dylan Sampson in more obvious passing situations. A new coaching staff could shift that deployment, but Sampson is a capable player who figures to remain part of the equation throughout their rookie contracts.

Judkins is a good player. Arguably the best pure runner in the 2025 class. But Cleveland's offensive outlook is shaky, and without growth in receiving usage, his path to true RB1 upside narrows.

That's not a massive red flag – it's just something to keep in mind.



RJ Harvey • RB

66.1

Y2 Score

DENVER BRONCOS

WEEKLY STARTER



58.7

ZAP Score

Journey Comps: Ameer Abdullah ▪ Zack Moss ▪ David Montgomery

We should always take single-season running back efficiency metrics with a grain of salt. They're not overly predictive, and it's easy to overstate their importance.

With that being said, poor marks still matter. And RJ Harvey had some in 2025.

Among 48 qualified backs, Harvey ranked 46th in rushing yards over expected per attempt, per Next Gen Stats. His success rate was 32nd – notably well behind teammate JK Dobbins, who ranked 12th in the same offensive environment.

On the positive side, Harvey's burst – one of his strongest traits entering the league – did show up at times. His 109.4 Speed Score translated into a 2.1% rate of 20-plus-yard runs. Only 55 other backs in the Year 2 Model database have cleared that 2% threshold on 100-plus rookie carries.

The issue is that the explosiveness wasn't consistent. While he connected on a few long gains, Harvey's 5.5% rate of 10-plus-yard runs ranked sixth-worst all-time among Year 2 Model backs with 100-plus first-year carries. In other words, the home runs were there – the steady stream of chunk plays wasn't.

We also saw a solid 10% target share, and he was efficient enough through the air. That's meaningful in a Sean Payton offense that has historically featured running backs as receivers. That part of his profile carries real weight for long-term fantasy value.

And, of course, there were the touchdowns. Harvey scored 12 total times – rare for a rookie back. But touchdowns are far less reliable than prospect scores, early-career volume, and core efficiency metrics. While plenty of rookie backs with double-digit totals went on to strong careers, the list also includes players like Antonio Gibson, James Robinson, Eddie Lacy, and Alfred Morris – productive, but not long-term fantasy cornerstones.

The fact that Harvey didn't fully seize the starting job until Dobbins was injured is at least mildly concerning, though it's not uncommon for rookies to require time before a takeover. The larger concern is that his rushing efficiency never truly separated.

So, where do we go from here? Well, Dobbins re-signed in Denver, which creates somewhat of a roadblock for Harvey's short-term outlook. But honestly, it was still one of the better outcomes for the second-year player in free agency. Denver could've landed a bigger name like Kenneth Walker, after all. The Broncos may add another back in the draft, but at least for Harvey's sake, this year's class isn't particularly strong. From that perspective, he may end up in an OK spot.

Harvey's age is a concern – he's already 25 – but if you set proper expectations, you should be able to navigate his market. He's capable of delivering an RB2 season over the next few years, but the ceiling is likely capped. He, to me, is not a bell-cow back.

Bhayshul Tuten • RB

52.3
Y2 Score

JACKSONVILLE JAGUARS

FLEX PLAY

 52.9
ZAP Score

Journey Comps: Trey Benson ▪ Derrick Henry ▪ Darrell Henderson

At the start of the offseason – back in January – yours truly listed Bhayshul Tuten as a buy candidate. Then, a couple of weeks later, I sent a newsletter out with a copy of this very player page, telling people not to be too aggressive. It now seems like, based on general sentiment, people don’t know where I stand. So I decided to re-write this whole thing to be clear: Bhayshul Tuten is more of a buy than a sell. That feeling may not be an intense one, but that’s the side I lean.

It’s no secret that the ZAP Model liked Tuten. And it’s no secret that he didn’t live up to the hype in 2025.

After Tank Bigsby was dealt to Philadelphia, Travis Etienne took firm control of the Jacksonville backfield. There were moments when it felt like Tuten might carve out a larger role, but something always intervened – an injury, a hot stretch from Etienne – and Tuten would slide back into the background.

Tuten’s ZAP Model profile was legitimately strong. And there were positives to his rookie season. He, for instance, posted a 47% success rate compared to Etienne’s 36%. That grinder mentality led to the Jags using Tuten frequently at the goal line – he had 7 goal-line attempts to Etienne’s 12, which is notable given Etienne’s workload advantage. Tuten also gained positive yardage on over 85% of his rushes, a top-two mark among 50-plus carry rookies from the 2025 class.

One issue is that the explosiveness that fueled his prospect appeal didn’t really show up in Year 1. On 83 rush attempts, Tuten failed to record a single run of 20 or more yards (though he did hit a 20-yard run in the playoffs). He had just two runs of 15-plus yards.

In the Year 2 Model database, 13 other running backs have logged at least 50 rookie carries without a 20-plus-yard run in the regular season. Of those 13, only one went on to average more than 10 PPR points per game in Years 2 through 4. The sample is small, but that’s not exactly comforting.

So this, at the moment, is a high-variance profile. On one end, you have a player beloved by the ZAP Model relative to draft capital expectations. And he had some encouraging marks as a rookie. On the other, the explosiveness that we – the model – liked to see wasn’t totally evident in Year 1.

Travis Etienne is gone now, though. All that’s left on the Jacksonville running back depth chart is Tuten, LeQuint Allen, and now Chris Rodriguez.

Tuten should at least get some shot this year, even if it’s in tandem with Rodriguez, who hasn’t been much of a pass-catcher in college or the NFL. And I’m more on the side that Tuten’s more talented than not – we can’t just totally forget about his ZAP score.



Woody Marks • RB

51.6

Y2 Score

HOUSTON TEXANS

FLEX PLAY



38.6

ZAP Score

Journey Comps: Javorius Allen ▪ Kendall Hunter ▪ Andre Williams

Woody Marks didn't profile as a true three-down back entering the NFL. That's what the ZAP Model suggested, and it's what I believed, too.

And yet, as a rookie, we frequently saw him in that role. Marks finished with the sixth-best weighted opportunity per game in the class. He also became just the 12th running back in Year 2 Model history to log at least 190 rookie carries after being selected outside the top 100 picks.

Sounds impressive.

Historically, it isn't.

Of the 11 backs who did it before him, their average best PPR points-per-game season across Years 2 through 4 is just 7.9. That's not difference-making production.

When Day 3 running backs earn heavy rookie volume, it's often more about team weakness than individual talent. Opportunity can be circumstantial.

That doesn't mean Marks is a bad player. In fact, the ZAP Model viewed him fairly favorably relative to his draft capital. But even last year's guide framed him as more of a complementary back with pass-catching ability than a true three-down option.

The strange part of his rookie season? Despite the workload, Houston didn't feature him heavily as a receiver. Marks posted just a 6.9% target share on a roughly 40% route participation rate – solid, but not what you'd expect for a player whose profile leaned on receiving utility.

Efficiency didn't help the case. Behind a below-average Houston run-blocking unit, Marks ranked 43rd out of 48 qualified backs in success rate, 33rd in rushing yards over expected per attempt, and 42nd in EPA per rush. Among the nine rookie backs with 100-plus carries, his rates of 10-plus-yard and 20-plus-yard runs both ranked second worst.

That's not a profile that screams long-term stability.

It's no surprise, then, that Houston traded for David Montgomery. Hypothetically, Montgomery's a strong complement – he can handle much of the in-between-the-tackles work the Texans thought Nick Chubb might provide in 2025. That's going to severely limit Marks' workload, though you could argue Montgomery is a win for Marks. If they don't add a back with significant capital in the draft, Montgomery isn't overly difficult competition compared to what could've been for Houston.

Even still, we're back where we started: Marks is a tandem back, not a bell-cow.



Dylan Sampson • RB

51.1

Y2 Score

CLEVELAND BROWNS

FLEX PLAY



36.8

ZAP Score

Journey Comps: Chuba Hubbard ▪ Ray Davis ▪ Andre Williams

Dylan Sampson finished 2025 with an 8.6% target share. That may not sound like much, but get this: among Year 2 Model running backs selected outside the top 100 picks, only 21 have reached an 8% target share as rookies.

What makes Sampson's season even more unusual is that he didn't enter the league with a strong collegiate receiving résumé. His best prorated reception share in college was under 10%. Of those 21 rookie backs to hit an 8% NFL target share, only seven had a sub-10% reception share in college.

Unfortunately for Sampson managers, that subset hasn't produced much fantasy upside. None of those backs became true difference-makers after Year 1. The best outcome was probably Jordan Howard, who topped out at 12.8 PPR points per game post-rookie season.

Maybe there's a small silver lining: Sampson was efficient as a receiver, posting the highest yards-per-route-run rate among that group. Maybe that matters enough to keep the momentum going into Year 2 and beyond. Maybe.

On the ground, though, little stood out – and what did wasn't encouraging. Sampson became just the ninth Year 2 Model back with 50-plus rookie carries to post a sub-5% 10-plus-yard run rate. While he managed a few 20-plus-yard gains, the down-to-down consistency wasn't there. His 29.1% success rate was borderline alarming.

You may have read earlier that Quinshon Judkins ranked last in yards before contact per attempt this past year. But that was when looking at higher-volume backs. When loosening that filter a bit and looking at guys with 50 or more carries, Sampson actually ranks even worse – he's dead last in the league by a healthy margin.

To put that another way, it's likely that Sampson's line wasn't doing him any favors this past year.

Still, the overall profile doesn't scream high ceiling.

If Quinshon Judkins is healthy, Sampson isn't leading this backfield. He's a capable handcuff – and his receiving usage supports that – but projecting much more than that in the short term feels aggressive. Down the line, perhaps his top Journey Comparable of Chuba Hubbard offers a plausible path. But that's more developmental outcome than immediate expectation.



Jacory Croskey-Merritt • RB

49.5

Y2 Score

WASHINGTON COMMANDERS

FLEX PLAY



13.9

ZAP Score

Journey Comps: James Robinson ▪ Jaylen Warren ▪ Daryl Richardson

The hype around Jacory Croskey-Merritt was very real just a week or two before the 2025 season, and he backed it up early. After the first month-plus, Next Gen Stats had Croskey-Merritt – “Bill” – posting the best success rate in football. Washington was still splitting the backfield, but Bill was undeniably productive.

Then regression hit.

Four of Croskey-Merritt’s first five games featured a success rate of at least 50%. During that stretch, he averaged a ridiculous 2.2 rushing yards over expected per attempt and gained 10 or more yards on nearly 21% of his carries.

After Week 5, the numbers cooled significantly. Croskey-Merritt had just two games with a 50% success rate the rest of the way. His rushing yards over expected per attempt fell to 0.34, and his 10-plus-yard run rate dropped to 9.1%.

Even so, his full-season body of work isn’t terrible. Bill generated a 10-plus-yard run at a 12% clip – above average within the class – and finished with 8.6 PPR points per game. His comparables across those metrics include Jerick McKinnon, Tyjae Spears, Tarik Cohen, and Keaton Mitchell.

The issue? Most of those players were meaningfully involved as receivers early in their careers. Croskey-Merritt wasn’t in Year 1. He finished with just a 3.0% target share and ran a route on only 25% of Washington’s dropbacks.

Woof.

Overall, Croskey-Merritt’s rushing profile fits that of a big-play complementary back. The problem is that there’s little evidence of a receiving backbone – even in college, despite more than four seasons of play, he never reached a 10% reception share. That could explain why the Commanders went out and signed the pass-catching Rachaad White.

Bill should continue to have a role in Washington’s backfield, though. It may not be a massive one, but it’ll be something.

But absent growth in the passing game, it’s difficult to project him as anything more than a rotational option rather than a featured piece.



Kaleb Johnson • RB

49.4

Y2 Score

PITTSBURGH STEELERS

FLEX PLAY



64.8

ZAP Score

Journey Comps: Shane Vereen ▪ Derrius Guice ▪ Tank Bigsby

Do we really have to talk about Kaleb Johnson?

Each year, as you know, the ZAP Model gets refined. New data is tested. New inputs are introduced. Player scores shift.

This current iteration of the running back ZAP Model is the best it's ever been.

And it still likes Kaleb Johnson.

Great.

Johnson had arguably the most disappointing rookie season of any back in last year's class. From a volume standpoint alone, he joins 19 other Year 2 Model running backs drafted inside the top 100 who failed to reach 50 rush attempts as rookies. On his 28 carries, he didn't record a single 10-plus-yard run.

We're off to a great start.

When we isolate backs drafted between Picks 32 and 100 since 2011 who failed to reach 50 rookie rush attempts, there *have* been a few spike seasons. Six produced at least 13.0 PPR points per game in one of Years 2 through 4. One of those was Mike Leshoure, who tore his Achilles before his rookie season and never really had the opportunity for that workload.

The others? Shane Vereen, Kenyan Drake, Ronald Jones, Damien Harris, and Darrell Henderson.

There's a path to some one-off production, as that group of backs shows. But for Johnson to become a true fantasy staple, he'd essentially have to break historical precedent for backs in his draft range over the last decade-plus.

You can make that bet if you'd like – especially with his dynasty price cratered. There's a new coaching staff in Pittsburgh, and while the Steelers did add Rico Dowdle (while losing Kenneth Gainwell), you never know how a new set of coaches will want to run things.

But let's be realistic: Kaleb Johnson profiles more like this year's Ja'Lynn Polk than a misunderstood breakout candidate. It's probably not going to happen. The one sliver of hope? Running back prospect scores tend to carry more rebound value than wide receiver scores after a poor rookie season. So while the odds aren't close to being in his favor, the position itself at least leaves the door cracked open.



Kyle Monangai • RB

49.2

Y2 Score

CHICAGO BEARS

FLEX PLAY



16.4

ZAP Score

Journey Comps: Isiah Pacheco ▪ Justin Jackson ▪ James Robinson

The ZAP Model wasn't particularly fond of Kyle Monangai for two primary reasons: draft capital and receiving.

As a seventh-round pick, he didn't have meaningful investment behind him. And analytically, the pass-game background was thin. His adjusted receiving yards per team pass attempt sat well below the 2025 class average, and he never reached an 8% best-season reception share in college.

If Monangai was going to hit, it was going to be on the ground.

Fortunately, he landed in a spot that allowed that to happen. In Chicago, Monangai handled 169 regular-season carries. He became just the fourth Year 2 Model back to reach at least 160 rookie rush attempts after being selected outside the top 200 picks. The other three: the aforementioned Jacory Croskey-Merritt, James Robinson, and fellow Rutgers alum Isiah Pacheco – ironically Monangai's top Journey Comparable.

So what's next?

The receiving work didn't expand in Year 1. Monangai finished with just a 5.7% target share and an underwhelming 0.75 yards per route run rate. That's unlikely to fuel a fantasy ceiling.

As a rusher, he was solid – and undeniably fun to watch – but the underlying efficiency was more average than highlight reels suggest. PFF graded him below average in missed tackles forced per attempt, and Next Gen Stats had his rushing yards over expected per attempt hovering around league average.

Where he did stand out was in consistency. Among 48 qualified backs, Monangai ranked fifth in success rate. But even that deserves context: teammate D'Andre Swift ranked just below him, and Chicago's offensive line finished fifth in run-blocking grade, per PFF. The environment was doing some of the lifting.

Monangai isn't a bad player. In fact, relative to expectation, he's a ZAP Model L. But the receiving ceiling remains limited, and his rushing profile looks more early-down grinder than true difference-maker.

My personal rankings are higher on Monangai than what the Year 2 Model is saying, largely because the situation is fantastic. The model isn't accounting for that.

But the broader profile tells a more measured story. Long term, he projects as a flex option with occasional RB2 spikes, not unlike Isiah Pacheco. He's probably not some foundational piece. That makes the Flex Play designation appropriate.

Devin Neal • RB

NEW ORLEANS SAINTS

FLEX PLAY

47.0

Y2 Score

29.7

ZAP Score

Journey Comps: Vick Ballard ▪ Elijah McGuire ▪ Chase Edmonds

Devin Neal more or less did what the ZAP Model suggested he would do as a rookie.

Was he great? Probably not.

Was he playable? Absolutely.

Thanks to injuries to Alvin Kamara and Kendre Miller, Neal found himself operating as New Orleans' lead back for stretches of the season. He logged a 70% snap share three times, and in those games, he averaged a respectable 12.1 PPR points per contest.

Neal entered the league projecting as a potential three-down back – just not a dominant one. His collegiate profile suggested competence across the board without a true standout trait. And that's exactly what we saw in 2025. When given the opportunity, he handled early downs, ran routes at a high clip, and stayed on the field in passing situations. In those three high-usage games, his route participation exceeded 70%, leading to an 11% target share.

In other words, the coaching staff trusted him.

It tells us that if injuries strike again, Neal is capable of absorbing a near three-down workload. It may not be explosive or hyper-efficient, but it's usable volume.

Efficiency-wise, though, nothing jumped off the page. His success rate was low and similar to Kendre Miller's. His 10-plus-yard run rate lagged behind most of his rookie classmates. And his receiving efficiency was below the norm.

He didn't separate. But he also didn't crater.

And that's really the story here. Neal profiles as a stabilizer – the type of back who can keep an offense on schedule and deliver replacement-level fantasy production when called upon. He's unlikely to become a league-winner, but he's also unlikely to disappear.

In dynasty, that archetype has value. He's a high-end depth piece with contingent upside – the kind of player you're glad to roster when the inevitable running back injuries hit.

Not extraordinary. But very rosterable.

Closing

Football isn't solved. It never will be.

If it were, there'd be no reason to do this. No reason to build models. No reason to debate landing spots or argue over breakout ages. No reason to care about a 21-year-old running back's target share.

But this game lives in the gray area.

Humans are playing it. Coaches are making decisions. Front offices are guessing. Injuries happen. Situations change. And we're all trying to make sense of it — **to reverse engineer a sport built on chaos.**

That's what makes prospecting so addicting. There's always room for improvement.

This guide isn't about certainty. It's about probability. It's about stacking small edges over time. It's about having a process you trust when you're on the clock and the group chat is losing its mind.

We'll get things right. We'll get things wrong. That's part of it.

But we'll keep refining. Keep questioning. Keep iterating. Because the edge isn't in being perfect — it's in being thoughtful.

Thanks for letting me obsess over this stuff for another year.



Rookie Rankings

Single-QB Top-48										
Rk	Player	Pos	Pos. Rank	Tier		Rk	Player	Pos	Pos. Rank	Tier
1	Jeremiyah Love	RB	1	1		25	Elijah Sarratt	WR	13	7
2	Jordyn Tyson	WR	1	2		26	Chris Brazzell	WR	14	7
3	Carnell Tate	WR	2	2		27	Ted Hurst	WR	15	7
4	Makai Lemon	WR	3	3		28	Kaelon Black	RB	7	7
5	KC Concepcion	WR	4	3		29	Max Klare	TE	5	7
6	Jadarian Price	RB	2	3		30	Demond Claiborne	RB	8	7
7	Kenyon Sadiq	TE	1	4		31	Skyler Bell	WR	16	7
8	Omar Cooper	WR	5	4		32	Mike Washington	RB	9	7
9	Fernando Mendoza	QB	1	5		33	Justin Joly	TE	6	8
10	Denzel Boston	WR	6	5		34	Caleb Douglas	WR	17	8
11	Germie Bernard	WR	7	5		35	Malachi Fields	WR	18	8
12	Antonio Williams	WR	8	5		36	Brenen Thompson	WR	19	8
13	Jonah Coleman	RB	3	5		37	Adam Randall	RB	10	8
14	Chris Bell	WR	9	5		38	Marlin Klein	TE	7	8
15	Eli Stowers	TE	2	5		39	Bryce Lance	WR	20	8
16	Nick Singleton	RB	4	6		40	Eli Heidenreich	RB	11	8
17	De'Zhaun Stribling	WR	10	6		41	Zavion Thomas	WR	21	8
18	Zachariah Branch	WR	11	6		42	Tanner Koziol	TE	8	8
19	Kaytron Allen	RB	5	6		43	Barion Brown	WR	22	9
20	Eli Raridon	TE	3	6		44	Carson Beck	QB	3	9
21	Oscar Delp	TE	4	6		45	Kevin Coleman	WR	23	9
22	Ja'Kobi Lane	WR	12	6		46	Matthew Hibner	TE	9	9
23	Ty Simpson	QB	2	6		47	Sam Roush	TE	10	9
24	Emmett Johnson	RB	6	6		48	Cyrus Allen	WR	24	9

Superflex Top-48

Rk	Player	Pos	Pos. Rank	Tier	Rk	Player	Pos	Pos. Rank	Tier
1	Jeremiyah Love	RB	1	1	25	Ja'Kobi Lane	WR	12	6
2	Jordyn Tyson	WR	1	2	26	Emmett Johnson	RB	6	6
3	Carnell Tate	WR	2	2	27	Elijah Sarratt	WR	13	7
4	Fernando Mendoza	QB	1	2	28	Chris Brazzell	WR	14	7
5	Makai Lemon	WR	3	3	29	Ted Hurst	WR	15	7
6	KC Concepcion	WR	4	3	30	Kaelon Black	RB	7	7
7	Jadarian Price	RB	2	3	31	Max Klare	TE	5	7
8	Kenyon Sadiq	TE	1	4	32	Demond Claiborne	RB	8	7
9	Ty Simpson	QB	2	4	33	Cole Payton	QB	5	7
10	Omar Cooper	WR	5	4	34	Skyler Bell	WR	16	7
11	Denzel Boston	WR	6	5	35	Taylen Green	QB	6	7
12	Germie Bernard	WR	7	5	36	Mike Washington	RB	9	7
13	Antonio Williams	WR	8	5	37	Cade Klubnik	QB	7	7
14	Jonah Coleman	RB	3	5	38	Justin Joly	TE	6	8
15	Chris Bell	WR	9	5	39	Caleb Douglas	WR	17	8
16	Eli Stowers	TE	2	5	40	Malachi Fields	WR	18	8
17	Carson Beck	QB	3	5	41	Brenen Thompson	WR	19	8
18	Drew Allar	QB	4	5	42	Adam Randall	RB	10	8
19	Nick Singleton	RB	4	6	43	Marlin Klein	TE	7	8
20	De'Zhaun Stribling	WR	10	6	44	Bryce Lance	WR	20	8
21	Zachariah Branch	WR	11	6	45	Eli Heidenreich	RB	11	8
22	Kaytron Allen	RB	5	6	46	Zavion Thomas	WR	21	8
23	Eli Raridon	TE	3	6	47	Tanner Koziol	TE	8	8
24	Oscar Delp	TE	4	6	48	Barion Brown	WR	22	9

Rookie Rankings Notes

Overview: My overall sentiment with rookie drafts this year is that things get very flat after the first half of the first round. At that point, you can really just take the players you're most comfortable with. Throw average draft position out the window. The ZAP Model can guide you, but keep in mind that we're not dealing with a ton of elite talent. When that's the case, a difference of 5, 10, or even 15 points in the model isn't the biggest deal in the world. And, often, in those cases, we should be caring more about landing spot.

Some general thoughts are below:

- Jermiyah Love is the top pick in all formats, and the ZAP Model favors Jordyn Tyson over Carnell Tate. Tate, of course, may be the safer investment given Tyson's injury history, and he has a path to being the alpha in Tennessee. I still prefer Tyson, but Tate clearly belongs in that tier.
- After Tier 2, you're looking at Makai Lemon, KC Concepcion, and Jadarian Price. I leaned on the model when ranking the wide receivers, but there are pros and cons to both landing spots. The bigger takeaway is that Concepcion is likely to go well after Lemon in most rookie drafts, when I think he belongs in the same tier.
- Sticking with that tier, you can make a strong case for Price as early as 1.05 in superflex drafts. The ZAP Model isn't overly bullish, but running back production is heavily tied to coaching decisions — and his draft capital suggests Seattle won't keep him on the sidelines. I just don't want to overreact to landing spot alone. It's not perfect, and there's a lot of volatility in his profile. Still, with Charbonnet's injury, Price should hold early value, and that matters.
- There's a noticeable drop after Jadarian Price. Omar Cooper and Kenyon Sadiq operate in similar areas of the field and land in less-than-ideal spots, but their profiles and draft capital suggest they should be next.
- After Cooper and Sadiq are off the board, we really enter a choose-your-own-adventure tier. Denzel Boston isn't a ZAP Model favorite, and the landing spot is questionable. Antonio Williams has his own red flags, but Washington is a strong situation. If you're chasing early production and potential value gain, I can get behind taking Williams as early as 1.09 in a single-quarterback league — which is kind of wild to say. I just don't have him ranked that aggressively.
- Tier 5 in single-quarterback leagues is large for a reason — it's flat. Jonah Coleman grades well in the model and has a path to a larger-than-expected role in Denver. Chris Bell is a wildcard with limited competition and real upside — he's a ceiling play. Eli Stowers may struggle to produce right away; it's reminiscent of the Terrance Ferguson situation last year.
- Tier 6 is even deeper. I'm wary of the Stribling profile, but the draft capital is undeniable, and I'd expect the dynasty community to be lukewarm. Nick Singleton could see work

immediately, which makes him intriguing even as a Day 3 pick. The same goes for Kaytron Allen. Emmett Johnson sticks here because the talent profile is strong. But at this point, just draft for need. If you want a tight end, take one. If you want to swing on a running back, do it. The opportunity cost at wide receiver is minimal.

- The same logic applies to the next tier. Kaelon Black was a Day 2 pick, but the 49ers' track record of reaching on running backs — paired with a mediocre profile — is concerning. Skyler Bell and Elijah Sarratt are probably the most appealing wideouts here if you're thinking about 2026 upside, but they're far from certainties.
- For superflex rankings, I did my best to place the quarterbacks in reasonable pockets where the opportunity cost dips. They're not elite prospects, but Taylen Green and Cole Payton stand out due to mobility. Quarterbacks are currency in superflex formats, so even as Day 3 picks, their upside cases are stronger than most skill players in that range.

ZAP Model Rankings

RUNNING BACK		
Rk	Player	ZAP
LEGENDARY PERFORMER		
1	Jeremiyah Love	97.6
WEEKLY STARTER		
2	Jadarian Price	69.3
FLEX PLAY		
3	Jonah Coleman	48.7
4	Kaelon Black	46.5
5	Mike Washington	41.4
BENCHWARMER		
6	Emmett Johnson	34.7
7	Nick Singleton	33.2
WAIVER WIRE ADD		
8	Adam Randall	29.9
9	Eli Heidenreich	27.3
10	Demond Claiborne	25.3
11	Kaytron Allen	23.3
12	Seth McGowan	20.0
DART THROW		
13	Jam Miller	17.1
14	Desmond Reid	15.2
15	Roman Hemby	12.4
16	Robert Henry	11.1
17	CJ Donaldson	10.9
18	J'Mari Taylor	10.2
19	Noah Whittington	7.3
20	Le'Veon Moss	4.7
21	Rahsul Faison	0.0

WIDE RECEIVER		
Rk	Player	ZAP
LEGENDARY PERFORMER		
1	Jordyn Tyson	96.2
ELITE PRODUCER		
2	Carnell Tate	88.3
3	Makai Lemon	77.4
4	KC Concepcion	75.4
WEEKLY STARTER		
5	Omar Cooper	65.2
6	Germie Bernard	64.8
7	Denzel Boston	62.3
FLEX PLAY		
8	De'Zhaun Stribling	58.7
9	Ja'Kobi Lane	54.4
10	Antonio Williams	53.3
11	Zachariah Branch	49.1
12	Caleb Douglas	47.2
13	Malachi Fields	46.7
14	Chris Brazzell	46.5
15	Ted Hurst	45.6
16	Chris Bell	42.9
17	Zavion Thomas	40.7
18	Elijah Sarratt	40.1
BENCHWARMER		
19	Reggie Virgil	35.2
20	Skyler Bell	34.3
21	Brenen Thompson	33.8
22	Bryce Lance	31.3
23	Barion Brown	30.8
WAIVER WIRE ADD		
24	Kevin Coleman	29.8
25	Kaden Wetjen	27.9

TIGHT END		
Rk	Player	ZAP
LEGENDARY PERFORMER		
1	Kenyon Sadiq	98.5
ELITE PRODUCER		
2	Eli Stowers	75.4
WEEKLY STARTER		
3	Max Klare	63.4
4	Sam Roush	61.2
FLEX PLAY		
5	Marlin Klein	59.7
6	Oscar Delp	55.5
7	Eli Raridon	51.5
8	Will Kacmarek	43.7
BENCHWARMER		
9	Matthew Hibner	36.1
10	Justin Joly	31.7
WAIVER WIRE ADD		
11	Tanner Koziol	28.3
12	Nate Boerkircher	25.6
13	Joe Royer	25.6
14	Seydou Traore	22.9
15	Bauer Sharp	21.1
16	Riley Nowakowski	21.0
17	Josh Cuevas	20.6
DART THROW		
18	Jack Endries	14.3
19	Jaren Kanak	13.6
20	John Michael Gyllenborg	10.5
21	Dallen Bentley	10.1
22	Carsen Ryan	7.2
23	RJ Maryland	7.1
24	Michael Trigg	7.0
25	Dae'Quan Wright	6.9

ZAP Conversion Chart

Understanding the Table

The previous iteration of the ZAP Model leaned more into percentiles. With ZAP 2.0, the scoring scale has changed to better highlight the talent gaps between players, as you read about earlier.

You can use this table to convert old ZAP scores to new ones. It's not a perfect translation — think of it as a range — but it should give you a solid idea of where a player would land under the new system.

For example, if a running back scored a 91 in the old ZAP Model, that would translate to somewhere between 66 and 77 in ZAP 2.0, leaning closer to 66.

Comparing across classes isn't usually necessary — we have NFL data to work with outside of this class, so we'd want to lean on that — but for transparency (and curiosity), this gives you a way to do it.

	ZAP 2.0		
ZAP 1.0	WR	RB	TE
100	100	100	100
95	82	77	80
90	72	66	68
85	64	59	57
80	56	47	49
75	49	40	45
70	41	37	38
65	35	34	33
60	31	30	29
55	28	27	25
50	26	24	20